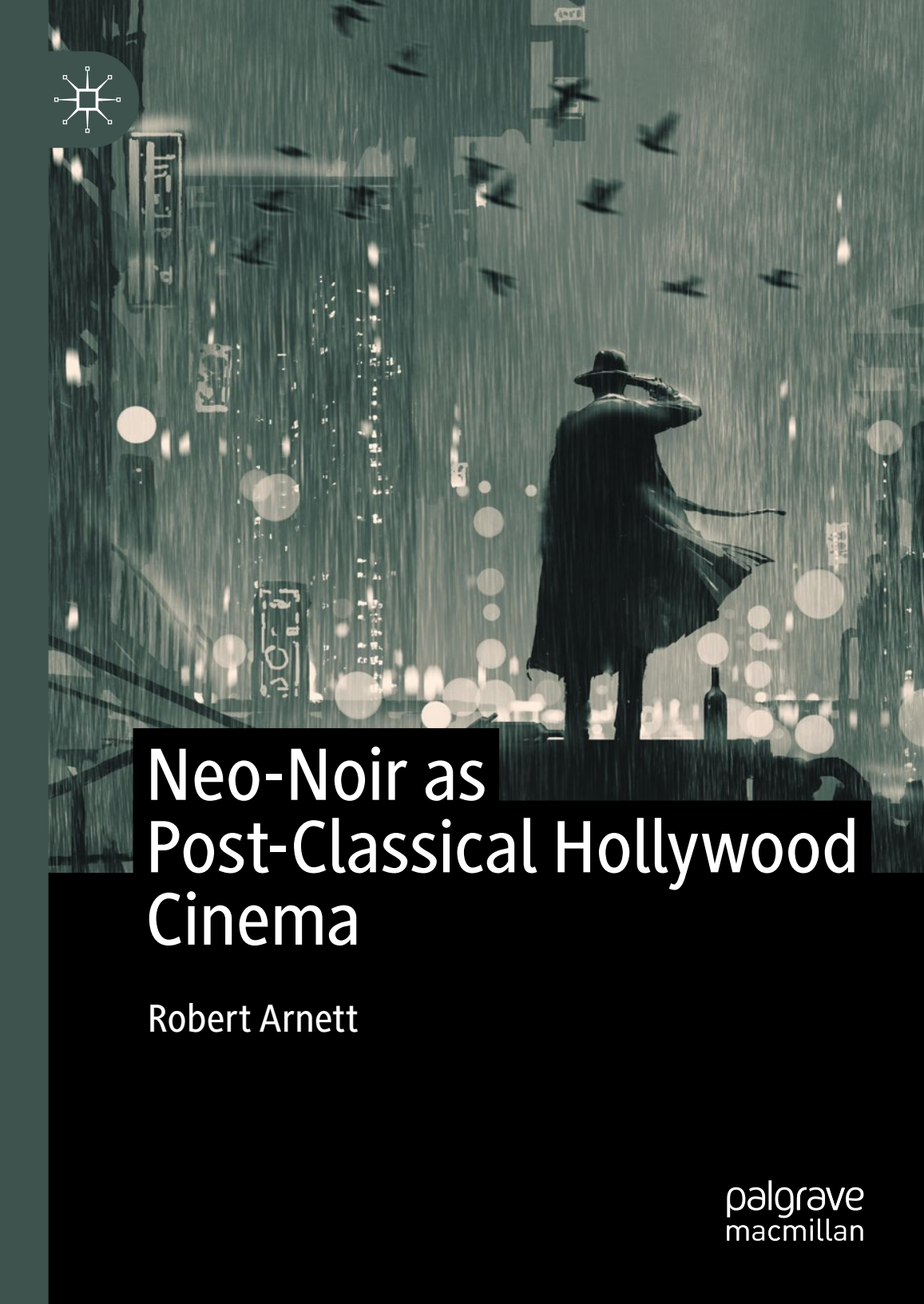




Neo-Noir as Post-Classical Hollywood Cinema

Robert Arnett

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Robert Arnett
Old Dominion University
Norfolk, VA, USA

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To paraphrase another writer: though the byline is mine, I did not write this book alone. I dedicate this book to the kind people who gave their time and insight to its preparation. Most of all I thank my wife, Jane, who sat through multiple viewings of many of the films with me, kept me sane, kept me on-task, and most importantly listened patiently.

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CHAPTER 1

Introduction

The term neo-noir, representing a concept that binds together a group of films, has become diffused and simplified to the point of uselessness. Neo-noir developed an amorphous quality wherein it seems any film or television show featuring any combination of a detective, a crime, a handgun, a hat, and some moody lighting qualified as noir. *Raiders of the Lost Ark* (1981) (Abrams 2009, 12)? *Die Hard* (1988) (Bould 2005, 93)? If we attach “noir” to every genre, eventually it becomes pointless for both the subject genre, which could contain its own darker variations, and for noir as modifier. Much of the problem stems from using the term neo-noir as a vehicle for other critical concerns, such as international cinemas, issues of representation, other genres, marketing, and audience, all viable and worthy topics, but more concerned with the advancement of their non-noir topic than with an understanding of neo-noir. As Mark Bould points out, what qualifies as neo-noir became “fuzzier,” prompting the question, can one “talk about any film as noir if it is illuminating to do so, regardless of what one might consider its dominant generic tendency?” (92). In other words, neo-noir takes a backseat to another research agenda. Consequently, noir criticism lost sight of the purpose of neo-noir, and neo-noir as a concept became generalized, amorphous, and, ultimately, misunderstood.

How neo-noir became something “fuzzy” began during the transition from the classic noir period to the neo-noir period. Alain Silver and Elizabeth Ward, in their sweeping reference work, *Film Noir: An Encyclopedic Reference to the American Style* (1979), suggest, “Whatever

the reasons, it could be said that the cycle of noir films never did conclude, as such, but rather diminished gradually ... The few productions in the 1960s and 1970s from *Manchurian Candidate* [1962] to *Hustle* [1975] are not so much a part of that cycle as individual attempts to resurrect the noir sensibility” (6). Foster Hirsch, author of a preeminent work in neo-noir, *Detours and Lost Highways: A Map of Neo-Noir* (1999), notes neo-noir is “so widely dispersed that it can no longer claim an essence of its own, as a dilution of a historically grounded style, or as a figment of the imagination of journalists and scholars who have wished it into being” (5). Hirsch does contend that neo-noir exists and that it continues “themes and the look formulated in classic noir” (13). He also suggests neo-noir may “branch off into fertile or misguided new terrain,” but he also sees a “long neo period” (13). Bould et al. (2009) expand Andrew Spicer’s (2002) general notion of neo-noir breaking into two “cycles” (Bould et al. 2009, 4). The first cycle runs from the mid-1960s to the mid-1970s. For Spicer, 1967 to 1976 constituted a period “when film noir was resurrected as a part of the ‘Hollywood Renaissance’” and was kicked off by *Point Blank* (John Boorman 1967) (130). The second cycle “was inaugurated in the early 1980s by the success of *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (Bob Rafelson 1981) and *Body Heat* (Lawrence Kasdan 1981) [and] has never really ended” (4). Spicer calls *Body Heat* “the moment when this contemporary sense of film noir was first acknowledged and which inaugurated the current revival” (130). That is, then, one 10-year cycle and one bloated 45-year cycle. Neo-noir has been around for almost 60 years (classic noir lasted about 15–20 years), and accepting that neo-noir continued the same themes and look of classic noir no longer seems reasonable. Nor should we buy into two cycles—the second of which has not changed since *Body Heat*? Can a noir film of 2020 really be all that “neo?” The answer is, oddly, yes, and the most interesting aspect is finding the “neo” in the films we suspect as neo-noir.

This book seeks to clarify the fuzziness and reclaim the idea of neo-noir. Further, it intends to disrupt common notions about what constitutes neo-noir in the post-classical Hollywood cinema, the Hollywood cinema that evolved from the classic Hollywood cinema and transformed into something entirely different, something still evolving today. Diffusion and simplification blurred the idea that neo-noir operates as a movement of films with a distinct purpose—contributing to a tradition of commenting on and reflecting the darker discourse of the social and cultural context in which the films were created. To reclaim the concept of neo-noir, I

suggest an idea that runs counter to much noir criticism. Neo-noir critics like to refute the claim that noir ended in 1958 with Orson Welles' *Touch of Evil*. Raymond Durgnat in 1970, for example, claimed noir as "perennial" (Naremore 1995–1996, 31).¹ In 1974, Richard Jameson concluded, "*film noir* is still possible, and has no apologies to make to anybody" (205). Hirsch claimed, "noir remains a quantifiably distinct commodity" (13). Yet, some of the first noir criticisms, especially Paul Schrader's seminal 1972 "Notes on *Film Noir*," see classic film noir as "a specific period of film history, like German Expressionism or the French New Wave [and] refers to those Hollywood films of the Forties and early Fifties which portrayed the world of dark, slick streets, crime and corruption" (54). And by designating a specific time period, Schrader asserts, classic film noir ended. In the "Film Noir" episode of *American Cinema* (1995), Schrader referred to classic noir as a "historical movement" that ended. Hirsch cites Schrader and cinematographer Michael Chapman at a panel in 1997:

Paul Schrader claimed that noir was "a movement, and therefore restricted in time and place, like neorealism or the New Wave" and that the concept of neo-noir was therefore a mirage. Concurring in the "impossibility" of noir post-1958, [Michael Chapman] defined noir as "the answer to a historical situation which doesn't exist anymore. The techniques used in noir are still available and used all the time—but the soul isn't there". (1)

Hirsch refutes Schrader and Chapman and asserts that neo-noir does exist and noir (classic and neo) is a genre (4). But I contend Schrader and Chapman are correct: classic noir ended and neo-noir is a mirage. Seeing neo-noir as a mirage helps clarify our understanding of neo-noir, because in accepting that classic noir ended establishes a historical marker and accepting neo-noir's status as a mirage establishes its illusory, oneiric nature, a key feature of neo-noir. Bould was on to something with the concept of two cycles of neo-noir, but failed to fully develop the idea. Take for example his first cycle, running from the mid-1960s with *Seconds* (John Frankenheimer 1966), *Bonnie and Clyde* (Arthur Penn 1967), and *Point Blank* to the mid-1970s with *Chinatown* (Roman Polanski 1974) and *Taxi Driver* (Martin Scorsese 1976). Then he claims a new cycle started in 1981 with *The Postman Always Rings Twice* and *Body Heat*. Similarly, Andrew Spicer (2010) suggests a "neo-modernist phase of film noir" began with *Point Blank*; included the neo-noir work of the Hollywood Renaissance directors like Altman, Polanski, Penn, and Scorsese, along

with a “separate development” of “noir crime thriller” Blaxploitation films; and ended in 1980 (xlv). Again, in 1981 *Body Heat* and *The Postman Always Rings Twice* remake signal, for Spicer, a “new phase of neo-noir in which noir conventions were embraced rather than criticized” (xlv). Spicer makes no indication that phase two ever ended. The detail missing is that like classic noir, and the first cycle, or Spicer’s first phase, the second cycle or phase also ended. The context, to use Naremore’s word, ended. A new context arose and a new cycle began. But, again, at some point that second cycle ended. In fact, as we will delve into later, Bould and Spicer miss the “cycles” to which *The Postman Always Rings Twice* and *Body Heat* belong, because the evidence suggests more than just one cycle/phase/movement possible in the late 1970s. Many, many cycles, in other words, constitute neo-noir, including time-specific ones that begin and end and ones bound together by thematic qualities. I suggest that neo-noir cycles end, just as classic noir began and ended. The context, for example, that allowed for a 1980s noir did not exist prior to that time and no longer exists. To claim that a single cycle/phase may account for all the issues or context of neo-noir from 1980 to the current moment is too simplistic to accept. The fragmentation of neo-noir is symptomatic of a larger story of Hollywood film history after the demise of the classical studio system, and that is why the notion of post-classical Hollywood cinema becomes crucial to understanding neo-noir.

A post-classical approach, or in Peter Kramer’s (2000) words, post-classicism, provides the critical perspective necessary to make our way through the mirage of neo-noir. It also provides a model for how to situate neo-noir into historical contexts and differentiate cohesive groups of films within the larger concept of neo-noir. The post-classical perspective sees an ever-speeding fragmentation and excessiveness following the classical, so neo-noir becomes a group of fragments, which negates the idea of a singular, or stable, neo-noir tradition, because neo-noir never coalesced as a unified voice, nor, in Hirsch’s words, did it find its essence, nor did it find a consistent social or cultural context against which it could rail. Instead, neo-noir came to be dominated by the post-classical Hollywood cinema of fragmentation and excessiveness.

Classic film noir, like the classical Hollywood cinema laid out by Bordwell, Staiger, and Thompson in their seminal *The Classical Hollywood Cinema: Film Style and Mode of Production to 1960* (1985), held common ideas about narrative, film style, and purpose for a group of films similar in tone, mood, and historical context. The mode of production in the 1940s

and 1950s contained an idea of film noir, first enunciated by French critics and later elaborated by American critics. Film noir began as a critical concept, not, as with traditional genres, a mode of production. Consequently, film noir never achieved a complete articulation, nor was consensus of definition ever achieved. As many noir critics, such as Naremore and Hirsch, point out, none of the production people who worked in classic film noir were ever aware that they were making film noir. But what this group of films did create, in Cowie's (1993) words, was a "fantasy," upon which critics could hang a term, "film noir" (121). This is a profound notion on multiple levels: a variation on Schrader's contention that noir-like films after classic noir are a "mirage," Spicer's inclination to add "noir" to many other genres, and, as we will cover in detail shortly, Raymond Borde and Etienne Chaumeton's (1955) oneiric state in film noir. The classical period ended, and films bearing a similar purpose to the classical, but aimed at the current moment, then appeared. For film noir, its classic period ended, but the mirage of what film noir could be continued.

As Kramer points out, at a basic level, the post-classical marks "the end of the classical period in American film history," the era dominated by the Hollywood studio system (late 1910s to the 1960s), and "despite overriding stylistic and institutional continuities, Hollywood has undergone a set of fundamental changes which deserve critical attention" (63). Kramer and other critics rely on Bordwell, Staiger, and Thompson's *Classical Hollywood* to identify the classical and register its institutionalized hegemony, specifically the "homogeneity and stability of classical Hollywood" (Kramer 63). Barry Langford (2010) suggests the beginnings of a post-classical Hollywood can be found in 1945, with the industry's adapting to a post-World War II environment. Thomas Schatz (1993) contends the mid-1960s marked the end of a "phase" and that by 1975 and the release of *Jaws*, a "New Hollywood" began (10). 1960 becomes a convenient signpost as many film historians, like Bordwell, Staiger, and Thompson, agree the once dominant Hollywood studio system transitioned into another form during the 1960s. Whereas an oligopoly developed and maintained a style of filmmaking—the classical—during the 1960s other modes of production and reception became economically and aesthetically viable (e.g., the made-for-television movie, the multiplex, art house cinemas, four-wall releases), thereby fragmenting the once hegemonic classical style into multi-faceted modes and means of production. Fragmentation and destabilization dominated the 1970s, but that era also ends. The 1980s saw new modes of production competing with 1970s modes, some

rising and some falling away (e.g., the Hollywood Renaissance of serious young directors giving way to the New Hollywood of blockbusters). The stability of genre, as it influenced production and reception, fragmented during the 1960s and 1970s. In film theory, the a priori reasoning of structuralism gave way to the destabilizing notions of poststructuralism. The 1960s and 1970s destabilized genres like the western, the musical, and the war film. Neo-noir (genre? movement? mirage?) added more fragments to the notion of post-classical Hollywood cinema.

Kramer suggests asking “What are the most important stylistic and thematic innovations introduced during the post-classical period?” (63). The emphasis needs to be on the plural, that innovations form the fragments of the post-classical and the excessiveness warns of the quantity. Catherine Constable (2015) offers significant clarification: seeing the post-classical as “Fragmented/open ended/intertextual” (36). The films coalesce into movements, and the movements form a mosaic, a mosaic held together by intertextuality. Westerns, musicals, war films, and noir of the 1970s differ dramatically from westerns, musicals, war films, and noir of the 1990s and 2000s. The act of identifying those differences becomes work of post-classical intertextual discourse. The post-classical acknowledges the inevitability of change in cultural norms and their relationship to Hollywood films. Times change quickly and the Hollywood cinema, working with many more modes of production, reacts, reflects, and recognizes those changes. Further, stylistic innovations may rise to dominance, then recede or become part of the norm. Groups of neo-noir films, then, could de-emphasize the time frame in favor of an overwhelming stylistic commonality. These films grouped in stylistic similarity offer a discourse with the darker elements, but also enact Constable’s idea of an intertextuality, in that these stylistic groupings emphasize other levels of filmic connection. Neo-noirs that recreate the past, specifically the era of classic film noir, engage in an intertextual discourse. *Farewell, My Lovely* (Dick Richards 1975), for example, becomes a post-classical epic of intertextual discourse, an R-rated adaptation of Raymond Chandler’s novel, starring an older Robert Mitchum, a star of many classic film noirs, and it remakes *Murder, My Sweet* (Edward Dmytryk 1944).

A post-classical approach should guide neo-noir criticism. First, the challenge marked by Constable: the post-classical offers “the possibility of more complex modes of spectatorship” (25). We should acknowledge the fragmentation and return to the films with a new, open perspective. Changes in industry and business dominate most film study labeled as

post-classical (e.g., Langford, Dixon), with little devoted to aesthetics (e.g., Elsaesser on Coppola's *Dracula* and Knapp on Tony Scott's *Domino*), which necessitates focusing a keen eye on shifting aesthetic values, changing cultural contexts, and new modes of production as criteria for isolating groups of films, the fragments, within the increasingly excessive post-classical body of neo-noir films. Though Bordwell (2006) and Thompson (1999) have gone on to deny the post-classical (in favor of a persisting classical mode), they did suggest in *Classical Hollywood*, "It is now pertinent to consider to what extent the Hollywood mode of production and the classical style have changed" (Bordwell et al. 1985, 608). As Kramer points out, post-classicism focuses on the "increased speed and intensity of stylistic change" (81). Neo-noir can be the vehicle for exploring the changes and fragmentation within the evolving post-classical Hollywood, and post-classicism provides a method for organizing, deciphering, and, finally, understanding neo-noir since the 1960s.

To understand neo-noir means clarifying the elements that constitute a noir film and that means returning to the problem that kicked off this introduction—the amorphous, and useless, quality of the contemporary concept of neo-noir. The intention here is not to put forth the ultimate definition of noir, but to isolate the elements one finds in most noir films and then apply those concepts to neo-noir films. Hirsch and Steve Neale (2000) point out that noir from the 1960s to the present has "updated itself, speaking from and to contemporary concerns" (Hirsch 1999, 7). For Naremore, film noir "because its meaning changes over time, it ought to be examined as a discursive construct" (6). These claims reiterate the central tenet of Borde and Chaumeton's chapter, "Towards a Definition of *Film Noir*," in *Panorama of American Film Noir*, "[Film Noir] responds to a certain kind of emotional resonance as singular in time as it is in space. It's on the basis of a response to possibly ephemeral reactions that the roots of the 'style' must be sought" (5). In 1976, "neo-noir" had yet to become the dominant term, Larry Gross offered a similar contention with his term, *film après noir*. Gross asserts, "The adoption of the *film noir* conventions is as much an indictment of society as it is an act of nostalgia for a glorious cinematic past. It is a way of saying that contemporary life is too ambiguous for the conventions available to commercial filmmaking, and that the only way to solve the problem is to emphasize these conventions for the purposes of demonstrating their inevitable dissolution" (44). Gross, like Borde and Chaumeton, recognizes noir's focus on engaging the contemporary world or "new city." But Borde and Chaumeton's

definition is, as Naremore points out, problematic, as is much of the foundational writing. Naremore notes Borde and Chaumeton's writings on noir contain elements of haziness, such as being "unclear" (19), Andre Bazin's offers "ambiguity" (26), and Paul Schrader's "Notes on *Film Noir*" defines noir by "tone" and "mood" (53). The problem with generic definition resides in its a priori reasoning—wanting to divine noir in the cinematic mist with some noir-detecting device. As Cowie pointed out, only the term, film noir, succeeded. We have to accept a degree of haziness (the mirage), because no universally accepted definition of film noir or neo-noir exists. Recognizing noir in the contemporary moment will be difficult as we attempt to operationalize a meta-idea based on loosely defined filmic concepts. For example, noir criticism accepts the idea of the classic noir filmmakers not knowing the term, *film noir*, while they created their films. The neo-noir filmmakers work with various degrees of understanding their predecessors and historical context, but they may be unaware of the current moment in which they work (e.g., they know film noir, but do not realize their own membership in a contemporary group). What remains hazy is a level of historical context and realization. Noir criticism should proceed by looking back for a response to a "particular time and place." Again, the speed and intensity of change negates a single linear story, or one or two cycles, and encourages a multi-faceted mosaic of movement fragments (groups of films), some coexisting, some certain to end as others emerge, and some tied together by more transformative thematic qualities. To work our way through the mosaic, we need constants—elements of noir that the various movements of neo-noir possess.

Borde and Chaumeton provide not only an early clarification of film noir, but a series of elements to guide our detection of noir within the films that form the fragments of the post-classical conception of neo-noir. Let's call these the basic elements of noir. Borde and Chaumeton articulated these elements in the mid-1950s, well before the advent of a neo-noir. Their elements, therefore, come tailored not for neo-noir, but for the larger principle of *film noir*. If the definition of neo-noir has become so amorphous as to be useless as a concept, then we need to stake out some conceptual criteria. We return to Borde and Chaumeton's central idea that *film noir* has a purpose: "The vocation of film noir has been to create a specific sense of malaise" (13). Using the basic elements forces us to discern noir in the age of the fragmented, so they act as a heuristic device, guiding the organization of film movements around specific senses of malaise. And, of course, the basic elements may instigate argument over films

not qualifying as neo-noir, and examples of this will occur in the upcoming chapters. Significance resides in the discourse of noir—does this film belong? If yes, where? Is it like other noir of its time? Does it have more in common with other films dealing similar thematic motifs? At this point, establishing criteria by which to gauge films fulfilling the purpose of noir becomes the primary necessity of the basic elements.

In understanding that film noir (or, more simply, noir) works within neo-noir, means accepting that a noir film has a purpose, the first basic element, and that purpose is exploring the darker elements of the culture and society in which it was produced. What Borde and Chaumeton articulated was a group of films responding to the contemporary moment and that idea has been lost in the thinking about neo-noir. Groups of films are going to come together because they respond to a certain moment—they engage with it, argue about it, and provide alternative takes—and then that moment ends and another begins. Maybe, the filmmakers move on to the next moment, but, often, they do not, because they lose something and fail to engage the next movement of neo-noir. As we will see, a group of disparate filmmakers coalesce in the 1980s to respond to the era of Ronald Reagan with a group of visually distinct noir films. Nothing screams the 1980s more than the image of Don Johnson and Philip Michael Thomas decked out in pastel tones, leaning against an expensive sports car under a palm tree at magic hour. But that look fades, as the Reagan era faded, to be replaced by new style, and social context would, and new filmmakers. Among the filmmakers, Michael Mann could move in neo-noir, but William Friedkin could not. Similarly, the society and culture that produced *Pulp Fiction* (Quentin Tarantino 1994) and *The Usual Suspects* (Bryan Singer 1995) in the 1990s is not the society and culture that produced *Man on Fire* (Tony Scott) in 2004 or *I Am the Night* for television in 2019. Seeing these films as a part of one “cycle” strains credulity. In some cases, the films respond to a singular “space,” in that they respond to a common theme. In neo-noir, the possibilities of thematic space keep expanding. With neo-noir a retro, or nostalgic, space appears, something not possible during the classic era. Other thematic neo-noir spaces include a focus on the femme fatale (e.g., Lindop 2015; Farrimond 2018) and technology (Auger 2011), among many other possibilities.

The next element derived from Borde and Chaumeton is the presence of an ambivalent hero, typically male, but in the post-classical neo-noir era, the hero need not be defined by gender. Understanding the noir hero

as ambivalent provides a major cause for the deterioration of the concept of neo-noir. Most often, this issue arises in the false equivalence of the private eye and the police detective equaling the noir hero. They're not the same—they can be, but just because the hero is a private eye does not make him/her a noir hero. Typically, the private eye who is not a noir hero lacks the ambivalence needed for the noir decision. Consider the rash of detective films, usually titled by the detective's name, that came out in the 1960s and early 1970s, such as *Harper* (1966) and its two sequels, *Tony Rome* (1967) and its sequel, *Marlowe* (1969), *Chandler* (1971), *Shaft* (1971) and its sequels, and a long list of television private eyes of the same time (e.g., *Mannix*, *McCloud*, *Cannon*, and *Shaft* became a TV private eye [1973–1974]). These private eyes never doubted what they were doing, always possessed a clear vision, and returned to the status quo at the end. They may have faced obstacles on the way finding out “whodunit,” but their character never descended into ambivalence. Often the hero makes a “noir decision,” a conscience decision to act, knowing full well they will cross a line, giving in to their baser instincts or going to the darker side of the world they live in. In *Out of the Past* (1947), Jeff (Robert Mitchum) abandons his mission to bring back Kathy (Jane Greer) who ran off with Whit's (Kirk Douglas) money when he falls for her the first time he sees her. Jeff's voice over tells us, “I went to Pablo's that night. I knew I'd go every night until she showed up and I knew she knew it. [...] I knew where I was and what I was doing. I thought what a sucker I was.” The twisting plot of *Chinatown* propels Jake Gittes (Jack Nicholson) to Chinatown where, as in his past, helping a woman only insures that she will be hurt. In *Man on Fire*, Creasy (Denzel Washington) takes a job as a bodyguard with the intent of drinking himself to death, and when his suicide attempt fails, he becomes emotionally attached to the family's young daughter, knowing he shouldn't, and when her inevitable kidnapping occurs, Creasy, as his mentor (Christopher Walken) explains, “paints his masterpiece” of violence. Many private eyes and police detectives do achieve noir hero status, because their “noir decision” adds the necessary ambivalence to their character. In Borde and Chaumeton words, “he's often the masochistic type, his own executioner ... not so much through a concern for justice or cupidity as through a sort of morbid curiosity. Sometimes he's a passive hero who is willingly taken to the frontier between lawlessness and crime” (9). One of the ways in which neo-noir films engage the current moment is through what makes the hero ambivalent in the particular social context. For example, the original *Miami Vice*

TV show offers a dramatically different meaning to going undercover than its 2006 remake. The 1980s version goes undercover through conspicuous consumption and the 2006 version goes undercover to penetrate digital networks.

Next, the element of violence. More accurately, violence takes a particular form of cruelty, particular because the violence often represents the time period or thematic style of the neo-noir moment. As Borde and Chaumeton claimed in 1955, “An unprecedented panoply of cruelties and sufferings unfolds in film noir.” In isolating neo-noir movements, violence, as a theme, becomes helpful as method for understanding the engagement and resonances within a singular moment. The violence may be symptomatic of the “malaise” Borde and Chaumeton identify as part of the singular time. We will find a recurring attraction to violence inflicted upon faces, most often to women and often to the eyes (poor Evelyn Mulwray!).

The next element, an oneiric state, encourages multiple levels of analysis. Borde and Chaumeton noted that “A number of titles could readily be found in which the action is deliberately situated at the level of the dream” (11). Even though a film could be a “dream” for a central character, the oneiric state/dream quality is not limited to the narrative world. Borde and Chaumeton suggest, “One gets the feeling that all the components of noir style lead to the same result: to disorient the spectators, who no longer encounter their customary frames of reference” (12). Consider the dream possibilities as a spectrum. At one end, the dream is explicit, we clearly understand usually through voice-over narration that we are within the point of view of the character. Bordwell calls this referential and explicit meaning, in that the film unquestionably contains the elements (e.g., the settings, the voice-over narration, etc.). At the other end of the spectrum, the oneiric state is more abstract. Again, according to Bordwell, “the perceiver may also construct *repressed* or *symptomatic* meanings that the work divulges ‘involuntarily’” (9). In other words, the dream quality of the film moves further away from narrative representation, sometimes into the very act of watching the film. Take, for example, the progression of David Lynch’s neo-noir films. With *Blue Velvet* (1986), the dreamer/noir hero is readily apparent in the form of Jeffrey (Kyle MacLachlan), the young noir hero. Lynch limits the viewer to Jeffrey’s point of view for most of the film and the references to dreams within the film are clearly stated. In *Lost Highway* (1997) and *Mulholland Dr.* (2001), the narratives become more

abstract, and the viewer may be unsure of the dreamer, but the dreamers are in the films and we know the dreams belong to them. But with *Inland Empire* (2006) all Lynch offers are the dreams with no indication of the dreamers and the concept of narrative all but eliminated. The dream-like quality of Lynch's films begins with referential and explicit meaning and moves to repressed and symptomatic, wherein the film itself becomes the dream.

The earlier contention of haziness in discerning neo-noir provides another way of seeing the oneiric state within neo-noir films. Schrader's "tone and mood" of noir and Bazin's "ambiguity" contain the possibility of oneiricism. The singular time with which the neo-noir film engages may include aspiration as a dream, or in Schrader's words a "mirage." For example, in the 1980s, Reagan offered a new "morning" in America. These films bear the tone and mood—mirage?—of the 1980s. The neo-noirs of the Hollywood Renaissance in the 1970s engage a movie-based dream as many of the filmmakers, many of them former film students, attempt to recreate or redefine genres of classic Hollywood. The element of an oneiric quality provides another tool in understanding a neo-noir's resonance with its singular time or thematic motif.

Turning the dreams, ambivalence, violence, and singular time into images necessitates an element of visual style. Too often the distinct visual style of the classic noir is seen as the only style of noir. As with other elements of noir, the style also ended with the movement. This is not to say the filmmakers stopped using the classic noir style; rather, it creates the idea that when neo-noir movements form, even if temporarily, they contain a distinct visual style. The visual style of the 1980s noir is particularly distinct. The visual style of the neo-noir films of the 2000s reflects their digital age. So too are the visual styles of other time movements and thematic groups. For example, neo-noir made possible Nostalgia Noir—a neo-noir movement visually recreating the era of classic noir, or an earlier era of neo-noir. Nostalgia Noirs, like *Chinatown* (1974) and *L.A. Confidential* (1997), share this element of recreation and they have more in common with each other than they do with other films of their times. The visual style of a movement is determined by the films' shared focus on engaging their moment. Borde and Chaumeton do not articulate a specific visual code for film noir, but they do isolate groups of noir film by, in part, their visual style. Much has been made of classic noir's borrowing of German Expressionism and the language of light and shadows, as Janey Place and Lowell Peterson (1976) do in their seminal essay "Some Visual Motifs of

Film Noir.” The movements of neo-noir across the arc of post-classical Hollywood cinema each contain distinct visual motifs. It becomes our job, as critics, to organize and articulate how a visual style works within a neo-noir movement.

The final element, the femme fatale/homme fatale character, raises a quirky aspect to the basic elements. A film absent femme fatale character (e.g., Andre De Toth’s *Pitfall* [1948] and *Crime Wave* [1953] or Michael Mann’s *Collateral* [2004] and Tony Scott’s *Man on Fire* [2006]) need not be disqualified as noir. In some cases, a movement’s distinctiveness may be determined by its femme fatale/homme fatale character. Those movements seeking to evoke classic noir invariably rely upon the presence of the femme fatale (e.g., *Chinatown*, *Body Heat*, *Blade Runner* [1982]). But other movements may prove distinct because of the absence of the femme fatale. Or, the femme fatale/homme fatale may be elevated to noir hero, as is the case in the Erotic Noir Thrillers of the 1980s (Williams 2005; Martin 2007). The femme fatale/homme fatale character rises to basic element of noir because she/he needs to be identified and made relevant to the specific case, or the absence of the femme fatale should be given purpose, even if she has been replaced by a homme fatale. Hence, the quirky nature of this element: identification with the possibility of absence necessitates articulating the meaning of that absence.

To summarize:

The basic elements of noir

1. Response to a singular time or space
2. The ambivalent hero
3. Oneiric/dream state
4. Violence theme
5. Visual style
6. Femme fatale

Again, this is not meant as the definitive criteria for film noir. Rather, the list provides a criterion meant to help guide a discussion of neo-noir films and the meanings they may contain, especially as they reflect the post-classical Hollywood cinema. Simultaneously, I want to be explicit about how a film is judged as neo-noir and not just assume its status as noir. I see neo-noir as metaphorical, representing a larger picture of post-classical Hollywood cinema—meaning hidden within the fragmented and excessive history of Hollywood cinema after the classical studio era. We cannot

cover every aspect or topic, so the choices made, the topics of individual chapters, will hopefully reveal the potential of the larger picture of neo-noir.

The chapters coalesce into two types. Being time-specific defines the first group and places emphasis on the first basic element of reflecting the singular time. Similar thematic or stylistic motifs define the second group and de-emphasize the singular time to find a more dominant trait bringing together the group of films. Being noir, these responses, whether time-specific or thematic, detail a multi-layered evolution of neo-noir as films exploring the dark side of the culture which produced them.

Each time-specific chapter marks a beginning and an end of a movement and argues for how these films form a “response” to their particular cultural context through their processing of the narrative style, which typically involves engaging the other basic elements that then articulate a unique “tone and mood.” Since many films make up each group, each chapter examines two or three films as representative examples. Chapter 2 begins with Transitional Noir, occurring from the mid-1960s to the early 1970s. The unique trait of this movement is its coexistence with the last films of classic noir, which adds the necessity of separating classic noir from the overlapping post-classical. Don Siegel’s *The Killers* (1964) and John Boorman’s *Point Blank*, both starring Lee Marvin, a pivotal figure of this movement, serve as the examples of Transitional Noir. These films engage the basic elements to form a response unique to this period and in this case unique to its position to classic noir. Transitional Noir often calls reality into question—sometimes suggesting the questionable existence of characters or questioning the very world they live in. The chapter, like the following chapters, ends with a list of films that define this movement.

The next, Chap. 3, examines neo-noir of the Hollywood Renaissance (1969–1979). A group of directors who redefined Hollywood make this movement distinct. They are a different group than those of the Transitional Noir, and while many of them will make films for many years to come, these noir efforts are unique to the 1970s. Many of the directors, like Martin Scorsese, Terrence Malick, or Robert Altman, dabbled in noir as they moved through, and destabilized, multiple genres. These directors looked into the dark side of cinema, as many of them were film students or had worked their way up through television. Their reaction to the 1970s intermingles with their reaction to noir cinema, forming their neo-noir movement. Walter Hill’s *The Driver* (1978) offers one approach by

recreating noir within the 1970s. Robert Altman's *The Long Goodbye* (1973) redefines noir by overtly manipulating genre tropes to fit the 1970s.

Chapter 4 argues for an Eighties Noir. The pastel color palette makes these films visually distinct. Steven Sanders (2009) called it "Sunshine Noir." But these films come from a much different culture than the 1970s. The 1980s are distinct because of Ronald Reagan's presidency. These neo-noir films demonstrate a reaction to President Reagan's vision of America, calling into question the status quo of the political climate. The core films representing the period include Michael Mann's *Manhunter* (1986) William Friedkin's *To Live and Die in L.A.* (1985), and David Lynch's *Blue Velvet* (1986).

Nineties Noir, Chap. 5, evolves from the inevitable end of the 1980s and finds its own dynamic response to a new socio-political era and technology boom. Nineties Noir develops its own look, a return to the dark, and forms a socio-cultural response to the end of the century. Something temporary also creeps in to the neo-noir of the 1990s, as if it were aware of its own imminent passing. Michael Mann's *Heat* (1995) and Quentin Tarantino's *Jackie Brown* (1997) provide the samples to explore this movement. By referencing another film by Mann, we see one director adapting to the changing times with an evolving concern with the depiction of urban spaces and how these films foresee a loss of identity.

Chapter 6, Digital Noir, covers the neo-noir films in the twenty-first century. The idea of "digital" pervades not only the look of these films but also their thematic response to the time. These films focus on male heroes lost on the digital grid, unsure of time and place. Their noir "adventure" focuses on the dark implications of the digital world. Watching the films of this movement forces the viewer into new positions of negotiating film viewing. Tony Scott's *Man on Fire* (2004) follows a hero into his last battle with the digital world. In Chad Stahelski's *John Wick* (2014), the hero re-enters a network of crime from which he had retired. Wick was once seen as a master of the network, not only with fighting skills but also with superior ability to negotiate network communication, professional exchange, and monetary systems. He never assumes a false identity, but must repeatedly establish the proof of his legendary identity. In both films, as in all Digital Noirs, the heroes come to question the validity of their identity in a new, digital world.

The second set of chapters concerns groups of neo-noir films made distinct by a strong thematic or stylistic quality that register the films as a cohesive group. First, Chap. 7, a group of neo-noir films come together in

their emphasis on nostalgia. Since no classic noir films ever portrayed a time period other than the time in which they were produced, Nostalgia Noir carries extra post-classical weight. Nostalgia Noir recreates a preceding movement, most commonly classic noir. Roman Polanski's *Chinatown* single-handedly created and dominates this group. In it we see a film set in 1937, but focused on the time of its release. Similarly, Curtis Hanson's adaptation of James Ellroy's *L.A. Confidential* (1997) recreates the 1950s, but in a way that responds to the 1990s. Shane Black's *The Nice Guys* (2016), however, represents a growing number of neo-noir interested in the 1970s—a first wave of Nostalgia Noir recreating an earlier movement of neo-noir.

Chapter 8 explores how neo-noir operates within genre hybridity. Hybrid Noir activates noir elements in another genre. Film noir often darkens another genre, like science fiction, with Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) or the superhero genre, as with the Netflix version of *Jessica Jones* (2015–2019) created by Melissa Rosenberg. Noir takes advantage of the hybrid remix to respond to the particular moment as sci-fi and superheroes provide a guiding metaphor not often found in neo-noir. To explore the darker side of the Jessica Jones story in the modern world, Rosenberg relied, as did the writers and artists of the graphic novels, on film noir. Similarly, in the early 1980s, Ridley Scott turned to noir to explore the darker implications of the sci-fi genre, which had become overly fixed upon the construction of utopias. With genre hybridity filmmakers bring the dream of noir to the foreground while working with another genre.

The last thematic chapter, Chap. 9, focuses on a different kind of dream construction—Remakes and Homage. Again, the basic elements activate a response to the current moment with these films, but, simultaneously, we are aware of their meta-qualities as recreation. Remakes do not always recreate the time period, as Nostalgia Noir does; they may reconstruct a previously experienced story within a contemporary setting. An Homage Noir reworks the basic elements of a previous film, or films, so thoroughly that the result seems like a remake, but, technically, is not. An Homage Noir may run under the radar of the popular audience, but the noir literate recognize the intertextual discussion instigated by the homage. As neo-noir in post-classical Hollywood, the remake or homage relies on the viewer's awareness and ability to participate in the intertextual discussion. Of the sample films, Dick Richards' *Farewell, My Lovely* (1975) reworks Raymond Chandler's novel of the same name, and it remakes Edward

Dmytryk's 1944 version titled *Murder, My Sweet*. Lawrence Kasdan's *Body Heat* (1981) pays homage to Billy Wilder's *Double Indemnity* (1944) and season one of *True Detective* (2014), created by Nic Pizzolatto, evokes the tropes of classic noir storytelling. These modern films demonstrate intertextual post-classical meta-discussions stemming from noir, but also analysis of their historical contexts reveals responses to their time and place.

The final chapter, the conclusion, summarizes the key benefits of analyzing noir as post-classical Hollywood cinema. The emphasis is on the benefit of adding to genre criticism a historical context that narrows the definition of what constitutes film noir and returns noir criticism to its central concept of being a part of the discourse concerning the darker aspects of a culture in which these films were produced. Also, the benefit of the post-classical context is summarized, as it is the key to understanding that neo-noir exists as a multi-layered evolution and not a singular response. Neo-noir movements in the post-classical, like its classical predecessor, end and new responses emerge. Many more fragments of neo-noir exist in the post-classical that did not make it into this project, such as two movements of Blaxploitation Noir in the 1970s and 1990s (also demanding clarification as to what Blaxploitation films qualify as neo-noir when all do not) and female-centered neo-noir in the 1980s and 1990s (Covey), and if we break outside of the realm of Hollywood cinema, we could consider international contributions, such as neo-noir in the Hong Kong action cinema pre-unification, multiple movements within the French cinema and the German cinema, Modern Japanese, remakes of foreign films by Hollywood, Television Noir, and acknowledging movements and clusters at this point in their incubatory stage.

NOTE

1. Naremore's *More Than Night: Film Noir in Its Contexts* contains the essential, thorough review of noir criticism.

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PART I

Time-Specific Movements



CHAPTER 2

Transitional Noir, 1960s–Early 1970s

Key Films

The Killers (1964), d. Don Siegel
Mickey One (1965), d. Arthur Penn
Seconds (1966), d. John Frankenheimer
Point Blank (1967), d. John Boorman
Bullitt (1968), d. Peter Yates
Targets (1968), d. Peter Bogdanovich

Into the mid-1960s, the final efforts of classic noir exist alongside the first efforts of neo-noir. Seeing the distinctly different films illuminates both groups. *The Naked Kiss* (Sam Fuller 1964) and *Mirage* (Edward Dmytryk 1965) work as late efforts of film noir, in black and white, rife with post-World War II anxiety and film noir visual style. But *Seconds* (John Frankenheimer 1966) and *Point Blank* (John Boorman 1967) signify new territory. *Point Blank* featured Lee Marvin, a character actor during the 1950s—in classic noir films, such as *The Big Heat* (Fritz Lang 1953)—now a major Hollywood movie star, in a mind-bending widescreen, color neo-noir heist revenge oddly reminiscent of *Hiroshima, Mon Amour* (Alain Resnais 1959) and *Last Year at Marienbad* (Alain Resnais 1961). *Seconds*, in black and white and photographed by the legendary James

Wong Howe, featured equally mind-bending 1960s compositions, an almost sci-fi plot, nudity and relied on a lens not previously used in feature films (Frankenheimer 1997). While *Seconds* and *Point Blank* demonstrate a new form of noir film, Transitional Noir did not spring fully formed from the ooze of the fading Hollywood system; rather it developed from early efforts by filmmakers, unaware of their similarities, working within a movement that would only be recognized well after their time had passed. In other words, they operated in a post-classical version of the story previously enacted by the filmmakers of classic film noir.

Transitional Noirs coalesce into a consistent group because of their efforts to observe the purpose of neo-noir *and* to be different than their classic predecessors. Therefore, Transitional Noirs work as symptomatic of the 1960s and thoroughly engage that volatile time. While the civil rights movement, the Vietnam War and its protest, and social protests raged, the Hollywood studio era faded to its ending. The major studios, finding themselves in new forms of corporate ownership, grasped for financial security from the perspective of what had worked in the past—blockbuster hits, especially musicals and historical epics. *Ben-Hur* (1959) and *The Sound of Music* (1964) established a deadly precedent that led to projects like *Cleopatra* (1964), *Doctor Doolittle* (1967), and *Star!* (1968) and “staggering losses” (Monaco 2001, 37). The hegemony of the classic Hollywood studio system waned but did not disappear in the 1960s. Other modes of film production, such as American International Pictures’ drive-in fare, import productions like the Beatles’ films and the James Bond franchise, and indie and art house cinema, found success and differentiation from Hollywood’s product. Into this gap films from new filmmakers, new modes of productions, and new visions of genres found success. According to British director John Boorman, “[The studios] were so confused and so uncertain as to what to do, they were quite willing to cede power to the directors [...] and there was this desire to import British or European directors who would somehow have the answers” (Biskind 1998, 22). Transitional Noir emerged from these new or different modes of production and in some cases came from the studios looking for “answers” in new directors. This chapter focuses most of the discussion on two films, *The Killers* (Don Siegel 1964) and *Point Blank*, both starring Lee Marvin, to demonstrate the emergence, and fading, of Transitional Noir. For a more complete list of Transitional Noir films, please see the list at the end of this chapter.

The Killers, less a remake of the 1946 classic film noir, reworks the premise of Hemingway's short story of the same name. In the 1964 version, the two hitmen of the opening, the older professional, Charlie (Lee Marvin), and younger, Lee (Clu Gulager), propel the story. Charlie finds it odd that Johnny North (John Cassavetes), a former race car driver, made no effort to defend himself when they arrived to assassinate him. Being overpaid for the job and the million dollars unaccounted for from a heist in which Johnny participated further arouse Charlie's suspicions. Their search reveals Johnny's story of being taken in by Sheila (Angie Dickinson), who sets up Johnny so she and the crime boss, Browning (Ronald Reagan), can make off with the million dollars. When Charlie and Lee get too close, Browning tries to kill them (shooting a sniper's rifle from a window), but only kills Lee and wounds Charlie. Charlie manages to catch Sheila and Browning at Browning's suburban home and kills them, but then dies in the front yard as the police arrive.

Point Blank is much more non-linear. The story concerns Walker (Lee Marvin), betrayed by his partner, Mal (John Vernon), and wife, Lynne (Sharon Acker), after they steal money from "the organization" at a transfer point in the abandoned Alcatraz penitentiary. Mal shoots Walker "point blank" and leaves him for dead on Alcatraz. Somehow, Walker survives. With the aid of Yost (Keenan Wynn), who seems to be some kind of agent, Walker pursues a revenge mission against his wife, who commits suicide upon his return, then Mal, and then demands his share of the money from the organization. The end reveals Yost as part of the organization and Yost's use of Walker to eliminate competing members of the organization. Yost offers the money and a job to Walker, but Walker fades away into the darkness and the camera reveals they are not at Alcatraz, but nearby. *The Killers* and *Point Blank* offer two different positions within Transition Noir, one at the very beginning of the movement and the other at a more advanced and complicated moment.

The basic elements of noir ((1) reflecting a singular time, (2) ambivalent hero, (3) violence theme, (4) oneiric state, (5) visual style, (6) femme fatale), applied to *The Killers* and *Point Blank*, provide a path through the ideas and issues within Transitional Noir. Because this movement possesses unique features among neo-noir, the discussion ranges into areas the other movements may not possess. For example, Lee Marvin so dominates Transitional Noir that the ambivalent hero discussion will emphasize one actor. Snipers appear prominently in these films, a singular reflection of the times. Also, this time period holds many detective movies (usually

titled by the detective's last name) often mislabeled as neo-noir, and the last of classic noirs exist in this time period. Therefore, more discussion focuses on the elements that qualify a film as neo-noir than will be found in later chapters.

Perhaps an oversimplification, but Transitional Noir by definition exhibits something "new." The earlier the effort, the more elemental the "new" aspect. For example, though Andrew Spicer (2002) claims, "the neo-noir revival began with John Boorman's *Point Blank* [...]. Its modernity consists in its extreme version of the oneirism that characterizes film noir" (136). But *Point Blank* is not the first neo-noir, nor did it activate a revival. Rather, it is the most sophisticated expression of Transitional Noir, and soon after its release the movement ended. *The Killers*, released in 1964, stands as one of the first neo-noir, and its new elements are much less sophisticated than those of *Point Blank*. First, *The Killers* is in color, so its visual elements are not of the black and white style of moody expressionism, as one finds in the last efforts of classic film noir. Also, *The Killers* began as one of Universal's initial made-for-television films, but deemed too violent for television upon completion, Universal gave it theatrical release (Siegel 259). Television, in its second decade, continued supplanting the role of B-movie production, and Lee Marvin, a character actor who had moved to star of his own television series (*M Squad* 1957–1960), could for the first time in his career be listed as the lead actor. And *The Killers* bears the presence of Ronald Reagan at the literal end of his acting career and the beginning of his political career. Don Siegel, while having directed many B-movies in the classic studio system, was by 1964 relegated to directing episodic television and sought a way back to feature films. *The Killers*, then, exists as an oddity—its place not understood in 1964 because its makers could not articulate the concept of neo-noir, much less Transitional Noir, and it features an odd mix of old Hollywood (e.g., Ronald Reagan, oft-used Universal sets, and familiar character actors like Claude Akins and Norman Fell) and talent in ascendance (e.g., Lee Marvin, John Cassavetes, Angie Dickinson, and Don Siegel). Its neo-noir qualities seem awkward and crude, not unlike its two hitmen.

Point Blank also found an irregular path to production. Three years after *The Killers*, Marvin, in the wake of the success of *Cat Ballou* (1965), *Ship of Fools* (1965), *The Professionals* (1966), and *The Dirty Dozen* (1967), could insist on director approval and bring the young, British director, John Boorman, to Hollywood and see to Boorman's creative control (Boorman 1998). Steve McQueen would also wield his new star power to

get Peter Yates, another young Brit, to guide *Bullitt* (1968). Peter Bogdanovich would make *Targets* (1968) through an odd deal with Roger Corman (involving the use of Boris Karloff). Transitional Noir films do not share a similar mode of production; rather they share being made outside the fading Hollywood studio system or by a manipulation of the system by a new power-player within the studio. They often feature new stars, more accurately elevated stars. Appearances in Transitional Noir would move them toward their superstar status. After struggling as character actors and then television stars, Marvin and McQueen would become major movie stars. Warren Beatty, similarly, moved from a floundering career to star. All had struggled in the old studio system. Transitional Noirs also feature directors seeking to break out from stifling Hollywood molds, like Siegel, and the directors from the era of live television, like Arthur Penn and John Frankenheimer, or new directors, like Bogdanovich, Boorman, and Yates, attempting to breach the wall around Hollywood production. None of these filmmakers would forge a career in neo-noir; rather neo-noir became a vehicle for their ideas and creative energies in that moment. The directors and actors would move on to other genres and new filmmakers would move neo-noir beyond its transitional phase. Nonetheless, Transitional Noir came together as a cohesive movement at a specific time, with filmmakers working in similar modes of production, producing films of similar intent, much like the filmmakers of classic film noir.

Along with the commonality of alternative paths to production, Transitional Noir films engaged the 1960s in an uncommon way. In a group of films dominated by middle-aged white men, and lacking little evidence of hippies and counterculture, the films are, within the context of their time—firmly anti-establishment, anti-authority, and anti-capitalism. “The Man” in Transitional Noir, the representative of the status quo, actively sought to neutralize the hero. But unlike the hippies of *Zabriskie Point* (Michelangelo Antonioni 1970), or The Monkees in *Head* (Bob Rafelson 1968), or Billy and Wyatt in *Easy Rider* (Dennis Hopper 1969), the heroes of Transitional Noir spring from within the establishment and represent its self-destruction. The establishment/The Man/the status quo is not going to be brought down by young outsiders, but from the cancerous manifestations of the status quo’s own creation. Lee Marvin in *The Killers* and *Point Blank* begins as an operative within the organization, and Steve McQueen is a detective within the San Francisco Police Department who goes up against a corrupt District Attorney (Robert Vaughn). The

closest person to an outsider in the core group of films is Bobby, the young sniper in *Targets*, but even here an emphasis is placed upon his coming from a “normal” family. According to Peary (1981), “Bogdanovich doesn’t contend that Bobby’s actions are those of the average man on the street [...] but he sees the average man as a potential Bobby” (339–340).

Corruption as the status quo highlights many noir films before and after Transitional Noir. What makes Transitional Noir unique stems from its variation on the theme of organizations being so corrupt they breed their own destruction, and that is the core of Transitional Noir’s metaphor of the 1960s. Everything that was established, including organized crime, rots from within. We enter the stories from an existential point of view—the characters wake up to find the world has changed and not for the better. In *Point Blank*, the crime syndicate from which Walker demands his \$93,000 cannot produce the money—no one has the cash; no one has the checkbook. All they can produce is a sniper who kills everyone involved in exchanging money. In *The Killers*, Charlie makes the fatal mistake of wondering why Johnny North would not defend himself, which in turn leads to the crime organization killing Charlie. Bullitt literally wakes up to a new case that seems fishy from the beginning. In *Seconds*, the organization transforms the hero into a new person (a “second”) and then judges him a failure and begins a new, unwanted transformation. The system destroys its members who question its methods and takes full advantage of those who do not understand the role of the organization. In effect, Transitional Noirs activate an odd Vietnam War metaphor. It’s not that Transitional Noirs become anti-war statements, but rather they question the powers-that-be who engage in war and create “heroes” that question the existence of the “organization” and their own being—all within the upheaval of the 1960s.

Lee Marvin, the actor who most embodies the Transitional Noir hero, may seem an enigma to modern audiences. So much of his career appears counter-intuitive, because he ascends to stardom as a middle-aged man, prematurely gray, in an age celebrating youth and outsiders. He lacks the good looks of Steve McQueen or Warren Beatty. He excels in roles that subvert genre and myth: *Cat Ballou* parodies the western gunslinger, *The Professionals* uses the western as Vietnam metaphor, and *The Dirty Dozen* contained a cryptic anti-war message. According to biographer, Dwayne Epstein, Marvin worked out a screen persona that would become the model for the “modern action hero” (155). “[H]is characters,” writes Epstein, “were loners with a past who allowed film audiences to get their

‘vicaries’ [vicarious thrills] watching them pursue a mission or goal with singular purpose” (155). Interestingly, Marvin pared his roles to the bone, often “substituting gestures for dialogue” (Epstein 155), and used a “method” approach in his acting: the alcoholism in *Cat Ballou*, the knowledge and use of firearms in *The Professionals*, and his own military experience in *The Dirty Dozen*. Marvin’s style became one in which the audience watched and felt on an emotional level, one that specifically bypassed giving speeches or developing bits of verbal business (did comedians ever do imitations of Lee Marvin?). Instead, Marvin found ways to force the audience to keep their eyes on him and to always be a bit unsure about what he would do next. Much of Marvin’s style is first evident in *The Killers* and resonates with the ambivalent hero in neo-noir (Fig. 2.1).

Charlie Storm, the seasoned, professional hitman, wonders aloud to his younger partner, Lee, about why their victim made no effort to defend himself, “he just stood there. That’s one. Twenty-five thousand for a simple hit. I never got more than ten in my life. That’s two. Now, I happen to know Johnny North was in on a big mail robbery in California. He supposed to have gotten away with a million bucks, left the other guys holding the bag. [He holds up three fingers.]” Charlie then concludes,



Fig. 2.1 Lee Marvin as a reflection in the sunglasses. *The Killers*, Don Siegel, dir., 1964, Criterion Collection Blu-ray

“Whoever laid this contract wasn’t worried about the million dollars.” The professional knows the organization duped him. Charlie’s “noir decision,” to go to that place that he knows means trouble, comes when he convinces Lee that they should track down the million dollars. The source of Charlie’s ambivalence comes from his experience within the organization: sensing the scheme beneath the surface and the willingness to assert himself against the powerful entity behind the scheme. Perhaps a Vietnam metaphor? Marvin dials his performance down, eliminating the brashness of Liberty Valance, in favor of a minimalism of movement and voice—threatening violence that when it does erupt becomes all the more startling. Charlie menaces through implication, especially in the first half of the film. Charlie’s partner, Lee, does most of the dirty work. The two most violent scenes feature Charlie terrorizing the film’s femme fatale, Sheila. He hangs her out a window by her ankles, and in the final scene he executes her. The stillness of the performance is balanced by intense burst of action and movement.

Lee Marvin’s acting, his physical presence, dominates the ending of *The Killers*. The story resolves itself through dialogue (Reagan’s character confesses, and Angie Dickinson’s femme fatale begs for mercy). As Browning and Sheila retrieve the money from the safe in the den of Browning’s suburban home, Charlie, mortally wounded (shot by Browning earlier), stumbles into the doorway of the den and then falls to the floor. Charlie has four short lines of dialogue between the bits of expository dialogue: “Don’t bother ... Oh, God ... I told you, you couldn’t run ...” He then shoots Browning. And after his famous, if opaque, last line, “Lady, I don’t have the time,” he shoots Sheila.¹ Charlie walks out of the house with the briefcase of money, toting his pistol with a big silencer. His white shirt bares a large blood stain. Marvin performs a dangerous looking stumble, landing hard on his forearm. He crawls a bit, but gets to his feet, taking the briefcase, but leaving his pistol. As he walks toward his car, he makes an odd move of throwing his head to the side. A police car pulls up across the street from the house, as Charlie collapses on the trunk of the car. Charlie holds up his gun hand, trigger finger ready, but no gun. He falls back, the money splays out of the briefcase. A crane shot lifts up and the film ends. Marvin’s physicality imbues the scene with an extra layer of meaning: he’s achieved success—he got the money—but he’s also dead, literally walking dead (a recurring motif in Don Siegel films), and his last gesture is an impotent pointing of the gun he no longer holds at the law. For Epstein, the end of *The Killers* shows, “As a



Fig. 2.2 “Lady, I don’t have the time.” *The Killers*, Don Siegel, dir., 1964, Criterion Collection Blu-ray

silver-haired, granite-faced, middle-aged man of violence, Lee Marvin came to represent the anxiousness of the times” (129) (Fig. 2.2).

According to Siegel, Marvin showed up drunk to shoot the death walk scene (248). Marvin was, in effect, a functioning alcoholic. Epstein’s biography contains multiple anecdotes of Marvin showing up on a set drunk. Siegel makes an interesting claim about Marvin’s drinking while explaining the difficulty of the crane shot at the end of *The Killers*: “Lee had a theory about drinking. If you didn’t talk, no one could smell you. Also, if you didn’t open your mouth, your speech wouldn’t be muddled” (248). Of his drinking while working, Marvin said:

It usually happens when I pump up too hard, when I get my energy level so high that I’m wringing inside; I just have to stop it. Nothing can be that important, so the way I show its unimportance to myself is to have a drink or two or three or whatever. The next thing you know, I’m a little juiced. It’s really a defiance of my own involvement. It allows me to be honest with myself. (Marvin, *Playboy*, 78)

Marvin's alcoholism plays into the ambivalent hero of Transitional Noir in that it emphasizes alternative mind sets, a desire to see the world filtered through an alcoholic haze. The anxiety of the times—Marvin was an avid supporter of Kennedy and *The Killers* was in production when Kennedy was assassinated—the internalization of his own war experiences, his non-method method-like style of acting, and improving his roles in films make for an alignment of the conditions of the actor with the interests of the films, in this case the early efforts of neo-noir. This alignment finds its most complex and complete expression in *Point Blank*.

In *Point Blank*, Walker's ambivalence melds with Marvin's own ambivalence. His "anxiousness of the times" becomes much more of an existential exploration. As Boorman (2003) explained:

In one sense *Point Blank* was a study of Lee Marvin [...]. The young Marvin, wounded and wounding, brave and fearful, was always with him. The guilt of surviving the ambush that wiped out his platoon hung to him all his days. He was fascinated by war and violence, yet the revulsion he felt for it was intense, physical, unendurable.

His power derived from this. He should have died, had died, in combat. He held life, particularly his own, in contempt. Yet he was in possession of a great force that demanded expression. (Boorman 2003, 135–136)

Epstein points out several scenes in *Point Blank* come from Marvin's personal experiences, "such as Walker's wife's suicide [Marvin's wife attempted suicide]. ... when John Vernon's character of Mal desperately entreats the drunken Walker to help him out of a financial jam [Marvin helped friends with financial trouble]" (163). Marvin said, "That was a real troubled time for me, too, in my own personal relationship, so I used an awful lot of that while making the picture, even the suicide of my wife" (Epstein 2013, 164). Walker's ambivalence and his confusion, mistrust, and disassociation extend beyond the narrative into the film itself. Watching the movie is like being in Walker's head, and if we're in Walker's head, we are by extension in Lee Marvin's head. Many critics point out the within-a-dream quality of *Point Blank*. For example, David Thomson: "But what was unique in *Point Blank* was its inner mystery: that Marvin's character, Walker—or was it sleepwalker?—might be dead the whole time and just dreaming the stages of revenge" (406). Foster Hirsch notes, "Defying logic and probability, the rhymed prologue and coda encase Walker's quest with a dreamlike glaze" (168). Boorman and Marvin use neo-noir

to bring the viewer into the ambivalence, not unlike the art film technique seen especially in Michelangelo Antonioni's *Last Year at Marienbad*: is what you're seeing *now*, or is it last year at Marienbad? Or has Boorman worked out Lee Marvin's version of Fellini's *8 ½* (1963)? The anxiousness of the times, then, becomes a part of the film-viewing experience.

For *Point Blank*, the movie is the dream, but within the dream come other layers of dreaming, as Boorman disperses fragments of the opening sequence throughout the film. Frankenheimer's *Seconds*, like *Point Blank*, foregrounds the oneiric. The oneiric quality of *The Killers* and *Bullitt*, however, exists more in the background, because the oneiric state becomes aspirational—a goal, or state of mind, the characters dream of achieving. Charlie explains to Lee (in an effective monotone by Marvin), “But me, I’m gettin’ old, my hair’s turnin’ grey, my feet are sore, I’m tired of runnin’. And now, if I had a half a million bucks. . . I wouldn’t have to run.” Charlie dreams of idyllic retreat after his career as a hitman. Perhaps Charlie’s last line, “Lady, I don’t have the time,” has something to do with it? Similarly, in *Bullitt*, Jacqueline Bisset’s character, Cathy, rises above the pedestrian girlfriend role in one scene where she questions the world Bullitt lives in. Cathy tells him, “You’re living in a sewer, Frank. Day after day.” Bullitt replies, “That’s where half of it is. You can’t walk away from it.” Cathy goes into a litany of the ugliness of Bullitt’s world. McQueen seems to be taking a note from Lee Marvin in that he says nothing. Cathy ends with, “What will happen to us in time?” After a pause, Bullitt responds, “Time starts now.” Almost as opaque as “Lady, I don’t have the time.” Bullitt’s aspiration involves a life with Cathy, but what kind of life is unclear. We’re left with the ambiguity of Bullitt staring at himself in the bathroom mirror at the end. An even darker oneirism prevails in *Targets* when we contemplate the “dream” of the “normal” young guy, Bobby, who becomes an assassin of random victims. The dream that Transitional Noir returns to in multiple variations is one in which the dreamer aspires to an idyllic, if warped, state, one that defies logic. Charlie, in *The Killers*, thinks money will alleviate having to be on the run, Walker enacts revenge upon the organization which has become the status quo, Bullitt believes he can thwart corrupt politicians, *Seconds* shows another organization controls the dream of transformation, and the young shooter of *Targets* kills for some unfathomable reason. These films do not confront the major issues of the time head on. Instead Transitional Noir confronts the anxiety of the people living in the time of Vietnam, race riots, and sexual liberation. The one issue that does merit direct confrontation is violence.

Violence in films perplexed film critics in the late 1960s. The long-time film critic of the *New York Times*, Bosley Crowther, famously misunderstood the violence in *Bonnie and Clyde*. As Biskind points out, “Lately, [Crowther] had been on a tear against violence in movies, slagging not only Robert Aldrich’s *The Dirty Dozen*, but also John Boorman’s *Point Blank* for their lack of redeeming social value” (39). Crowther would lose his position at the *Times* and Hollywood films would go on to produce much grander visions of violence, such as *The Wild Bunch* (Sam Peckinpah 1969) and *A Clockwork Orange* (Stanley Kubrick 1971). *Point Blank* presented violent content so distinct major critics took notice. Less dramatic, *The Killers* was deemed too violent for television release. The violence in *The Killers* and *Point Blank* works thematically, juxtaposing a personal, up-close, sexualized violence that often spills out into the public, in a way not seen in the other films known for their violence (e.g., the bloodiness of *Bonnie and Clyde* and *The Wild Bunch*) with more distanced, corporate style of violence usually featuring snipers. Snipers feature prominently in the famous/infamous violent incidents of the 1960s—assassination of President John Kennedy in 1963 and the sniper in the tower on the camp of the University of Texas in 1966 (a major influence on *Targets*)—and were involved in the Detroit riots during the summer of 1967 and the assassination of Martin Luther King, Jr., in 1968. The violence theme provides another example of Transitional Noir reflecting the times in which they were made.

The up-close, personal violence in *The Killers* features Charlie and Lee dangling Sheila out of her apartment window by her ankles. Charlie reels her in, throws her across the room, and gets right up in her face with a whispered threat—with Lee Marvin adding an interesting twist of following Angie Dickinson’s eyes with his eyes. Later, Charlie shoots Browning and Sheila in Browning’s home, up close, with the barrel of his silenced pistol up close to the camera lens. When he dies, Charlie goes down making the impotent hand gun gesture. Hirsch criticizes Siegel’s *The Killers* because it has been “virtually cleansed of noir motifs” (38). While it may not look like a classic noir, the violence contained in *The Killers* serves the purpose of noir in reflecting the violence of its time. Similarly, in *Point Blank*, Walker punches a thug in crotch, and when he confronts Mal, Mal is naked except for the bed sheet wrapped about his waist. Walker intimidates Mal out on to a penthouse balcony and over the edge—with Walker left holding the sheet and Mal’s body drops on to the cars in the street below. Throughout *Point Blank*, Walker inflicts his violence upon the

important objects of his victims, as opposed to the victims themselves. When he confronts his ex-wife, who he believes has betrayed him, he forces his way into her bedroom and shoots up her bed with, according to Boorman (1998), “lots of sexual innuendo.” Walker gets close to the faces of the people he terrorizes, often whispering to them.

By contrast, the violence inflicted by the organization comes in the form of a hired sniper, who works from a distance. In *The Killers*, Browning shoots at Charlie and Lee from a building across the street as they come out of Sheila’s apartment. Lee is killed, and Charlie is wounded. The sniper in *Point Blank* shoots the used car dealer in the concrete Los Angeles river bed—thinking it is Walker—from a bridge a way in the distance. The used car dealer seems to have been shot by some omniscient force, but when we see the sniper (James B. Sicking), he works calmly, professionally, as he wraps his rifle and returns to his car. Bobby, the sniper in *Targets*, also works calmly and methodically. While not associated with any organization, he is shown to be from a “normal,” middle-class background and equally as mechanical as the sniper in *Point Blank*.

Another common aspect to the violence in Transitional Noir, and an element that will reoccur in other neo-noir movements, is how the violent action spills over into the non-noir world. Often the characters exist in an otherworld, dealing only with characters of that otherworld. But on occasion their violence escapes their world and enters the “real” world. Bobby inflicts his psychopathy on innocent drivers and later patrons at a drive-in movie theatre. In *Bullitt*, the famous car chase takes place on public streets. Browning shoots Charlie and Lee while they stand on a public sidewalk. Mal’s body falls on to some unlucky person’s car. The violence in Transitional Noir resonates with the anxiety of the times; it springs up from an underworld where an ambivalent hero has momentarily upset the status quo—to, like the film itself, interact with the public.

Perhaps Hirsch missed neo-noir style in the violence of *The Killers* because his definition of noir was focused on visual style. Indeed, *The Killers* did not look like a classic noir, because of the simple fact that it was not. Instead, *The Killers* and *Point Blank* forge a neo-noir style, a style unique to Transitional Noir. As mentioned earlier, a key aspect of Transitional Noir is being discernably different than the classic noir with which it coexisted. An early effort, like *The Killers* of 1964, makes a cruder, less nuanced, statement than the more carefully crafted *Point Blank* of 1967. *The Killers* features the flat lighting of television and studio bound sets. Even the exterior of Browning’s house in the finale, though not on

the studio lot, looks like an upscale suburban neighborhood from 1960s television (Siegel 247). *The Killers* does not look like a B-movie of the 1940s; it looks like the new version of the B-movie, the made-for-television movie, of the 1960s. Within this mode of production, bits of Transitional Noir style appear, such as the first shot, after the title sequence, of Charlie's face reflected in the lens of Lee's sunglasses, the slow motion shot of Johnny North being shot, the close-up and personal style of threatening violence when Charlie and Lee interrogate Sylvester (Claude Akins)—Charlie leans down and whispers the threat in Sylvester's ear—and the misogynistic violence when Lee punches Sheila in the face. Because of the television mode, much of *The Killers* is close-up on faces, and much of the action is close-up with faces only inches apart. Charlie and Lee spiral in closer to Sheila as they terrorize her. Much of Sheila luring Johnny into the scheme is done in close-ups and intimate two-shots. The evolving style in *The Killers* hints at the possibilities and affirms its difference from classic noir.

In *Point Blank*, the visual style embraces the fragmentation and excess of the post-classical mode. The reflections, the intimate threat of violence, the expressive use of architecture, the action and gesture, the disjointed editing, and the use of color combine to bring the audience inside the experience of the film. That is, watching the film becomes analogous to the situation of the hero (we will return to this idea in later chapters). Classic film noirs often featured dream sequences, or dream-like set pieces, such as Marlowe's drug trip in *Murder, My Sweet* (1946) and the funhouse scene in *The Lady from Shanghai* (1947). The drug trip or action within the funhouse frames the expressive camera work and editing. *Point Blank* removes the confining framework, and Boorman emphasizes the subjectivity of the narrative. We bounce between the objective and the subjective, and the style—the visual compositions, the editing, the soundtrack, and the acting style—works to keep us off-balance. For example, the scene where Walker bursts into his wife's apartment to confront her. The scene begins overlapped to the sequence of Walker following Lynne where Walker's steps drone on the soundtrack. He sits in his car and watches Lynne walk up the steps to her apartment, shot/reverse shot. The sound of the steps ceases when Walker bursts through the door and grabs Lynne. He waves the gun around, then stumbles into the bedroom and shoots the bed six times. Walker looks around, sees no one. He inspects the bathroom, breaking perfume bottles in the sink. All of this has been done in a fairly standard style, with no odd angles, no strange lighting, and no

abrupt cuts. It lulls us into a key moment in the narrative with some standard technique, momentarily releasing us from decoding film style to take in the narrative. Walker goes back into the living room and sits on the sofa, Lynne comes over and sits near him. In a bit of Lee Marvin gun business, Walker empties the spent shells from the gun onto the coffee table. Walker then leans back on sofa and threads two fingers through open part of the pistol that holds the cartridge and stares off into the distance. Lynne begins answering unasked questions while Walker continues to stare. We've been thrown off guard again, Marvin's acting style in this scene—the gesture of no gesture—draws our attention. Lynne's expository dialogue floats over the scene. The most interesting thing she says is, "... Dream about you... how good it must be... being dead..." Is she talking about her own upcoming suicide? Or is she telling us Walker is himself dead? Marvin's acting style does not provide an answer; rather it focuses our attention on him as we, and he, process the information from Lynne. The visual style, including the odd acting, bring us, as viewers, into the experience of Walker (Fig. 2.3).

Boorman's technique in *Point Blank* also keeps the viewer continuously off-kilter. Transition scenes often feature fragments of the meeting between Mal and Walker (the two men rolling on the floor together at a party). A new sequence may begin with an odd low angle on the building in which the upcoming scene takes place, then Boorman's camera finds Walker and associates him with architecture. The emphasis on the vertical ascendance of the modern exteriors establishes the grid through which



Fig. 2.3 Lee Marvin using stillness to focus attention. *Point Blank*, John Boorman, dir., 1967, Warner Bros. Home Video Blu-ray

Walker must pass. He seems to move from one maze to another, be it the building Mal lives in or the office building and hallways of Carter's office, and even at Brewster's house in the hills, Walker is placed against the maze pattern of sprawling Los Angeles in the distance, and in the ending the prison compound is revealed to not be Alcatraz, as we've been led to believe. The visual style of *Point Blank*, taking notes from Antonioni, always turns us back to the mind of Walker—we know, at times, that we see what he sees and at times we see what he thinks about, but at other times we see images that represent his interior, as with the montage after Walker discovers Lynne's suicide—Boorman uses images of Walker to convey Walker's strange anguish, images such Walker shot through a screen window that slowly finds focus, the colors of the broken perfume bottles in the sink, the stripped mattress which tells us someone has “cleaned” the apartment but left Walker behind, and Walker in the empty living, squatting in the corner. The progression of images and the odd flow of time put us back in Walker's mind, a process of film-viewing which we have to remind ourselves to perform as “normal” narrative progression is once again upset (Fig. 2.4).

To decode the visual style of Transitional Noir, as with other movements, we should not seek noir motifs derived from classic film noir, as Hirsch did with his dismissal of *The Killers* (38). Instead, we should examine *how* filmmakers use visual style to fulfill the purpose of neo-noir. Siegel, Boorman, Yates, Frankenheimer, and Bogdanovich manipulate technique to set their visual style apart from classical film noir. Early efforts, like *The*



Fig. 2.4 Walker enters the maze. *Point Blank*, John Boorman, dir., 1967, Warner Bros. Home Video Blu-ray

Killers, work with the flat color of television production of the mid-1960s, and while the film contains bits of neo-noir technique, *The Killers*' visual style as Transitional Noir is minimal. *Point Blank*, on the other hand, achieves the post-classical sense of excessiveness. *Seconds* also provides an interesting case, because it, like *Mickey One*, is in black and white. Frankenheimer bypasses color, but he does not bypass technique, as the film is highly stylized, manipulating different lenses, editing technique, and image distortion—to keep the viewer as disoriented as the main character Arthur Hamilton (John Randolph/Rock Hudson). The anxiety of the times finds its way into the visual style of Transitional Noir. Unlike its classic predecessor, Transitional Noir has rather few distinct visual motifs (e.g., reflections, distortions) and instead offers a consistent visual style based on using film technique to disorient the viewer and heighten anxiety. The heroes of Transitional Noir do not evoke a distinct visual look, although Lee Marvin usually appears in a gray suit with a narrow tie. Instead, they look like members of the ordinary world. The femme fatale, brought into the light, also comes with modified associations.

Angie Dickinson plays the femme fatale in *The Killers* and *Point Blank* and provides a solid example of how the films early in the movement have more recognizable classic film noir traits. Dickinson's Sheila, in *The Killers*, lures men into the criminal scheme, playing them for patsies. She's blonde and sunny and appears in vibrant colors. At no point does she lurk in the darkness and exhale cigarette smoke into shafts of light. Her temptation is modernized, but focused on keeping her victim off-balance. Sheila possesses the "secret story," the story information the other characters do not know, and lures Johnny North into the scheme concocted by her and Browning. What she does not know or expect is the emergence of Charlie, the professional hitman experiencing a moral dilemma. It is to Sheila, when she makes her femme fatale-style appeal that it was Browning all along and she is innocent, that Charlie exclaims, "Lady, I don't have the time," before he shoots her. Interestingly, the "lure" of the femme fatale, in *The Killers*, is not something associated with darkness. Sheila, like Charlie, appears to be quite the professional, so lingering in seedy bars or dingy hotel rooms would go against her professionalism. She only meets her match at the end, because she runs out of options, and Charlie acts as a professional. Knowing he has been duped leads to Johnny's acceptance of the killers and provokes Charlie's professional concern. Sheila's femme fatale act, then, becomes the source of anxiety for the two central male characters.

Much more complicated is Angie Dickinson's role in *Point Blank*. She plays Chris, the sister of Walker's wife, Lynne. Because of Lynne's suicide, brought on by the anxious position Mal's betrayal scheme put her in, Chris willingly helps Walker achieve his revenge on Mal. To do so, Chris acts the femme fatale to distract Mal with sex. While she lures Mal into the bedroom (and unlocks the balcony door), Walker ascends the building, avoiding Mal's security force. The plan works, but Mal accidentally falls from the penthouse balcony to his death. Chris and Walker leave, moving on to the next victim in Walker's plan. In effect, Walker and Chris manipulate the femme fatale role—knowing they can use Mal's weakness to their professional advantage. After Mal's death, Chris and Walker arrive at a house high in the hills above Los Angeles, a modern house done in a log cabin style, with plenty of modern extras—a pool, built-in stereo, and every electric kitchen appliance (in a rage, Chris will turn them all on). Whatever power Chris can exert, even sexuality, has little effect on Walker. The twist is Walker's impenetrability keeps Chris off-balance. She, like the audience, does not understand Walker. Her frustration leads to a key moment in Transitional Noir, the scene that defines gender relations in Transitional Noir: Chris, so frustrated with Walker at the modern house in the hills, beats on Walker's chest—she really lets him have it. Boorman (1998) contends Angie Dickinson was getting Marvin back “for what he did to her in *The Killers*.” Dickinson, at one point, stops hitting him, but then digs back in. Marvin simply stands there and takes it. After this scene, the couple end up in bed. At this point, the audience is very off-balance. During the love scene, Lynne appears to Walker, taking us into Walker's anxious mind. After sleeping together, Walker adds to the detachment of the characters by attempting to pay Chris. Chris rejects the money and asks him, “Do you know my last name?” Walker, not missing a beat, replies, “Do you know my first name?” Neither Walker, Chris, or the audience fully understands the connection between the two characters—nor are we supposed to, because they operate in a different, highly subjective, world, one that most likely belongs to Walker. Chris' attack on Walker, aided by Dickinson's 110 percent commitment to the scene, crystallizes the loss of humanity in Walker and by extension the world he inhabits. The “femme fatale,” now merely a role to be played, only illuminates the complete lack of humanity in Walker: unaffected by sexual appeal, unaffected by emotion, unaffected by greed. He exists on some other plane, an alternate universe, hence the rage directed at him by Chris.

Point Blank elevates the ambivalent hero to a metaphysical state, bringing the oneiric quality to the foreground, buttressing it with visual style and violence, and diffusing any classical connections like the femme fatale. In the end, the audience is not even sure, or confident, that Walker exists. This disappearance into the ether is the core reason why *Point Blank* is the acme of Transitional Noir: the vision of what neo-noir can be is embodied by a figure springing from a dream; enacting a violent rampage through the “organization,” only to find the system equally ephemeral; and then disappearing back into the darkness.

Boorman pushed *Point Blank* into the realm of art film by using the film language based on an understanding of noir (“we were conscious of making a genre picture”), specifically the noir films that had begun to differentiate themselves from the classic noir films of the 1940s and 1950s (Boorman 2003, 129). *The Killers* provides an early effort, one not sure of its destination, but knowing it is a part of a new journey. Other films, like *Seconds* and *Mickey One*, offer further elaboration of the ideas of neo-noir, which have been bundled together herein as the basic elements of noir. Different filmmakers coming together with a common concept that something like film noir can become a vehicle for them to explore the anxiety of the 1960s, not from a perspective of young people or hippies or counterculture, but from the inside, from the perspective of aging white men seeing the culture and society, which they had previously dominated, now coming to an end—even working against them. Transitional Noirs establish a significant precedent by showing how neo-noir films can coalesce within a distinct historical period and reflect that moment’s darker possibilities, following the model of classic noir.

APPENDIX

Transitional Noir Film List

The Last Classical Noirs

- Key Witness* (1960), d. Phil Karlson
- Midnight Lace* (1960), d. David Miller
- The Lawbreakers* (1960), d. Joseph N. Newman
- Pay or Die!* (1960), d. Richard Wilson
- Portrait in Black* (1960), d. Michael Gordon
- The Pusher* (1960), d. Gene Milford

Seven Thieves (1960), d. Henry Hathaway
The 3rd Voice (1960), d. Hubert Cornfield
Why Must I Die? (1960), d. Roy Del Ruth
Look in Any Window (1961), d. William Aland
Blast of Silence (1961), d. Allen Baron
Underworld U.S.A. (1961), d. Sam Fuller
The Most Dangerous Man Alive (1961), d. Allan Dwan
Experiment in Terror (1962), d. Blake Edwards
13 West Street (1962), d. Philip Leacock
War Hunt (1962), d. Denis Sanders
The Girl Hunters (1963), d. Roy Rowland
Right Hand of the Devil (1963), d. Aram Katcher
Shock Corridor (1963), d. Sam Fuller
Thunder Island (1963), d. Jack Leewood
The Naked Kiss (1964), d. Sam Fuller
Kitten with a Whip (1964), d. Douglas Heyes
Angel's Flight (1965), d. Raymond Nassour and Kenneth W. Richardson
Mirage (1965), d. Edward Dmytryk
The Money Trap (1966), d. Burt Kennedy
The Hostage (1967), d. Russell S. Doughten Jr.

Transitional Noir

The Killers (1964), d. Don Siegel (also Remake Noir)
The Hanged Man (1964), d. Don Siegel (also Remake Noir—*Ride the Pink Horse* [1947])
Brainstorm (1965), d. William Conrad
Mickey One (1965), d. Arthur Penn
Who Killed Teddy Bear (1965), d. Joseph Cates
Seconds (1966), d. John Frankenheimer
Point Blank (1967), d. John Boorman
Stranger on the Run (1967), d. Don Siegel
Warning Shot (1967), d. Buzz Kulik
The Split (1968)
Bullitt (1968), d. Peter Yates
Targets (1968), d. Peter Bogdanovich
The Lost Man (1969), d. Robert Alan Aurthur (also Remake Noir—*Odd Man Out* [1947])
Once You Kiss a Stranger (1969), d. Robert Sparr (also Remake Noir—*Strangers on a Train* [1951])

NOTE

1. Epstein misquotes the line as “Lady, I just don’t have the time,” but Marvin never says the word “just.” 1:32:50 on the DVD/Blu-ray. Siegel misquotes the line as “Lady, I just haven’t got the time” (256).

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Hollywood Renaissance Noir, 1969–1979

The Key Films

Klute (1971), d. Alan J. Pakula
The Getaway (1972), d. Sam Peckinpah
The Long Goodbye (1973), d. Robert Altman
The Friends of Eddie Coyle (1973), d. Peter Yates
The Conversation (1974), d. Francis Ford Coppola
The Parallax View (1974), d. Alan J. Pakula
Night Moves (1975), d. Arthur Penn
Taxi Driver (1976), d. Martin Scorsese
The Killing of a Chinese Bookie (1976), d. John Cassavetes
Rolling Thunder (1977), d. John Flynn
The Driver (1978), d. Walter Hill

The fragmentation of post-classical Hollywood accelerated during the 1970s to the extent that lumping neo-noir films together and calling them Seventies Noir ignores significant nuances of the groups of neo-noir films forming during this time. Amidst the growing excessiveness and fragmentation of the 1970s, a crucial movement known as the Hollywood Renaissance emerges. The directors of the Hollywood Renaissance, such as Francis Ford Coppola and Martin Scorsese, would make *the* films that define this period. David Cook, in *Lost Illusions: American Cinema in the Shadow of Watergate and Vietnam, 1970–1979* (2000), explains the difference between these directors and their predecessors:

Whereas the generations of directors descended from classical Hollywood had learned their filmmaking through apprenticeship or in transmigration from Broadway and the theater, and the recruits of the fifties and sixties were trained in television, many new directors of the seventies had studied *film as film* in university graduate programs and professional schools. They had taken film history, aesthetics, and production as formal academic subjects, and they had learned the technical aspects of production, as well as budgeting and marketing, more thoroughly than any generation before them. (133)

Hollywood Renaissance Noir operates while another distinct group of neo-noir films, films distinguished by their balance of neo-noir intent and nostalgia with stories set in the past (e.g., *Chinatown* and *Farewell, My Lovely*, a movement we will discuss in an upcoming chapter), begins development. Within Hollywood Renaissance Noir, a unified, but not homogeneous, group of directors began a discourse of genre revision, which included neo-noir. Among the directors we find a film school-educated group, dominated by Francis Ford Coppola and Martin Scorsese. Another group consists of directors coming to feature films having served apprenticeships in television, such as Robert Altman, Sam Peckinpah, and Arthur Penn, who incorporated television production technique with their evolving ideas about film, often influenced by the international auteur director, especially the French New Wave, to further develop distinct visions. It should be noted that these directors were not the only ones to venture into feature films after television apprenticeships. Directors like Buzz Kulik, Joseph Sargent, and Lamont Johnson came from similar backgrounds yet never established themselves as auteurs. A third subset consists of Walter Hill and Paul Schrader (also a film academic), representing screenwriters who work their way to directing. Each subset contributes to the renaissance with their unique explorations of neo-noir, and each subset tends to come to its own conclusions.

This movement features directors, producers, screenwriters, and actors, often working within the floundering Hollywood system. Each new film strives for a distinctly modern cinema. Simultaneously, the social and cultural context fomented an audience for these films. While Hollywood continued to produce what Ken Windrum (2019) labels “traditionalist” fare, such as *Airport* (1970), *Love Story* (1971), a Disney film, or a Roger Moore entry in the James Bond franchise, more challenging films, with a distinct and often bleak vision, also found success at the box office between

1968 and 1976. In 1969, for example, *Midnight Cowboy* (1969), an X-rated film, won an Academy Award for Best Picture. What could constitute mainstream Hollywood, and popular entertainment, had never been so expansive, allowing so many hitherto taboo ideas about film to succeed at the box office and with critics. Could films such as Stanley Kubrick's opaque *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), Peckinpah's super-violent *The Wild Bunch* (1969), the three-hour concert film *Woodstock* (1970), early Blaxploitation like Melvin Van Peebles' *Sweet Sweetback's Baadasssss Song* (1971), Bernardo Bertolucci's challenging *Last Tango in Paris* (1973), or the despair of Scorsese and Schrader's *Taxi Driver* (1976) succeed in any other time period? Ultimately, this time, and these types of films, would end when a new Hollywood, rooted in blockbuster hits, ascended. For Cook, "Somewhere between the dumbing down of American corporate culture that produced the cynical young tycoons of the 'New Hollywood' and the remarkable aesthetic revival that produced the *auteur* directors of the 'Hollywood Renaissance' [...] lies a cinema of great expectations and lost illusions" (6). Neo-noir played a crucial role for the directors of the Hollywood Renaissance.

Scorsese, Altman, and Coppola tried their hand at neo-noir and then moved on to other genres. For example, during this time Scorsese, who had already made his first neo-noir, *Mean Streets* (1973), and screenwriter Schrader come together for *Taxi Driver*. Scorsese then moved on to a musical, *New York, New York* (1977), a concert documentary, *The Last Waltz* (1978), a boxing drama, *Raging Bull* (1980), and did not return to neo-noir material until 2010 with *Shutter Island* (I see his remake of *Cape Fear* as a thriller/horror film). Schrader, writer of the 1972 seminal article of film noir, "Notes on Film Noir (1972)," became a writer-director and made two more neo-noir films, *Hardcore* (1979) and *American Gigolo* (1980), and did not return to noir. Altman methodically worked his way through the genres in the 1970s, and into the 1980s, with a single neo-noir effort, *The Long Goodbye* (1973). Likewise, Coppola made a single neo-noir, *The Conversation* (1974), and never returned to noir. Other directors, particularly Walter Hill and Sam Peckinpah, contributed to the renaissance but stayed within genres, namely westerns, crime films, and neo-noir. Peckinpah died in 1984, but Hill continues to make westerns, crime films, and neo-noir. His neo-noirs engage the times in which they were released: compare 1984's *Streets of Fire* (bring-back-my-girlfriend plot set in retro-futuristic 80s world) to 2016's *The Assignment* (a hitman revenge involving gender re-assignment). These directors and this

movement demonstrate how the post-classical approach can find combinations of filmmakers working in sync, often unknowingly, if only for a limited time and then dispersing into other movements of the post-classical. More evidence for Schrader's concept of film noir as a "historical genre" (1995).

As an historical movement, Hollywood Renaissance Noir establishes unique qualities which differentiate it from previous neo-noir movements, Transition Noir, and other movements of neo-noir existing simultaneously. Hollywood Renaissance Noir features new directors working within a new organization of Hollywood, bringing a new set of criteria to neo-noir, one based on a sophisticated knowledge of film history, the changing role of the director, and a skeptical attitude about genre. No single actor dominates this movement as Lee Marvin dominated Transitional Noir, and no one director epitomizes this movement. The Hollywood Renaissance Noir directors are keenly aware of film noir and genre and auteur directors, but unaware of their own participation in a cohesive movement. The times have changed since Transitional Noir and the Hollywood Renaissance filmmakers deal with a different social and cultural context. Whereas *Point Blank* (John Boorman 1967) and *Bullitt* (Peter Yates 1968) bored into their central characters and analogized the pop culture of the time with the noir experience, Hollywood Renaissance Noir engages the Nixon presidency and its downfall, the end of the Vietnam War, and early paranoia brought on by technology. But Hollywood Renaissance Noirs also have a different visual style than their predecessors (and those that follow). I find a distance between the films and the audience that one does not find elsewhere in neo-noir. No descendant of *Point Blank* exists in this group, as the films never attempt to create a viewing experience analogous to the hero's experience. Instead, these films maintain a distance between viewer and audience, always finding a way to *not* relate to the audience. This sense of distance becomes an important influence of our understanding of Hollywood Renaissance Noir.

Robert Altman's *The Long Goodbye* and Walter Hill's *The Driver* (1978) serve as the two sample films for Hollywood Renaissance Noir. Each represents a sub-group, or mode, within this movement. *The Long Goodbye* represents the films that attempt to *redefine* neo-noir. Altman, Scorsese, Schrader, Coppola, Penn, and Alan J. Pakula, the film school and television directors, were among directors and writers primarily interested in questioning what genres could represent. Altman, for example, takes direct aim at film noir, adapting a novel from the canonical Raymond

Chandler and using a script from Leigh Brackett, who was one of the writers on Howard Hawks' *The Big Sleep* (1946) and many Hawks westerns, including *Rio Bravo* (1959), and was hired by George Lucas to write *Star Wars V: The Empire Strikes Back* (1980). The key element within this subgroup consists of finding that thing in the material, where genre, social context, and audience expectations meet, and then turning it in a new, unexpected direction. Simultaneously, these directors deploy a sophisticated film technique to amplify the redefinition. When Altman came to *The Long Goodbye*, he had already thrown the war movie into doubt with *M*A*S*H* (1970) and re-envisioned the western with *McCabe and Mrs. Miller* (1971). After *The Long Goodbye*, Altman would remake and subvert the classic gangster film *They Live by Night* (1948) as *Thieves Like Us* (1974). Altman explained his desire to undermine genre with *The Long Goodbye*, knowing full well where it stood in relationship to film noir:

So I read Leigh Brackett's script [...] and in her version, in the last scene Marlowe pulled out his gun and killed his best friend, Terry Lennox. It was so out of character for Marlowe, I said, 'I'll do the picture, but you cannot change that ending! It must be in the contract.' They all agreed, which was very surprising. If she hadn't written that ending, I guarantee I wouldn't have done it. [...] I decided that we were going to call him Rip Van Marlowe, as if he'd been asleep for twenty years, had woken up and was wandering through this landscape of the early 1970s, but trying to invoke the morals of a previous era. I put him in that dark suit, white shirt and tie, while everyone else was smelling incense and smoking pot and going topless; everything was health food and exercise and cool. So we just satirized that whole time. (Thompson 75, 76)

Leigh Brackett (1991) admitted to being unaware of Altman's farcical intent (24), and Brackett's screenplay (1972) provides for interesting comparisons. Namely, delineating certain elements as "Altman" touches and those aspects where he's following the screenplay as written. For example, the opening scene about the cat and the cat food is not in the script. Through satire and irony, Altman uses *The Long Goodbye* as a vehicle to engage the 1970s and redefine the possibilities of the private eye neo-noir mythos. Scorsese and Schrader take a similar approach with *Taxi Driver*, as does Alan J. Pakula with *The Parallax View* (1974) and Coppola with *The Conversation* (Fig. 3.1).

The other sub-group/mode consists of films that *recreate* film noir within the historical context of the 1970s. That is, films like *The Getaway*



Fig. 3.1 Rip Van Marlowe awakens. *The Long Goodbye*, Robert Altman, dir., 1973, Kino Lorber Blu-ray

(Sam Peckinpah 1972), *The Friends of Eddie Coyle* (Peter Yates 1973), *The Killing of a Chinese Bookie* (John Cassavetes 1976), and *The Driver* (1978) engage the 1970s as neo-noir films and as B-movies. These films do not throw genre into doubt, but demonstrate the viability of neo-noir in the contemporary moment. These directors celebrate neo-noir and revel in its darkness. Further, they rely on a mode of production for B-movies (more accurately, they seem like B-movies compared to the expensive A-movies of the time) still extant in the 1970s—if barely. Drive-ins, double-features, and second-run theatres, where these *films* played and found their original success, were on their last legs. This mode of productions highlights the historical nature of the post-classical movements, that production possibilities are temporary. Walter Hill (2006) explained, “Yes, that niche [lower budgets and expectations with little producer interference] no longer exists. The middle ground has fallen out of the studio system” (120).

Within the Hollywood production system of the early 1970s, Walter Hill found success as a screenwriter, especially with *The Getaway* (1972). After writing and directing his first film *Hard Times* (1975), Hill wrote an original screenplay, *The Driver*, intended for Steve McQueen, but McQueen, not interested in doing another car chase film, opted out (Hewitt 2017). Without McQueen’s superstar status, *The Driver*, with Ryan O’Neal in the lead, revels in its B-movie status. It reactivates many film noir tropes in the contemporary world, but never becomes nostalgic

and it focuses on a male hero whose ambivalence comes from an exaggerated minimalism.

The ambivalent male hero works as a key element in establishing the “distance” between the film and the audience of Hollywood Renaissance Noir. With *The Long Goodbye* and *The Driver*, we see the two different modes in operation, each resonating with their style but also working to keep the audience at a distance. Elliott Gould’s performance as Phillip Marlowe in *The Long Goodbye* may be the epitome of ambivalence in this movement, or any neo-noir movement in post-classical Hollywood. His catch phrase, so to speak, is “It’s okay with me.” As Altman stated above, Gould’s Marlowe seems to have been transported from the 1940s to the 1970s: he seems to be the only one in Los Angeles smoking cigarettes (he chain-smokes through the entire film), he drives a 1948 Lincoln Continental (Gould), and he wears a basic black suit with a white shirt and narrow black tie—if not very 1940s, the suit is certainly out of fashion in the 1970s. Gould imbues the performance with mumbling, so much so that dialogue can be difficult to make out at times, and he rarely makes eye contact. Altman gives the audience no background information on Marlowe, only that Marlowe knows Terry Lennox and his wife before the film picks up the story. Altman never allows us to relate to Marlowe or sympathize as he works his way through 1970s era Los Angeles. Marlowe never interprets anything along the way: from the topless women practicing yoga and baking pot brownies to the abusive relationships among the wealthy living at the beach, it’s simply “Okay with me.” Marlowe is not tasked, but forced, into a mission, by LA gangster, Marty Augustine, to retrieve the money Terry Lennox stole from Augustine. This sends Marlowe out to the beach colony to meet the Wades, who were friends with the Lennoxs. Mrs. Wade then hires Marlowe to get her husband out of shady rehab clinic. Marlowe suspects a connection between the Wades and the Lennoxs. Marlowe’s detective work is not very impressive, again keeping a distance between the film and viewer. He stumbles along as the Wades act out their marriage drama and Marty Augustine periodically appears and demands his money. Brackett puts off the “noir decision” to the ending (Brackett 1972), when Marlowe finds Terry Lennox in Mexico. Lennox staged his own death and put Marlowe on the hook for Marty Augustine’s money. Marlowe also learns Lennox was a habitual wife beater and had beaten his wife to death the night he asked Marlowe to take him to Mexico. Marlowe then shoots Lennox and walks off, passing Mrs. Wade as she heads to her rendezvous with Lennox, evoking the ending of *The*

Third Man (Carol Reed 1949). “Hooray for Hollywood” plays and Marlowe smiles and kicks his feet up—happily released from his noir adventure. The “distance” in *The Long Goodbye*, evoked through Marlowe, arises from being the subject satirized, in this case the world, through the lens of Los Angeles, in the early 1970s. We are not connected to the investigator’s POV, seeing the world as he sees it; rather, Marlowe looks at us, a culture of the self-absorbed, and mumbles, “Okay with me.”

With *The Driver*, we engage a more traditional neo-noir hero, known only as the Driver. None of the main characters have names, only job titles: the Driver, the Detective, and the Player. We relate to the neo-noir experience, not the personality of the hero. The Driver remains distant as part of genre expectations, noir characters known for their skills, like the pick-pocket in *Pickup on South Street* (Sam Fuller 1953) or the safecracker in *The Asphalt Jungle* (John Huston 1950)—Hill is not redefining; he is recreating. The Driver engages the modern world in a way that reminds us of how classic noir films worked. In typical Hill fashion, *The Driver* focuses on the relationship between two men, one rather quiet and the other talkative (as with *Hard Times* and *48 Hours* [1982]) with like motives. In *The Driver*, the talkative one, the Detective (Bruce Dern), represents the corrupt institution, the Law, who only wants to play a game with the Driver. And when the Detective makes the game apparent to the Driver, the Driver makes his “noir decision” and goes along. The “distance,” this time, resides in the exaggerated male competition in which only the Detective and the Driver are good enough to compete. The good bad guy, the Driver, and corrupt law, the Detective, battle to a standstill because, just like the times, they were so focused on each other they failed to notice someone else taking advantage of their competition, a tidy metaphor for Vietnam, Watergate, the Manson family murders, and other ills of the 1970s. *The Driver* achieves what the best B-movies achieve: a solid punch of entertainment with other layers of meaning in it for anyone interested in digging them out. In Hill’s words, “The real power of movies lies in their connection to our unconscious or semiconscious dream life, and action movies are about heroism and death. Will he live or will he die is the ultimate drama, isn’t it?” (127).

The films that seek to redefine our perception of neo-noir, like *The Long Goodbye* or *The Parallax View* or *Taxi Driver* or *Klute* (1971), emphasize dreamers. The films begin by finding the dreamer and establishing the context of the dream. For example, in *Klute*, the detective’s (Donald Sutherland) investigation takes him to New York City, where he

finds Brie Daniels (Jane Fonda), who dreams of a career as an actress in New York City as she survives as a prostitute. Gene Hackman's character in *The Conversation* lives a puritan kind of life and sees himself detached from the corruption he deals with as a wiretapper. *The Long Goodbye* opens with the prowling camera finding Marlowe asleep (recall Altman referring to "Rip Van Marlowe"). Further, *The Long Goodbye* is bookended by the ironic use of "Hooray for Hollywood," which touts the American myths of Hollywood ("any mechanic can be a panic"), into which we could put our faith in genre. We trust in a Hollywood movie that "things" will all work out in the end: good guys vanquish bad guys, the couple unite in rom-coms, the murder mystery is solved, and so on. Even tragedies end as they should, because that is how "things" should work out, such as the couple united in heaven in *Wuthering Heights* (1939) or the man in love with the dream of a dead woman ends up causing the death of the woman he convinced to play the part in *Vertigo* (1958). On rare occasion when the characters failed to reaffirm genre expectations, the filmmakers made sure that the audience knew the answer, as with Rosebud in *Citizen Kane* (1941). It is from this conventional form of "Hollywood" that Altman's and Gould's Marlowe wakes. He drifts through 1970s Los Angeles, not as a real person in a dream, but a dream person in reality. Altman twists neo-noir to fit his satirical intent. In *The Long Goodbye* "things" are not working out. The story does lead to finding out "whodunit," but justice is not served. As quoted earlier, the idea of Marlowe executing Terry Lennox at the end appealed to Altman and that Brackett had provided a suitable new take on the myth of the most famous Los Angeles private detective. Typically, in a Raymond Chandler Philip Marlowe story, most famously *The Big Sleep* (Howard Hawks 1945) and *Murder, My Sweet* (Edward Dmytryk 1946), Marlowe does not kill the bad guys. He stays out of the way as they kill each other—and then ends up with a reformed femme fatale. For Altman and Brackett, things do not work out so neatly in early 1970s—institutions, like genres, are not to be trusted. In confronting the illicit affairs and abusive behaviors of the contemporary world, Altman's Marlowe executes one of its primary instigators, Terry Lennox, and returns to his dream, his "Hooray for Hollywood." For once, it's not okay with him.

The films that recreate noir also work with the movie-as-dream method. Whereas the Redefinition films identify the dreamer and depict their journey through the dream world, in the Recreation films, the hero emerges from a darkness and the film/dream begins. At the opening of *The Driver*,

the hero appears from the darkness—a utility elevator in a parking garage. As if on a conveyor belt, he ascends from a dark hole and steals a car. In *The Getaway*, Doc (Steve McQueen) emerges from the darkness of a prison corridor and walks out onto the yard. *Rolling Thunder* begins with Ranes' (William Devane) return from Vietnam (he emerges from a plane). Cosmo Vitelli (Ben Gazzara) steps out of the darkness of a nightclub entrance into the street in the opening shot of *The Killing of a Chinese Bookie* (1976). Their emergence from the darkness acts as the catalyst of the dream/film connection.

These heroes act as cyphers, dream projections of 1970s angst. The Driver, for example, becomes a cypher on to which the other characters project their personal psychological demons: the Detective sees him as a "cowboy," bigger than the rules that govern the rest of us; the younger drivers see him as an aspiration; other criminals feel they've achieved a new level of success only to have their work discredited by the Driver (e.g., "you were late," "I don't like guns," "go home"); the two key women in the film see the potential for danger in the Driver. *The Driver* works as a fantasy, and like the characters, we project our fantasy selves upon the film: we battle corrupt institutions not to a victorious point, but to a point of neo-noir success—the corrupt institution fails to corrupt us. The Driver walks away, returning to the darkness at the end. Doc disappears into Mexico in *The Getaway*. Rane survives the shootout he instigated in *Rolling Thunder* and stumbles out into the night. The dream ends with the hero returning to the darkness.

The element of oneiricism ties the films of Hollywood Renaissance Noir together as a distinct group. We dream of idyllic worlds only to find darkness in the world and in ourselves, as does Marlowe in *The Long Goodbye* (and Travis in *Taxi Driver*, and Klute, and Harry Caul in *The Conversation*). Or, our movie dream takes place in a neo-noir world in which irony snatches triumph away and insists we be satisfied with survival, as it does for the Driver (and Doc in *The Getaway* or Eddie Coyle). In the neo-noir of the Hollywood Renaissance, the oneiric state consists of cultural institutions, fundamentally flawed, and the dream is, if not unrealized, severely, and usually violently, compromised. Vietnam never reaches a definitive ending; it just grinds to a halt. Watergate never leads to impeachment; Nixon, already pardoned, resigns and fades away. Charles Manson ends up in jail, but the dream of freedom and openness gives way to gated communities, seclusion, and elitism. We survive.

What little violence there is in *The Long Goodbye* shocks the viewer and happens quickly. In keeping with the dreamer in the real world of the 1970s, the violence is something one would not see in a Hollywood film of the classic noir era. Marty Augustine hits his girlfriend, Jo Ann, in the face with a bottle, which shocks Marlowe as much as it shocks the audience as we see it happen on-screen, not in an off-screen style as happens, for example, when Lee Marvin throws hot coffee in Gloria Grahame's face in *The Big Heat* (1953). Augustine then tells Marlowe, "Now that's someone I love! And you I don't even like." And at the end, Marlowe shoots down Terry Lennox, complete with spurting blood squibs and slow motion. Robert Kolker (2011) points out:

Altman is one of the few American filmmakers who examines the results of the violent act, which more often than not only reaffirms the state that existed previous to it. The act of violence alters nothing. (397)

Later in *The Long Goodbye*, a confrontation between Marlowe and Marty Augustine occurs in Augustine's office; Jo Ann, with her face in bandages and her jaw wired, joins them. Augustine uses some therapy-speak as he works out why he hit Jo Ann ("I was taking out on her what I should have been giving you"), which he does not see as a problem (this dialogue about hitting Jo Ann is not in the 1972 screenplay). Altman's ideas about violence aligns with the sense of a more personal, up-close violence ("That's someone I love"). For a moment, Jo Ann and Marlowe are alone together. Marlowe says casually to her, "A lot of entertainment for five grand." The most violent act in the film has little, if any, repercussions for the characters.

The Driver contains multiple action scenes, mostly car chases, and very little violence. The Driver kills two of the robbers that betray him, by shooting each with a pistol. The first one the Driver shoots works as a surprise, because the lead robber believes the Driver never carries a gun. The one moment of violence that resonates with Hollywood Renaissance Noir happens when one of the robbers goes to the Connection (Ronee Blakley) for information about the Driver and ends up killing her by quickly placing a pillow over her face and shooting her. As with *The Long Goodbye*, the most violent act is quick and startling—and inflicted upon a woman's face and on-screen. The violence in Hollywood Renaissance Noir has advanced beyond what was seen in *Point Blank*, considered extremely violent in 1967. On-screen violence was at the forefront in the

1970s, in the wake of *The Wild Bunch* and *Straw Dogs* (Sam Peckinpah 1971) and *A Clockwork Orange* (Stanley Kubrick 1971). Altman's take seems unique among filmmakers of the 1970s, because his violence, as seen in *The Long Goodbye*, may be the saddest of all. Nothing changes because of violence. For Kolker, Altman seems to ask: if "the act [of killing] is appalling, then why are we not appalled by other acts just like it in our cinema?" (397). Again, Altman leads us to question the genre and our genre expectations.

The Driver, on the other hand, substitutes action for violence and only briefly touches upon the up-close, personal violence directed at women. This style of violence dominates the Recreation films. The women in *The Driver*, for example, inconsequential players in a male competition, demonstrate the lack of importance of women in Hollywood Renaissance Noir. It appears the male heroes of Hollywood Renaissance Noir prefer action to the company of women, a strange, frustrated shift of sexual potency. The Driver expresses himself through cars. In *Rolling Thunder*, women and families take a backseat to Rane's revenge mission. Travis' impotency with the campaign worker (Cybill Shepherd) in *Taxi Driver* leads to a suicidal assault in a whore house to save the child prostitute (Jodie Foster). The Hollywood Renaissance Noir directors and writers, especially the ones working in the Recreation mode, depict violence and blood lust, typically revenge for a murdered woman, as a sexually tinged form of release from an oppressive "institution." The directors and writers of Redefinition mode use the violence as a means to comment on the sadness of the contemporary culture, as Marty Augustine exemplifies in *The Long Goodbye*, as do the murders in *The Parallax View* (dissenters eliminated), as well as murders hidden by the corporate entity in *The Conversation*. With Redefinition or Recreation established, the knowledgeable neo-noir viewer adjusts expectations about themes concerning violence.

Expectations about neo-noir also influence the deconstruction of visual style in Hollywood Renaissance Noir, which add to the sense of distance between the viewer and the film. Altman, Gould, and Brackett make empathy with Marlowe difficult in *The Long Goodbye*, and the visual style adds emphasis. Much has been made of Altman's direction of Vilmos Zsigmond's camera work (Kolker, Pomerance). While Kolker establishes the camera work as appropriate for the noir tradition, he does not deal with its odd point of view (POV), which also adds to the distance. The camera seems to be moving with almost every shot, yet the movement is

not attributable to Marlowe; it is not his POV. Rather, the camera seems to prowl the scene, finding subjects. For example, in the opening, the camera moves around Marlowe's apartment until it finds him in bed and the cat awakens him. The camera looks out of Marlowe's apartment, over to the topless women practicing yoga, but the shots never "belong" to Marlowe, as he may pass through the shot (as he does in the opening scene), or the camera may find the window in the scene where the cops show up and we see the cops look over at the women, but, again, the shot doesn't "belong" to anyone, nor does it allow us any special viewer privilege. In Altman's words, the camera movement was "arbitrary" (Thompson 77). Murray Pomerance interprets the camera work thus: "A mo[b]ile camera involves the viewer not merely in the dramatic unfoldings but also, and more intrinsically, in the perceptual engagement with cinematic space; so that through its agency the viewer has the sense of entering the film physically" (236). Hence, the viewer is not privy to Marlowe's POV; rather, the camera puts us in the same space as Marlowe while things happen. The camera work, Gould's idiosyncratic performance, and Brackett's reworking of the story structure all contribute to the distance. Forcing our attention elsewhere, usually back to genre and its lack of trustworthiness. Altman baits our neo-noir expectations, but leads us not to affirmation, but to redefinition.

Altman's visual style toys with nostalgia, but nostalgia never comes to fruition. Zsigmond's moody cinematography touches on classic noir elements, like Marlowe's 1948 Lincoln Continental, the police station, and the night shots in various Los Angeles locales, but is balanced by many visual reminders that this is not the 1940s, but the 1970s, a time at odds with the earlier era. Marlowe's apartment building, the Broadview Terrace accessed by the High Tower elevator (Graham), is of the 1940s era, but what the ladies are doing is of the 1970s. Similarly, the Wades' beach house seems to be of the classic era, but the music and pot smoking evoke the 1970s. The visual style contains a dual, satirical purpose: to evoke a lost era while simultaneously criticizing the current (as of the film's making) era. Altman's visual style in *The Long Goodbye* amplifies his satirical engagement with the 1970s, the oneiric state, and the ambivalent hero (Fig. 3.2).

Another aspect of Altman toying with the tropes of classic noir lies with the almost-femme fatale character, Eileen Wade (Nina van Pallandt). The neglected wife having an affair of her own resonates with Chandler's other work, yet Altman diffuses her sense of allure, mystery, and danger. Marlowe



Fig. 3.2 The 1940s in the 1970s. *The Long Goodbye*, Robert Altman, dir., 1973, Kino Lorber Blu-ray

does a job for her and she seems interested in him, but she springs no femme fatale plot. Marlowe stays on the sideline and comments on the characters. The most telling being *The Third Man*-like ending. Eileen drives toward Marlowe and her rendezvous with the now-dead Terry Lennox. Marlowe passes her without acknowledging her presence, preferring to play with his mini-harmonica. Whereas the ending of *The Third Man* underscores a deep irony and sadness, in *The Long Goodbye*, Marlowe seems irreverent—happy to be released from machinations of the 1970s and Eileen an impotent femme fatale. Again, Altman uses the classic tropes to skewer the modern context.

On the other hand, Hill builds a visual style in *The Driver* out of classic noir tropes, ones that evoke its filmic origins, yet never evoke nostalgia. Perhaps because of budget (the Recreation mode consistently working with B-movie budgets), films of the Recreation mode rely on a straight-ahead, no frills style. Absent are the intricate camera moves and diffusion techniques of Altman and Zsigmond and the expensive locations of *The Parallax View* (e.g., the opening assassination scene atop Seattle's Space Needle) or *Klute* (New York City location shooting). Hill lets the location determine the visual style. Hill sets *The Driver* in downtown Los Angeles, mostly the industrial neighborhoods and low-rent bars and hotels. Outside the action sequences, the camera rarely moves. The shot compositions are uniformly functional and basic. Compare the intricacy of the scene in *The Long Goodbye* when Marty Augustine and his crew come by Marlowe's

apartment (multiple shots, moving camera) to the scene in *The Driver* where the Detective comes by the Driver's hotel room—a single shot scene with a static camera. A similar no-frills approach dominates *Rolling Thunder*. Peckinpah elevates this no-frills style in *The Getaway*. Peckinpah periodically breaks down the space in which the story takes place into masterful series of individual shots. For example, the opening prison scene consists of beautifully edited shots of the rural prison, the grounds, the prisoners, and the labyrinth of walls and fences, into which Steve McQueen naturally fits. And, of course, the signature use of slow motion in the action sequences also “signs” *The Getaway* as a Peckinpah film.

Though no-frills and straight-ahead, evocative moments in the recreation mode and *The Driver* exist. Hill demonstrates a visual style with the functional depiction of the story space in *The Driver* with the scene in the underground parking garage where the Driver shows what he can do. Hill calls this the “Exhibition” scene (Hewitt; Screenplay 44). The Driver whips a Mercedes around the garage, smashing it up against walls and support posts. A door gets torn off, fenders get ripped off, and the car, though thoroughly demolished at the end, still operates. The action stems from the Driver's manipulation of the car within the confines of the parking garage. The scene becomes memorable because of the combination of story, functional cinematography, and editing (and a bit of joy in watching someone masterfully destroy an expensive Mercedes). In *The Driver*, Hill's visual style centers around the characters' interaction with the transitory spaces (parking garages, streets, bars, rundown hotels) that evoke the neo-noir. Peckinpah works in a similar fashion in *The Getaway*, as does John Flynn with *Rolling Thunder*. In *The Long Goodbye*, the visual style reaffirms the ownership of spaces, like Marlowe's apartment, Augustine's office, the Wade's home, etc., and little of the action takes place in transitory spaces like streets or hotels. Similar visual style appears in *Klute*, *The Conversation*, and *The Parallax View*. The two modes deploy visual techniques for different visual styles that reinforce their mode within the Hollywood Renaissance Noir movement. Whereas visual style separates the two modes, the portrayal of women and the femme fatale unites the two modes (Fig. 3.3).

This idea will appear in other movements of neo-noir in the post-classical Hollywood: Hollywood Renaissance Noirs deal with the femme fatale by not dealing with her—but they do it in a unique fashion. The femme fatale, a woman of power and means, with an ability to control the male hero, is conspicuously absent from Hollywood Renaissance Noir.



Fig. 3.3 The characters in transitory spaces. *The Driver*, Walter Hill, dir., 1978, 20th Century-Fox DVD

During the early 1970s, neo-noirs that I categorize as Nostalgia Noirs (films made in the 1970s but set in era of classic noir) do depict the femme fatale because of the requirements of Nostalgia. But with the Redefinition and Recreation modes, the writers and directors stayed clear of the femme fatale. Scorsese, Schrader, Coppola, Hill, Peckinpah, and Altman, to a lesser extent, are not going to develop into women's filmmakers. The idea of a powerful woman remained an anathema to these writers and directors. Scorsese would struggle with women's roles during this period, occasionally finding some success with films like *Alice Doesn't Live Here Anymore* (1974) and *New York, New York* (1977); Altman would find strong roles for women on occasion in the 1970s, as with Julie Christie in *McCabe and Mrs. Miller* (1971) and many of the women's roles in *Nashville* (1975), but Schrader, Peckinpah, and Hill avoided powerful women and thereby amplified the "distance" in this movement between the audience and the films. Women have a presence in the films of Schrader, Peckinpah, and Hill, but not as characters of power. Many of the prominent women in these films function to empower men. Betsy (Cybill Shepherd) works on the presidential campaign of Charles Palantine, in *Taxi Driver*. She comes to represent Travis' sexual assimilation fantasy, which goes awry, leading Travis to a suicide mission to save Iris, the teen prostitute (another woman empowering men) from Sport's (Harvey

Keitel) pimps. In *The Getaway*, Carol (Ali MacGraw) makes the deal with the Texas gangster to get Doc out of prison. Her role becomes standard “girlfriend” fare as the couple goes on the run, but later we find out she betrayed Doc to the gangsters, but now in love with Doc again, she feels bad and returns to helping him. Perhaps the most complete avoidance of powerful women occurs in *The Driver*. The Connection sets up jobs for the Driver and is killed for it. The Player ends up with the Driver and in all their scenes together they merely perform their roles—no emotional spark occurs; no hint of romance can be detected. She, the Player, does the job she was hired to do.

The lack of powerful women in Hollywood Renaissance Noir provides the last key ingredient for the “distance” between audience and film in this movement. With the male leads we get ambivalence in two forms: sarcastic satire, as with Altman and Gould’s Marlowe, and exaggerated archetypes. *The Driver*, according to Patterson, features a “near-mythic battle between characters so archetypal they don’t have names.” With this we mix in women’s roles with a distinct lack of power, the styles of violence, and the combustion creates that feeling of distance. With *The Driver* it resonates from lack of heat between the Driver and the Player—not off-putting but also not compelling. With *The Long Goodbye* it comes to the scene where Marty Augustine breaks the bottle across Jo Ann’s face. The moment startles us out of the laconic and satirical funk Altman has established, but it does not pull us into the narrative or the characters’ sympathy. Instead, the moment reminds of us of the corruption of our own ideas about entertainment. In other words, it re-enforces the distance between the viewer and the film. Similarly, we’re made uneasy by the child prostitution in *Taxi Driver*, along with Travis’ inept attempt at taking Betsy on a movie date (he takes her to a porno grindhouse), and then the violent rampage that ensues (Schrader uses a similar process in *Rolling Thunder* and *Hardcore*). Also working in the dangerous area of child sexuality is Arthur Penn’s *Night Moves* (1975). Melanie Griffith has multiple nude scenes. She was 17 when the nude scenes were shot in 1975 and 15 when the non-nude scenes were shot in 1973 (Hinson). *Night Moves* is a sophisticated neo-noir by a filmmaker keenly in tune with 1970s, but it requires we watch nude scenes that push legal limits. Situating the audience in that uncomfortable space dominates Hollywood Renaissance Noir. Kolker points out in his discussion of *Night Moves* an idea that applies to many of these films, “the form does not function merely to make the viewer share Harry’s darkness and despair, but to indicate the difficulties of seeing and knowing

clearly anything about anyone. This perceptual murkiness extends to the character's insights about himself and the viewer's understanding of him" (52). Again, a distance exists between the film and its audience—we do not see the male detective/hero as a surrogate for ourselves, but as character, with a film history, moving through a new age of filmmaking, often wandering into dangerous territory, facing neo-noir obstacles, but rarely overcoming them. More appropriate for the 1970s' corruptions of Watergate and Vietnam, and aftershock of assassinations and murders, they simply survive, perhaps better for it, perhaps not. Much of the ambiguity, and distance, of the films required that solutions be denied to the audience, as with the final image of *Night Moves*: a boat named *Point of View* just goes around in circles as the camera pulls away.

APPENDIX

Hollywood Renaissance Noir Film List

Redefined Neo-Noir

- Klute* (1971), d. Alan J. Pakula
- The Anderson Tapes* (1971), d. Sidney Lumet
- The Long Goodbye* (1973), d. Robert Altman (Raymond Chandler novel adaptation)
- Mean Streets* (1973), d. Martin Scorsese
- The Conversation* (1974), d. Francis Ford Coppola (original screenplay by Coppola)
- The Parallax View* (1974), d. Alan J. Pakula
- Night Moves* (1975), d. Arthur Penn
- Taxi Driver* (1976), d. Martin Scorsese (original screenplay by Paul Schrader)
- The Late Show* (1977), d. Robert Benton (original screenplay by Benton)
- Who'll Stop the Rain* (1978), d. Karel Reisz

Recreated Neo-Noir

- The Getaway* (1972), d. Sam Peckinpah (Jim Thompson novel adaptation by Walter Hill)
- Vanishing Point* (1971), d. Richard C. Sarafian
- Prime Cut* (1972), d. Michael Ritchie
- The Friends of Eddie Coyle* (1973), d. Peter Yates

- Death Wish* (1974), d. Michael Winner
Bring Me the Head of Alfredo Garcia (1974), d. Sam Peckinpah
The Outfit (1974), d. John Flynn (adaptation of a Richard Stark “Parker” novel by Flynn)
Busting (1974), d. Peter Hyams (original screenplay by Hyams)
The Yakuza (1974), d. Sydney Pollack (original screenplay by Paul Schrader, rewrites by Robert Towne)
Hustle (1975), d. Robert Aldrich
The Killing of a Chinese Bookie (1976), d. John Cassavetes (original screenplay by Cassavetes)
Rolling Thunder (1977), d. John Flynn (original screenplay by Paul Schrader)
Straight Time (1978), d. Ulu Grosbard
The Driver (1978), d. Walter Hill (original screenplay by Hill)
Hardcore (1979), d. Paul Schrader (original screenplay by Schrader)

Notes on the Lists

While *Taxi Driver* has all the markings of modern B-movie, it transcends the Recreation category. Martin Scorsese’s direction, faithful to Schrader’s script, elevates the material to a level of art cinema. The directorial technique, De Niro’s performance, the look of the violence, and much more effectively redefine the genre in which it works—neo-noir. Paul Schrader’s other films, both as a screenwriter and director, *Rolling Thunder* and *Hardcore* in particular, fall into the Recreation category. *Rolling Thunder* for the purity of its B-movie qualities (similar material to *Taxi Driver* but without the transcendence). *Hardcore*, despite its risqué subject matter, enacts traditional tropes with its every-man hero saving the girl plot lifted out of *The Searchers* (much more apparent than *Taxi Driver* and much less violent). Note, too, in Schrader’s writing and directing, these films contain a clear “noir decision.”

Some of these films barely qualify as noir. Consider films like *The Outfit* and *Prime Cut*, which focus on professional bad guys, who are hired to do a job that typically doesn’t go as planned. They react as professionals, not as someone going over to the “dark side.” The good bad guy, to me, acting as a professional diffuses the noir quality. They owe more to the crime film genre than they do to neo-noir.

Notice, too, that the Redefine Noirs all qualify as A-movies. And the Recreate Noirs generally work as B-movies.

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CHAPTER 4

Eighties Noir

Key Films

American Gigolo (1980), d. Paul Schrader

Miami Vice season one (1984–1985), prod. Anthony Yerkovich,
Michael Mann

Jagged Edge (1985), d. Richard Marquand

To Live and Die in L.A. (1985), d. William Friedkin

Manhunter (1986), d. Michael Mann

Blue Velvet (1986), d. David Lynch

House of Games (1987), d. David Mamet

Sea of Love (1989), d. Harold Becker

The election of Ronald Reagan in 1980 signaled a societal and cultural shift in America. The experimental, exploratory “Me Generation” of the 1970s ended. In its place, a more conservative view of the country took hold. By the mid-1980s, social and cinematic forces aligned for a cycle of films forming an Eighties Noir, a response “singular in time as it is in space” (Borde and Chaumeton 5). By 1980, *Raging Bull* (Martin Scorsese) sign-posted the end of the Hollywood Renaissance. Of Hollywood Renaissance Noirs, Paul Schrader’s *Hardcore* (1979) possessed the grit and distance of that distinct movement, but Schrader’s *American Gigolo* (1980) marked a new direction and style. The New Hollywood era of blockbuster hits began fragmenting with a discernable difference between the franchise products associated with Steven Spielberg and George Lucas,

such as the *Star Wars* franchise, the Indiana Jones films, and the *Back to the Future* trilogy and the packaged films from mega-producers, like Bruckheimer and Simpson, Joel Silver, Jon Peters and Peter Guber, and David Putnam. Many of the mega-producers relied on a second wave of a British Invasion for directors (avoiding high-priced American auteurs), including Adrian Lyne, Ridley Scott, Tony Scott (Ridley's younger brother), Alan Parker, and Hugh Hudson. Fragmentation of genres and modes of production and distribution were in full swing (e.g., the ascendancy of VHS and Betamax tape). From this developing mosaic of fragments, Eighties Noir emerges as a significant and possibly solitary counter-current movement to the mainstream genres of the time, most of which, the exception being some horror films, reaffirmed the institutions of Reagan's America (government, military, family, religion, etc.). A disparate group of filmmakers created a cohesive Eighties Noir as they worked with similar visual styles and found a similar purpose in neo-noir: exploring the dark side of Reagan's America. The other genres, in the words of Reagan's 1985 inaugural speech, "pass[ed] that dream on to a waiting and hopeful world." Eighties Noir looked into much darker possibilities.

A core group of films and television programs exemplifies Eighties Noir and will provide the focus of this chapter: the first season of *Miami Vice* (Michael Mann, executive producer, 1984–1985), *To Live and Die in L.A.* (William Friedkin, 1985), *Blue Velvet* (David Lynch, 1986), and *Manhunter* (Michael Mann, 1986). As with previous chapters, see the more complete list in the appendix of this chapter. Eighties Noirs establish a unique vision, a response to the Eighties as singular time, in which Reagan affirmed, "It's morning again in America," but Eighties Noir insisted, "You are not safe."

The action-adventure franchises of Stallone, Schwarzenegger, Norris, and Bronson dominated the mainstream genres of the mid-1980s (Thompson 1986, 64). Provoked by a nemesis, usually non-American, the action-adventure hero reasserts and reaffirms Reaganesque values. For example, the *Rambo* and *Missing in Action* films re-win Vietnam. President Reagan pardons Rambo in *Rambo: First Blood, Part II* (1985), and the film, according to Jeffords, revives "the promise of masculinity itself" (1989, 138). Croteau and Hoynes (2003) add the outlook of these films shares "part of the appeal of Ronald Reagan, whose campaign for president in 1980 called for a return to a sense of national pride, strength, and purpose that would move the nation beyond 'the Vietnam Syndrome'" (175). Parshall (1991) identifies traditional values in *Die Hard*, making a

key point about the character Al, a gun-shy cop, who shoots and kills Euro-terrorist Karl at the end. McClane looks at Al, “giving his official hero’s approval to this act [...] the film, after exalting the renegade cop throughout, cleverly turns law enforcement back over to the legitimate cop” (Parshall 141).

“Spielberg projects” also dominated the mid-1980s (Thompson, 64). The films Spielberg directed uniformly emphasize the reunification of families: *E.T.: The Extra-Terrestrial* (1982), the “Kick the Can” episode of *The Twilight Zone* (1983), *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom* (1984), *The Color Purple* (1985), *The Empire of the Sun* (1987), and *Indiana Jones and the Last Crusade* (1989). The films on which he served solely as a producer, such as *Poltergeist* (1982), *Gremlins* (1984), *The Goonies* (1985), and the *Back to the Future* trilogy (1985–1990), also bear this theme, along with exaltations of suburbia and the middle class (the “silent majority”), the 1950s (the good ole days), and technology (the “Star Wars” defense initiative).

Youth films, too, demonstrate a return to traditional values. Whereas youth films of the ‘50s, ‘60s, and ‘70s portrayed young people questioning the values of the previous generations, in the mid-1980s young people worked out their differences and families reunited. The most prominent are John Hughes films, such as *The Breakfast Club* (1985) and *Ferris Bueller’s Day Off* (1986). Even across the subgenres, as Timothy Shary (2002) explains, “films in the late twentieth century depicted teenagers as an increasingly self-aware and insightful group” (261). Even in the few films that vilify teenagers, “at least one teenage character retains some sense of integrity or morality” (Shary 261). Young people, once the voice of the anti-establishment and anti-status quo, in the 1980s exemplified establishment integrity and morality.

The mainstream genres of the mid-1980s also relied on the conventional narrative structure of upsetting a status quo only to put it back together in ways that embraced the cultural hegemony of Reagan’s America: the jingoism of *Top Gun* (1986), the re-strengthened families of John Hughes films, the adoration and trust in technology in Spielberg films, and the reevaluation of law enforcement in *Die Hard*. Eighties Noir uses the same narrative structure to propel a noir hero into a dark state of being and demonstrates the false dream state embedded in the ideology of reaffirmation.

Compare the representation of law enforcement and family in *Blue Velvet* and *Manhunter* with action-adventure films like *Die Hard*. Will

Graham of *Manhunter* and Jeffrey Beaumont of *Blue Velvet* find themselves stuck between families as the victims of evil (e.g., Frank's victims and Dolarhyde's victims) and families as a root of evil (e.g., Frank's "family" and Dolarhyde's background). In *Manhunter*, Michael Mann juxtaposes the scene of FBI Agent Crawford coercing Graham back into an investigation involving a home invader who murders families with Graham and his stepson repairing a pen protecting spawning turtles. Jeffrey finds evidence of another family torn apart and over the course of his obsession/investigation ingratiates himself into Sandy's family—Sandy's father being the detective heading up the investigation. In the first episodes of *Miami Vice*, Crockett struggles with his status as a divorced father and the corruption of a family friend. Family haunts Eighties Noir heroes and connects the hero to the nemesis. *Die Hard*, on the other hand, as Parshall points out, dodges "a revolutionary step and reaffirms the traditional nuclear family and 'standard' male/female roles" (139).

In returning to his family, the Eighties Noir hero saves them from the institution that fails to protect families. Government institutions, usually law enforcement, become metaphors for other Reagan-era institutions failing to deliver the promised dream (e.g., technologically advanced military, church, corporations). For example, during Iran-Contra, the public discovered the Reagan administration supported agents donning masks to become the evil force they sought to vanquish (e.g., selling arms to terrorists). Oliver North's testimony revealed covert operations within covert operations and his insistence that he never acted without orders from above, specifically the Reagan administration. Eighties Noir responded to this "certain mood" when other genres would not. The failure of institutions forms the core of the Eighties Noir hero's ambivalence. In some fashion, the institution fails the hero serving it: law enforcement ruins Crockett's marriage, the FBI cannot shield Graham's family from Lecktor or Dolarhyde, the Treasury Department won't help Chance avenge the murder of his partner, and local law enforcement fails to stop Frank in *Blue Velvet*. In part, the hero's descent into the noir world comes from a realization of the failure of institutions.

The Eighties Noir narrative opens with a status quo of corruption and crime. When called to action, the Eighties Noir hero descends into a world that fuels his obsession (noir decision) and, generally, involves the hero's ability/inability to discern the real from the "other." This "other," corrupted dream, and the hero's obsessive behavior within it, becomes the vehicle for the filmmakers' critique of Eighties society, especially through

juxtaposition to the hero's insulated world and the darker world into which he descends. In *To Live and Die in L.A.*, Chance (William L. Petersen) moves from Reagan's secret service team to the aptly metaphorical underworld of counterfeiters. In *Blue Velvet*, Jeffrey's (Kyle MacLachlan) obsessions propel him into Frank's world, where sexual libido runs amok. In the *Miami Vice* pilot, Tubbs (Philip Michael Thomas) leaves the New York police force and acts as a vigilante in the drug world of Miami, where he meets Crockett (Don Johnson), who, personal life in shambles, obsesses over catching a drug kingpin responsible for his partner's death and the corruption of a family friend. *Manhunter*, Simon (1987) explains:

problematicizes and foregrounds some of the issues of the obsessions of a visual media-obsessed society (of which the film's "schizophrenic" visual quality is itself both a part and a potential critique), then the last section of the film re-establishes some trust in the visual aspects of communication. (8)

Also, we can find definition in the noir hero by looking at the nemesis. In Eighties Noir, the core films emphasize nemeses obsessed with an art that drives or torments their ambition. Many Eighties Noirs set up a doppelganger relationship between the hero and the nemesis. Rick Masters, in *To Live and Die in L.A.*, paints abstract portraits, which, the film's art critic explains, are "quite good." Dolarhyde builds a fantasy existence around William Blake's "The Great Red Dragon and the Woman Clothed with the Sun." Music, like Roy Orbison's "In Dreams," fuels Frank's fantasy in *Blue Velvet*. The nemeses live in dream worlds, confusing depravity with art. The nemesis possesses a simple goal: make the dream world real. Eighties Noir depicts complacency and depravity aided by media/technology (TV screen imagery appears in *Manhunter*, *To Live and Die in L.A.*, and *Blue Velvet*), with nemeses existing comfortably before the hero's arrival: Graham had recently caught Dr. Hannibal Lecktor, and Dolarhyde had been working on a "lunar cycle" for some time before the movie's start; Frank, *Blue Velvet* suggests, corrupted the police and community for quite some time before the story begins; and similar suggestions of longevity exist for the nemeses in *Miami Vice* (Calderone's drug empire) and *To Live and Die in L.A.* (Masters as a veteran counterfeiter). The nemeses do not spring upon us from the outside (as the Libyan terrorists in *Back to the Future* or "Euro-trash" terrorists in *Die Hard*), but emerge from

within, an emergence associated with a sex-tainted media obsession. Mainstream genres prefer xenophobia and cast the blame on “others.”

Eighties Noir prefers exposing the dream with narratives producing damaged heroes, who become, like their classic noir counterparts, icons of an ideology of bitter reality. A key to their iconic status is an Eighties Noir emphasis on assumed identities (or “going undercover”). Assuming identities allows the heroes to play out the greater society’s visual media obsession in microcosm. Jeffrey, in *Blue Velvet*, poses as a bug exterminator (amplifying a bug motif from the beginning of the film) to Dorothy Vallens’ apartment. Graham, the hero of *Manhunter*, for example, reaches a near-Zen state through obsessive research and fascination with the pictures and home movies of the murdered families. Dolarhyde’s (Tom Noonan) “becoming” never reaches fruition because Graham *becomes* first and becomes the weapon to stop Dolarhyde. *To Live and Die in L.A.* suggests an even darker “becoming”: Chance, while undercover as a corrupt real estate developer, literally has his face blown off (face/mask motifs and their destruction appear in all the core group films). Vukovich (John Pankow), Chance’s new partner, escapes and follows Masters (Willem Dafoe) to his studio. Masters almost kills Vukovich, but a fire starts and Masters immolates himself. In the denouement, obsession and corruption grow beyond systemic, becoming transcendent and self-perpetuating. Vukovich becomes Chance, bearing his mask of sunglasses, three-day beard, leather jacket, and insolent swagger (Fig. 4.1).

Eighties Noir use the face-mask motif to further an analogy between the undercover plot device and Eighties visual media obsession. The mask, in Joseph Campbell’s (1959) words, is “revered and experienced as a veritable apparition of the mythical being it represents—even though everyone knows that a man made the mask and that a man is wearing it” (21). In *Blue Velvet*, Jeffrey wears a new mask of domesticity at the end, returning to the opening images of the film. David Lynch created the most provocative and ambitious Eighties Noir, because viewing *Blue Velvet* and working through the narrative becomes analogous to being the hero in an Eighties Noir. The viewer experiences the disjunction between seeing and interpreting the controlled barrage of disturbing images. If the viewer “gets” the film, he or she is not returned to the status quo of Reagan’s America because the viewer understands the masks worn by the characters. Those who fail to “get” the film reject the movie and return to the assurance of mainstream genres. Lynch thereby acknowledges the mask effect of popular culture and challenges the cultural hegemony in the form of



Fig. 4.1 Transcendence. Vukovich becomes Chance. *To Live and Die in L.A.*, William Friedkin, 1985, Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer, Inc., DVD

genre expectation. In *To Live and Die in L.A.*, the masks get blown off and another hero assumes the mask. Mainstream genres never acknowledge the masks characters wear, because revealing the mask reveals the dream as a dream and challenges rather than affirms status quo. The Eighties Noir hero, filled with ambivalence, comes to understand their role in the dream.

As Borde and Chaumeton guided, noir evokes an oneiric, or dream, state, in which the noir hero exists. The “dream” becomes a key to understanding Eighties Noir as a reaction to its cultural context. In a media-obsessed society, especially in the mid-1980s with MTV at the height of its dominance, cable television reaching new levels of penetration and offering more choices, and VCRs offering the ability to keep, skip, and delete programming, Eighties Noir equates the monster to be not within the media but within our sex-tinted obsession with it, its make-believe surface, and our vain attempts to control it.

Unlike other movements, Eighties Noir does not rely on narrators, none uses voice-over, and the narrative point of view is fairly unrestricted. *Manhunter*, *Miami Vice*, and *To Live and Die in L.A.* often cut away from the heroes and follow the nemeses. *Blue Velvet* stays with Jeffrey for most of its duration. Yet, an oneiric state dominates each of these feature films and many episodes of the first season of *Miami Vice*. In *Manhunter*, Graham lives an idyllic life of retirement in a modern home on a Florida

beach. Because of his empathic skills, his former FBI superior, Jack Crawford (Dennis Farina), asks Graham to rejoin the FBI and advise them on catching a serial killer known as the Tooth Fairy. Later in film, Graham and Crawford argue about the case, and Graham alludes to the oneiric and its media-obsessive quality:

Graham: ... I gave it up! Until you showed up with pictures of two dead families knowing goddamned well that I'd imagine families three, four, five, and six. Right?

Crawford: You're fuckin' right I did it! And I'd do it again!

What Graham senses from the beginning is that the oneiric state he "imagines" does not belong to him. It belongs to the Tooth Fairy, Francis Dolarhyde, a photo-processing worker in the St. Louis area. Dolarhyde's scenes, like Graham's scenes, focus on process. We never see Dolarhyde murder the families; we only see him working on his preparations. Through Graham's investigations we see the evidence of the murders, which is focused on photographs and home movies—the media that fuels Graham's obsession. When we're with Dolarhyde, we learn that he dreams of "becoming" the Great Red Dragon of Blake's painting. Like Masters in *To Live and Die in L.A.*, Dolarhyde's "art" involves redefining himself. Part of the process includes the murder of the families through the act of home invasion, where he arranges the bodies to "witness" his becoming, a perverted performance art. Graham exists in an elite world of law enforcement that knows the security and privilege that comes with an upper middle-class lifestyle does not guarantee your safety, no matter how hard one works to achieve that "dream." For Graham, the battleground is within Dolarhyde's dreams. To understand Dolarhyde's attempts to achieve his dream world, Graham turns to Dr. Lecttor, the famous serial killer/cannibal. Dr. Lecttor torments Graham but also mentors him as they sift through the evidence. Lecttor understands, like Graham, the necessity of recognizing the serial killer's dream world. For example, Lecttor, having seen a file on some of the evidence, deduces:

Dr. Lecttor: This is a very shy boy, Will. What were the yards like?

Graham: Big backyards. Fences. Hedges. Why?

Dr. Lecttor: Because, my dear, Will, if this pilgrim imagines he has a relationship with the moon, he might go outside to look at it. Have you ever seen blood in the moonlight, Will? It appears

quite black. If one were nude, it would be better to have privacy for this sort of thing.

Graham: That's interesting.

Dr. Lecktor: No, it's not. You thought of it before.

Graham: I considered it.

Dr. Lecktor: You came here to look at me, to get the old scent back, didn't you?

At the end of the film, where Michael Mann's screenplay diverges dramatically away from Thomas Harris' novel, Graham finally enters Dolarhyde's dream world. The dreamer is vanquished—in dying Dolarhyde takes on the look of the Red Dragon he has admired as the blood pattern looks like wings. Graham, with his face scared, returns to his family at the beach to resume his version of the perilous dream.

Similarly, Jeffrey of *Blue Velvet*, having stumbled, willingly, into Frank's dream world, another built upon invasion of family and home, knows the only way out is to confront his nemesis within the dream. At one point, on a "joy ride," Frank has his boys pull Jeffrey from the car, and while Roy Orbison's "In Dreams" plays, Frank inhales his amyl nitrite, puts on red lipstick, and kisses Jeffrey, and then Frank explains:

Frank: Don't be a good neighbor to her. I'll send you a love letter ... straight from my heart, fucker! Do you know what a love letter is? It's a bullet from a fuckin' gun, fucker! You receive a love letter from me, you're fucked forever. You understand, fuck? I'll send you straight to Hell, fucker! 'In dreams, I walk with you.' 'In dreams, I talk to you.'

In the end, Jeffrey sends the love letter to Frank, and an emotionally scarred Jeffrey returns to his family fully aware of the perilous dream.

In *To Live and Die in L.A.*, Rick Masters defeats Chance, the Treasury agent who has obsessively chased him, only to immolate himself, or allow it to happen—a logical extension of the self-portraits he has been burning. Masters' dream comes to a logical conclusion, but the transcendence of Chance into Vukovich, which Masters seems to recognize, only prolongs the existence of deeply corrupted law enforcement, which endangers anyone and everyone in the pursuit of its goal (e.g., Chance ignores the Wrong Way sign and drives on to the interstate to escape the FBI chasing

him). The corrupt dream, then, transcends the dreamers—like a spirit moving from body to body.

Eighties Noir resolves the narrative complexities by constructing endings with a new status quo, one in which the hero, and by extension the audience, recognizes institutions of Reagan's America as a diversionary dream mistaken for reality. Eighties Noir narratives expose a disjunction between vision and knowledge. The re-established status quo in Eighties Noir included understanding Graham's reclusiveness in *Manhunter*, Jeffrey's suburban haze in *Blue Velvet*, the transcendent rogue agent in *To Live and Die in L.A.*, and the undercover life in *Miami Vice*—all states of living with corruption. Other genres reaffirm the Reagan hegemony by transforming the dream world into reality, thereby hiding the disjunction, or, to paraphrase a famous Oliver North quote, assisting in furthering a version radically different than the truth.

Violence as a theme takes place on two levels in Eighties Noir. The first is implied, or off-screen, and involves the destruction of families. The institutions of 1980s culture, especially wealth and privilege, fail to protect the families of these films. Dolanhyde has killed two families at the opening of *Manhunter*, and Frank has kidnapped Dorothy Vallens' husband and child—and severed the ear from the husband. In the first season of *Miami Vice*, Crockett's police work has ruined his marriage, and in "No Exit" (episode 7), Crockett and Tubbs struggle to protect a woman from her abusive husband (Bruce Willis). The noir heroes in these films and television shows often make that "noir decision" in reaction to the violence inflicted upon a family, such as Agent Crawford's manipulation of Will Graham in *Manhunter* and Jeffrey's fascination with the ear in *Blue Velvet*. But the violence is pushed to off-screen space and becomes a part of the oneiric state that permeates the films. The audience sees the consequences of the violence, presented, usually, as signifiers of the event re-translated into a narrative by the noir hero, as Graham does at the home of second victims as he studies the blood smears on the wall. Jeffrey finds the human ear, and when he turns it over to the police, the lab technician regales Jeffrey with all the information to be gained from the ear.

The other level of violence is performed on-screen. For definition, violence is seen as different than action. Violence in this case has to do with harm/force inflicted on a person. Action, generally, involves stunts, like car chases. Although a stunt could be a fight scene in which serious harm is inflicted. In Eighties Noir, much of violence is directed at faces. *To Live and Die in L.A.* puts much emphasis on it—three characters shot in the

face at close range, Rick Masters, the nemesis, paints large self-portraits of his face, which he lights on fire. At the end of *Manhunter*, Graham has a scar across his face from his fight with Dolarhyde. In *Blue Velvet*, Frank puts on lipstick so he can kiss Jeffrey in a weird assault on Jeffrey's face, and at the end of the film, Jeffrey shoots Frank in the forehead at point blank range. The violence inflicted upon faces returns us to the idea of the character having masks and that these acts of violence in effect strip the mask away, or forever change the mask. In *Blue Velvet*, Jeffrey destroys his doppelganger, Frank, and becomes a sedate version of himself. Graham, in *Manhunter*, has his face altered, a reminder of Dolarhyde. Chance and Master destroy each other and in so doing reveal true identities (Chance's undercover identity is given up and Master's artist identity goes up in flames). For Eighties Noir, the violence inflicted upon faces becomes a harsh metaphorical act of laying bare the truth—often involving the demise of the oneiric state and reinforcement of the you are not safe theme. The violent act is a necessary stage in narrative transformation—the noir hero must cross a violent threshold to arrive in a new world. David Lynch makes Jeffrey's serenity at the end of *Blue Velvet* seem fragile, artificial, as if restoration has anesthetized Jeffrey. The violence at the end of *Manhunter* releases Graham from Dolarhyde's dream world. The spirit of Chance transcends the violence at the end of *To Live and Die in L.A.* to find a new host in Vukovich and an eerie return to the status quo. By comparison to other neo-noir movements, Eighties Noir inflicts the on-screen violence upon men; in other movements, especially the ones that seek to recreate classic noir or pay homage to classic noir, much of violence is inflicted upon women, often the femme fatale character. But the femme fatale is a rarity in Eighties Noir, so the violence shifts to the dreamers.

Oddly, the femme fatale in Eighties Noirs becomes noticeable for her absence. She was a prominent character in soap operas of the time, especially on primetime soaps like *Dynasty*. Schiff (1994) contends men do not want to see femme fatales, suggesting, "Groping for the meaning of masculinity, eighties men may find the broad-shouldered she-wolves of the forties and fifties a bit threatening; how much easier it is to contemplate the innocent, vulnerable sexuality of child-women like Farrah Fawcett, Brooke Shields, and Bo Derek" (32). Eighties Noir rejects the Eighties dream world of "child-women" as the central female roles and forces a reconsideration of the vision of women, because 80s noir nemeses victimize middle- and upper-middle-class wives/mothers. Even Dorothy Vallens, who seems to be a femme fatale early in *Blue Velvet*, ends up being a victimized mother figure, not the lurid temptress.

Dolarhyde obsesses over the wives in *Manhunter*. Frank forces Dorothy into submission by holding her husband and child hostage in *Blue Velvet*. In the “No Exit” episode of *Miami Vice*, Crockett and Tubbs intervene in a surveillance of a weapons supplier when they discover he abuses his wife. The nemeses’ “art” shatters the “dreams” of family. The normalcy of the female victims sets the Eighties Noir movement apart from the mainstream genres, which preferred to fetishize the child-woman of a dream world (e.g., Molly Ringwald in John Hughes’ films).

Classic noir often depicts “frustrated and guilty” women with a penchant for “eroticization of violence” (Borde and Chaumeton 9). Eighties Noir twists eroticized violence to fit the comforts of wealth and complacency. This is particularly strong in *To Live and Die in L.A.* and *Blue Velvet*. Dorothy Vallens, who seems a femme fatale, ends up objectified by Jeffrey’s vision and the viewer’s point of view, which become one and the same. Jeffrey peers through the slats of the closet, seeing Dorothy remove her femme fatale “mask,” revealing her true identity as a mother/wife victim. In *To Live and Die in L.A.*, Masters’ female companion, with whom he makes numerous video recordings of their sex life, distracts men so Masters can enter and inflict violence. Eighties Noir emphasizes Laura Mulvey’s concept of women dominated by the gaze of men. The Eighties Noir nemesis goes a step further with the female victims: after much watching (usually mediated), the nemesis enters “the dream” and murders its inhabitants. Mediated voyeurism figures prominently in *Manhunter*, *To Live and Die in L.A.*, and the “No Exit” episode of *Miami Vice*. Again, the monster is not within the media, but within our sex-tainted obsession with the media/dream. The narratives and characters of Eighties Noir lent themselves to seductive visuals, which, examined carefully, reveal another layer of neo-noir reacting to a moment in history.

Jeremy Butler’s “*Miami Vice*: A Legacy of Film Noir” (1985) first established the distinct visual style of Eighties Noir. Butler points out Miami and Dade County determine the mise-en-scene of *Miami Vice*:

Just as *film noir* is strongly associated with the image of squalid city streets, glistening from a recent rain, *Miami Vice* depends on the imagery of Miami: bleached white beaches, pastel mansions on the water, wide boulevards, crowded ghetto streets, ultra-modern office complexes, and various bodies of water (the ocean, canals, rivers, concrete swimming pools). (133)

Steven Sanders (2007) coins the term “Sunshine Noir” and notes how color and brightly lit spaces replace “classic noir’s urban chiaroscuro”

(185). *Miami Vice* became an important point in an evolution of Eighties Noir visual style, one with its own unique codes, one that questions the complacency of the image, and one that would influence many other Eighties Noirs (Fig. 4.2).

Like classic noir, Eighties Noir borrowed from previous movements and styles to build a new code of neo-noir style. *To Live and Die in L.A.* and *Manhunter* become points of confluence for three major influences to form the Eighties Noir visual style. First, while pastel colors and sun-drenched deco architecture make Eighties Noir visually distinct, much of Eighties Noir takes place at night, but the Eighties Noir night looks different. Some of it is “magic hour,” the hour surrounding sunrise or sunset, when the sun is low to the horizon, casting long shadows, lighting the cloudscape, and in the city, filtering through the pollution to create a gold or reddish glow. The other part of the night is lit by neon and often seen in reflections. The neo-noir world of Eighties Noir casts a glow on its characters, and like the sharp angles of light and high contrast in classic noir, the neon glow amplifies the emotions of the Eighties Noir heroes



Fig. 4.2 Sunshine Noir. “Pilot,” *Miami Vice*, Season One, 1984–1985, Thomas Carter, dir., Universal DVD

and villains. Second, the expressionistic use of architecture and costumes, which begins with Michael Mann's *Thief* (1981), becomes sophisticated. The design work of Ferdinando Scarfiotti, the production designer/visual consultant and colleague of Bernardo Bertolucci, profoundly influences the look of Eighties Noir. Scarfiotti's contributions to Eighties Noir began with Paul Schrader's *American Gigolo* (1980), in which a more subdued color palette washed into noir lighting and composition. Scarfiotti further explored ideas about color and exaggeration in Schrader's *Cat People* (1982). With Brian De Palma's *Scarface* (1983), Scarfiotti demonstrates what *Miami Vice* would exploit: intense whites, pastel colors, and, perhaps most important, the city of Miami. In 1984, the *Miami Vice* pilot merged Scarfiotti's Miami visuals and Mann's ideas about architecture and costumes visualizing thematic aspects of character (Mann was executive producer). In *Scarface*, the designs visualize the opulent world of crime and cocaine, but in *Miami Vice* similar designs evoke Crockett's broken-down life, the futile war against Miami crime, and the surreal space—the dream—in which the warriors do battle. Mann would later enhance this technique of architecture and character in *Manhunter*, using an even more exaggerated pastel palette and expressive structures. For example, compare the clean symmetry of Graham's home with the irregular spaces and clutter of objects in Dolarhyde's home. Lynch opts for more primary colors, but still encodes the Eighties Noir visual style with magic hour shots and expressionistic use of setting and character. Lynch enhances the oneiric state with his visual style. We understand the movie is set in the contemporary world, yet Lynch uses architecture and objects (e.g., cars, television sets) from the 1950s. *Blue Velvet* is itself a strange dream, due in no small part to its visual style (Fig. 4.3).

Rather than ape the visuals of classic noir, Eighties Noir assembled its own style. The look is so specific, so unique, it sets Eighties Noir apart from the less visually distinct concept of neo-noir. Simon, in 1987, noticed the Eighties Noir set itself apart from neo-noir and cites Hal Foster's distinction between "neo-conservative" and "resistant" postmodern art. The neo-conservative art dovetails with our use of Reagan's America and the resistant uses "self-reflexivity in a particular way to comment on the images which pervade contemporary society and/or our obsession with them" (Simon 5). The Eighties Noir visual self-reflexivity makes it unique in neo-noir and amplifies the ideology found in the narratives and characters.

When the cultural times warrant the need for a reactive genre/cycle/movement, Eighties Noir demonstrates how a neo-noir movement fulfills



Fig. 4.3 Dolarhyde's home—the space and objects of his mind. *Manhunter*, Michael Mann, dir., 1986, Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer, Inc., Blu-ray

the purpose of noir by confronting the times in which they were created. Much more so than Transitional Noir or the Hollywood Renaissance Noir, because Eighties Noir created a new, emblematic look. We also see filmmakers operating in analogous situations and creating films that relate to their socio-cultural context in similar ways to how classic film noir operated. The Eighties Noir directors of the core group of films, Michael Mann, William Friedkin, and David Lynch, worked with low budgets and exploitative material, not unlike the conditions of classic noir, and pushed their films to become dissenting voices within the mainstream of genre films. The core group of Eighties Noir directors demonstrates a consistent vision: they question what other genres reaffirm; they reject when other genres reassure. These directors emerge on the heels of the Hollywood Renaissance directors of the 1970s, coming to filmmaking with an education in cinema. The Eighties Noir directors work with the knowledge of the Renaissance directors' achievements, demonstrating that the meta-awareness continually compounds upon itself. At no point do any of the Eighties Noir directors acknowledge that they were aware of working within an emerging movement of Eighties Noir films. The writers and directors (often the same person) worked within the Eighties Noir post-classical context with an acute awareness of their classical precedents, Transitional Noir films, and the work of the Hollywood Renaissance directors, but they also pushed out the basic elements of noir into new territory. And because of the time specification, the movement inevitably ends.

It became another fragment in the mosaic of post-classical Hollywood cinema. Other films may appear to qualify as Eighties Noir, but they are dominated by other factors, such as nostalgia, homage, parody, or recreation, and diffuse their response to the diversionary dream of Reagan's America. Eighties Noirs are singularly focused.

Romantic comedies, sci-fi spectacles, Generation X melodramas, jingoistic military adventures, and the other popular genres, all pieces of the excessive post-classical Hollywood cinema, reassured the increasingly younger audience of a dream world, encouraging complacency with Reaganesque institutions and feeding cultural fantasies: John Hughes' films glamorized upper-middle class geeks and teen angst. *Top Gun* and the *Rambo* films simplified military situations into clear-cut us vs. (usually non-white) them. Twenty-something single women, even Hollywood prostitutes, end up with millionaires, as Julia Roberts does in *Pretty Woman* (1990). And only a few Eighties horror films work their genre as an ideological vehicle (e.g., John Carpenter's *The Thing* [1982] and *They Live* [1988]). Mainstream genres reinforce the hegemony of Reagan's America wherein the dream becomes reality.

Eighties Noir faded as Reagan's America faded. The core films, which enjoy cult status today, were not commercially successful, and only *Blue Velvet* won critical acclaim. *Miami Vice* was very successful and different, as Butler pointed out, from standard cop fare. In its second season, however, it became as sanitized as any mainstream TV cop show. Eighties Noirs excelled between 1984 and 1986, not coincidentally during the apex of Reagan's presidency. Eighties Noir became a true neo-noir movement, rejecting parody, homage, and recreation, in its struggle against the mainstream current. No other time-centered movement of neo-noir is as concerned with its time as is Eighties Noir.

APPENDIX

Eighties Noir Film List

American Gigolo (1980), d. Paul Schrader
Angel of Vengeance/Ms. 45 (1981), d. Abel Ferrara
Cutter's Way (1981), d. Ivan Passer
Bad Boys (1983), d. Richard Rosenthal
Body Double (1984), d. Brian De Palma
Streets of Fire (1984), d. Walter Hill

- Miami Vice* Season One (1984–1985), prod. Anthony Yerkovich,
Michael Mann
- Jagged Edge* (1985), d. Richard Marquand
- Year of the Dragon* (1985), d. Michael Cimino
- To Live and Die in L.A.* (1985), d. William Friedkin
- 52 Pick-Up* (1986), d. John Frankenheimer (Elmore Leonard
adaptation)
- At Close Range* (1986), d. James Foley
- Eight Million Ways to Die* (1986), d. Hal Ashby
- Manhunter* (1986), d. Michael Mann (adaptation of Thomas Harris
novel, *Red Dragon*)
- Blue Velvet* (1986), d. David Lynch
- The Morning After* (1986), d. Sidney Lumet
- No Mercy* (1986), d. Richard Pearce
- Best Seller* (1987), d. John Flynn
- The Big Easy* (1987), d. Jim McBride
- Dead of Winter* (1987), d. Arthur Penn
- Someone to Watch Over Me* (1987), d. Ridley Scott
- House of Games* (1987), d. David Mamet
- The Stepfather* (1987), d. Joseph Ruben
- Cold Steel* (1987), d. Dorothy Ann Puzo
- Frantic* (1988), d. Roman Polanski
- Betrayed* (1988), d. Costa-Gavras
- Masquerade* (1988), d. Bob Swaim
- Call Me* (1988), d. Sollace Mitchell
- Dead-Bang* (1989), d. John Frankenheimer
- Sea of Love* (1989), d. Harold Becker (original screenplay by
Richard Price)
- Black Rain* (1989), d. Ridley Scott
- L.A. Takedown* (1989), d. Michael Mann—TV movie/series pilot
- Cat Chaser* (1989), d. Abel Ferrara
- Dead Calm* (1989), d. Phillip Noyce (Charles Williams adaptation)

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Nineties Noir

Key Films

The Grifters (1990), d. Stephen Frears
Bad Lieutenant (1992), d. Abel Ferrara
Heat (1995), d. Michael Mann
Se7en (1995), d. David Fincher
Bound (1996), d. Larry Wachowski and Andy Wachowski
Lost Highway (1997), d. David Lynch
Jackie Brown (1997), d. Quentin Tarantino
Fight Club (1999), d. David Fincher
The Limey (1999), d. Steven Soderbergh

One way to approach the arrival and formation of Nineties Noir is through the end of the distinctive color and sunshine pallet of the Eighties Noir visual style. Nineties Noir, less distinct visually, fully incorporates the notion of post-classical Hollywood cinema as excessive (many more films qualifying as neo-noir, from many more modes of production) and fragmented (many more types of neo-noir dealing with many more themes), much more so than previous time periods. And yet, when arranging the pieces of this post-classical mosaic, common themes emerge. Even with the excessiveness and fragmentation, these films fully engage the 1990s as a cohesive group. William J. Palmer (2009), in *The Films of the Nineties: The Decade of Spin*, offers a succinct explanation of the 1990s in comparison to the 1970s and 1980s:

If the seventies was the decade of Richard Nixon, Watergate, and Vietnam aftermath, and the eighties was the decade of Ronald Reagan, terrorism, and Yuppie commodity culture, then the nineties was the decade of sex and death and alienation in so many ways (the Clintons, the O.J. Simpsons, AIDS, and racial hatred). (1)

Nineties Noir, as a movement, becomes a mosaic within the larger mosaic of neo-noir. Further, Nineties Noir provides a model for critics attempting to organize neo-noir into chronological movements. The pieces of the movement, those sub-groups of films that coalesce into consistent categories under the rubric of Nineties Noir, form a post-classical representation of neo-noir's operation in the 1990s. And each sub-group engages the 1990s. Finding those elements that tie the films together becomes the job of the noir critic. Therefore, the more complete list of Nineties Noir in the appendix sub-divides into categories such as Adaptations, Police Procedurals, African American Noir, and others.

Each sub-group of Nineties Noir merits its own book, but herein, our attention focuses on the larger concept of neo-noir in the 1990s as a part of the grand scheme of noir cinema in post-classical Hollywood. *Heat* (Michael Mann 1995) and *Jackie Brown* (Quentin Tarantino 1997) provide the primary examples of Nineties Noir. *Heat* represents a sub-category of films often identified as Police Procedural (more simplistically: cops and robbers). This is not to claim that all Police Procedurals qualify as neo-noir. Just like the hard-boiled detective, Police Procedurals exist as an established genre. However, some Police Procedurals, like some hard-boiled detective works, qualify as neo-noir. What differentiates the Police Procedural that aspires to neo-noir is the hero's "noir decision." The central character consciously decides to do that thing they know they should not do. Compare Al Pacino's Vincent Hanna of *Heat* to Al Pacino's Frank Serpico, who Foster Hirsch (1999) contends is a noir hero (158). Serpico decides to *not* to be a corrupt cop and aids the investigation into police corruption—a traditional hero, deciding to do good. Vincent, on the other hand, willingly lets his marriage fail and continues a downward personal spiral because "I spend all my time chasing guys like you around the block—that's my life." Vincent *knows* that his obsession with his work defines him and that it is destroying his personal life. Frank Serpico, on the other hand, clearly acts to end corruption in the New York City police force. The Police Procedural (even in its form of the police being FBI or government agents) rises to neo-noir when its central character steps over

an ethical or personal line. *Heat* also contains the parallel story of the professional thief (already a noir decision), Neil McCauley (Robert De Niro), who, like most noir thieves, dreams of a new life and identity after one last job. Further, *Heat* negotiates its post-classical stance on a grand level: first, its epic dramatic scale makes the events seem operatic (consider the famous/notorious shoot-out in the streets of downtown Los Angeles and the film's ending); second, we dive deeper into the personal lives of the characters than the genre usually goes; third, the personae of the two major stars influences the film-viewing experience; and fourth, the visual style continues a theme in the films of Michael Mann of character and identity intricately related to spaces they occupy—a visual style that will find its way into neo-noirs of other directors.

Quentin Tarantino's *Jackie Brown*, the second example film, also offers a complicated post-classical experience. Unlike *Heat*, *Jackie Brown* cuts across filmic and neo-noir categories. For example, Tarantino adapted *Jackie Brown* from Elmore Leonard's novel, *Rum Punch* (Tarantino's only feature adaptation), placing it within a resurgence of crime fiction adaptation in the 1990s and setting it apart from Tarantino's adaptive homage films, like *Reservoir Dogs* (1992) and *Pulp Fiction* (1994). Leonard saw his novels *Get Shorty*, *Out of Sight*, *Gold Coast*, *Split Image*, *Touch*, and *Pronto* become movies or TV-movies, along with *Maximum Bob* adapted as a TV series. Other crime writers, such as Jim Thompson, Chester Himes, Walter Mosley, Richard Price, and Richard Stark (aka Donald E. Westlake), also saw screen versions of their work in the 1990s. Nineties Noir re-connected and reworked past efforts in noir films and crime fiction. Palmer uses the public relations term "spin" to contextualize how films of the 1990s interacted with media and events of the past. First, Palmer contends, "Spin is a belief in the power of interpretation. Nineties spin became a way of altering the direction of history" (45). In a post-classical sense, as Palmer describes, films like *Groundhog Day* (1993) and *Sliding Doors* (1998) engage generic predecessors like *It's a Wonderful Life* (1946) and *Heaven Can Wait* (1978) in "dialogic structures" (55), that is, nineties films spin the past to fit socio-political context of the 1990s. In adapting *Rum Punch*, Tarantino spins/interprets *Jackie Brown*, first, by re-envisioning the central character as a mid-forties, African American woman, alone a "spin," and then Tarantino casts the iconic Pam Grier in the role (also changing the character's name from Jackie Burke to Jackie Brown—perhaps an allusion to Grier's *Foxy Brown*—and making her name the title of the film). While *Jackie Brown* may not qualify as Blaxploitation, and

Tarantino claims it is not Blaxploitation, the casting of Grier makes the comparison/spin to the seventies films inevitable (Wooten 110). Further, Tarantino moved the setting from Florida to noir-friendly Los Angeles, to further guide interpretation. As with other Tarantino films, *Jackie Brown* contains numerous postmodern allusions to other films and pop culture, such as *The Graduate*-like opening shot; the use of Bobby Womack's "Across 110th Street," a theme from a seventies era Blaxploitation crime film, and also music from the Pam Grier vehicle *Coffy* (1973); and the strategic casting of character actor Robert Forster as bail bonds man Max Cherry. Also, *Jackie Brown* is one of the few Nineties Noir to feature a woman, who is not a femme fatale, as the lead character who makes the "noir decision." Hence, *Jackie Brown* not only engages in a neo-noir dialogue (or spin), but it also engages in an adaptation dialogue, a race and ethnicity dialogue, a gender dialogue, and a dialogue with a string of heist noir films such as *The Asphalt Jungle* (1950), *The Killing* (1956), and *Charley Varrick* (1973).

Heat and *Jackie Brown* spin the 1990s from separate points of view, but they share one crucial viewpoint—each film concerns identity. The identity theme ties Nineties Noir together. As the greater culture winds down from Reaganism and the Reaganism-lite of the George H.W. Bush years and transitions to the Clinton years, Nineties Noir becomes increasingly concerned with identity. More specifically, the identity theme does not develop as a discovery (i.e., the characters are not in the process of self-discovery); rather the characters exist as fully aware of their identity and the noir adventure usually forces the hero(es) to re-negotiate their identity within the spaces of the neo-noir world: in *Heat*, Hanna and McCauley force each other out into the open (violence, again, spills out into the public), and in *Jackie Brown*, Ordell Robbie's machinations, as well as those of the FBI, force Jackie Brown to defy the male and institutional definitions of her. Across the spectrum of Nineties Noir, we see central characters in conflict with a previous identity as they establish a new identity.

The articulation of identity within their overlapping worlds dominates the famous diner scene in *Heat* between Neil and Vincent. For example, this exchange after Neil explains the "heat" code of being able to walk away from everything in your life in 30 seconds when you feel the heat coming around the corner:

- Vincent: So, if you spot me comin' around that corner, you just going to walk out on this woman? And not say goodbye?
- Neil: That's the discipline.
- Vincent: That's pretty vacant.
- Neil: Yeah, it is what it is. It's that or we both better go do something else, pal.
- Vincent: I don't know how to do anything else.
- Neil: Neither do I.
- Vincent: I don't much want to, either.
- Neil: Neither do I.

In *Jackie Brown*, a similar moment of mutual recognition occurs between Jackie and Max Cherry:

- Jackie: I always feel like I'm starting over [...] If I lose my job I gotta start all over again, but I got nothin' to start over with. I'll be stuck with whatever I can get. And that shit scares me more than Ordell.

Articulating self-identity may seem like some kind of self-help/self-improvement appropriate to the consumerism resulting from the tech boom of the 1990s, but identity contains a darker consideration that becomes how Nineties Noirs engage this unique period. The rise of the Clintons and Bill Clinton's presidency continually forced supporters and detractors to articulate, and re-articulate, identity. Likewise, the O.J. Simpson trial forced issues of race and identity into the mainstream, as did finding one's reaction to the AIDS epidemic force articulation of identity. Rafferty broaches the idea in his look at the films of 1999, and it applies to Nineties Noir: the "movies of 1999 were also sneakily personal, luring viewers with promises of high-end thrills or movie star grandeur—only to turn the focus back on the audience, forcing them to consider all sorts of questions about identity and destiny" (xvii). The purpose of film noir, again, resides in its exploration of the darker aspects of our shared culture. In Nineties Noir, that takes the form of asserting "This is who I am."

Heat's path to production demonstrates how the developing pieces of the neo-noir mosaic interconnect—that is, how a contemporary film can work as a dialogue, or spin, with previous works. Writer/director Michael Mann contributed significantly to Eighties Noir by guiding the *Miami Vice* (1984–1990) TV series; adapting and directing the Thomas Harris

novel, *Red Dragon*, into *Manhunter* (1986); and writing and directing the TV-movie/pilot, *L.A. Takedown* (1989), a much-abbreviated version of *Heat*. But *Heat* bears very few of the narrative elements and little of the visual elements of Mann's preceding neo-noir efforts, and that includes *L.A. Takedown* (even his non-neo-noir *The Last of the Mohicans* [1992] is a narrative and visual departure from his eighties films). In the 1990s, Mann shifted his interest to new socio-political concerns and the identity theme.

Similarly, with *Jackie Brown*, Tarantino signaled a new direction. Having translated his success writing original screenplays, *True Romance* (screenplay 1987, Tony Scott-directed film 1993) and *Natural Born Killers* (screenplay 1991, Oliver Stone-directed film 1994), to directing the Homage Noirs *Reservoir Dogs* (1992) and *Pulp Fiction* (1994).¹ In his work prior to *Jackie Brown*, Tarantino used Homage Noir to insert surrogate versions of himself into the types of films he loved. *True Romance* follows Clarence (the romantic fantasy surrogate), a comic bookstore clerk, and his girlfriend/wife, Alabama, on an I-accidentally-found-a-suitcase-full-of-cocaine adventure. Once in Hollywood, Clarence meets variations of Tarantino: one, a struggling actor (Michael Rapaport), the other a slacker pot head (Brad Pitt). Of *True Romance*, Tarantino said, "Oh, I love Elmore Leonard. In fact, to me *True Romance* is basically like an Elmore Leonard movie [...] that he didn't write" (1994). Tarantino goes on to admit "figuring out my style" from Leonard. Mickey and Mallory of *Natural Born Killers* recall Clarence and Alabama—this time the couple on the run are pathological killers. Along the way they meet a Tarantino surrogate, Wayne Gayle (Robert Downey, Jr.), a tabloid writer who confers cult status on Mickey and Mallory (in Tarantino's screenplay the story is framed by tabloid TV show about Mickey and Mallory). In the first two films directed by Tarantino, the fantasy and realistic surrogate juxtaposition becomes even clearer: In *Reservoir Dogs*, Mr. Brown, played by Tarantino, espouses his theory on Madonna's "Like a Virgin" and then is killed in the heist. Mr. Orange (Tim Roth) becomes the fantasy version of Tarantino: the undercover cop working on his acting. In *Pulp Fiction*, Vincent represents Tarantino's romantic fantasy version of himself balanced against a more realistic, slacker version of himself (Jimmy, the suburban guy visited by the gangsters) played Tarantino. *Jackie Brown*, void of Tarantino surrogates, moves on from self-exploration into character study and asserting identity in the contemporary world—an identity other than Tarantino himself.

Michael Mann and Quentin Tarantino also represent a group of directors working within similar circumstances. Like previous groups of directors in other neo-noir movements and like the directors of classic noir, they find themselves in similar modes of production. In Nineties Noir, the mode of production tilted in their favor: the directors work within a Hollywood system willing to back their distinct (and often expensive) visions. Along with Mann and Tarantino, David Fincher, John Dahl, Abel Ferrara, Stephen Frears, Bill Duke, Carl Franklin, David Lynch, and others bring Nineties Noirs to the screen with unique visions. Unlike classic noir or Eighties Noir, it is not that their films share a visual style; rather they share the ability/opportunity to express *their* vision of Nineties Noir. And as with previous movements, while keenly aware of the neo-noir and the noir preceding them, little awareness of their like involvement in a neo-noir movement seems evident. To jump ahead, this ability to bring distinct visions to the screen will not last and many of these directors will not participate in future neo-noir movements. For now, we focus on *Heat* and *Jackie Brown* to see how they interact with the elements of neo-noir, the 1990s, and how they explore issues of identity.

Being neo-noir, ambivalence colors the question of identity. With *Heat* and *Jackie Brown*, three central characters dominate the discussion: Vincent Hanna, Neil McCauley, and Jackie Brown. All three define themselves by their work and in doing so set up worlds wherein the things and people existing outside their “orbits” do not matter. Vincent foreshadows their existential view when he interprets the armored car crime scene and one of the dead bodies: “The M.O. is that they’re good. Once it escalated to a Murder One beef for all of them after they killed the first two guards, they didn’t hesitate, popped guard number three because what difference does it make? Why leave a living witness? Drop of a hat, these guys will rock and roll.” For Vincent and Neil, their “underworld” takes the form of an elite level of professionalism, and when their work spills over into the “real” world, they will not hesitate to “rock and roll.” Vincent’s and Neil’s neo-noir ambivalence stems from that discipline (hence, the film’s title), that they will inflict their violence as a form of their professionalism. For Jackie Brown ambivalence concerns the business in which she has landed and from which she must extract herself.

Jackie Brown, with three key exceptions, represents a traditional neo-noir hero: someone caught in the underworld of crime due to their questionable conduct, who now, feeling the noose tightening, must escape that underworld. She belongs in that group of noir adventurers who are

innocents only in the sense that they are not professional criminals, nor professional law enforcement. From classic noir comparable characters include Walter Neff of *Double Indemnity* (1944), an insurance investigator falling for the femme fatale, or Edmond O'Brien in *D.O.A.* (1949), a salesman who has been poisoned, or *The Hitchhiker* (1953), one of two men on a fishing trip who pick up the escaped convict/killer. In the neo-noir era, it could be someone like Rane in *Rolling Thunder* (1977) a Vietnam vet, or Jeffrey Beaumont, a college kid home for the summer, in *Blue Velvet* (1986). For whatever sins they may have committed, their noir adventure includes extricating themselves from the underworld.

Jackie, in other words, is an archetype. And like the other archetypal characters, she comes from a less than innocent past. The character's background, when handled strategically, as Tarantino does, reflects the neo-noir's engagement with the historical context and sets up the ambivalence of the character. When agents Dargus and Nicolette take Jackie in for the money in her travel bag, they run down her priors. This device in less experienced writers acts merely as a vehicle for exposition. But with Tarantino it not only explicates the expository information, but it also establishes the ambivalence of Jackie as a neo-noir hero in the 1990s:

Dargus: Look, Miss Brown, we don't give a fuck about you. You know who we want. If you cooperate, if you tell us what we want, we'll help you get out of this. And if you refuse to cooperate, and you continue to cop a shit attitude, like you're doing right now, we will give you to Customs and they will take you to court, and with your priors, the judge will give you two years. [...] If I was a 44-year-old black woman, desperately clinging on to this one shitty, little job that I was fortunate to get, I don't think I'd think I had a year I could throw away. So, start again now, shall we? Who in Mexico gave you this money? And who in America were you bringin' it to?

Jackie: I'm not sayin' another goddamned word.

Unlike the previous noir "innocent" characters, Jackie Brown's ambivalence stems from race, gender, and age, and all three factors dominate her noir adventure. She turns to the darker side of 1990s culture, the perception of a "44-year-old black woman" placed on her by the representatives of "the law" and the "underworld," and seeks to use that ambivalence like a weapon.

The turning point in the story happens when Jackie learns of Beaumont's death. She knows Ordell killed him and she knows Ordell will kill her. Jackie's noir decision happens when she realizes she can manipulate Ordell into the hands of the law and, simultaneously, make off with Ordell's money. Her relationship with Max Cherry, the bail bonds man, provides a 1990s twist on the matter. Max falls for her and becomes a willing accomplice. Crucially, Max does not become the leader of her scheme. In each other, they negotiate identity in their middle ages—Max tires of his life as a bail bonds man, and Jackie tires of her life working for low-rent airlines. Jackie's ascent into her identity also works out visually across the arc of the film. She begins in her flight attendant uniform, which she then loses to her county lockup coveralls. After lockup, she meets Max, and her look improves. As her plan to play the cops against Ordell comes to fruition, Jackie sheds uniforms and coveralls, the look of oppressive institutions. She expresses herself through her look. When she confronts Ordell, she wears a red cocktail dress. Part of her plan to switch the money at the mall involves shopping for a suit in a department store, and everyone who sees her in it notices how good it looks on her. In the end, Jackie's ambivalence allows her to assert her identity: she plays Dargus and Nicolette so that they kill Ordell (allowing them to unleash the violence they wanted to unleash) and indirectly she causes Ordell's friend, Louis (Robert De Niro), to kill Melanie, and in turn Ordell kills Louis. In a bit of gender reversal, Jackie offers Max a chance to ride off into the sunset with her, but he declines. In the end, Jackie drives off in Ordell's car with Ordell's money singing along to Bobby Womack's "Across 110th Street," a song about the border street between Harlem and Central Park North. Jackie Brown crosses a boundary into self-determined identity.

Neil and Vincent come with pre-determined identity. The noir adventure for each of them, the entire direction of *Heat*, rests solely with their collision. Unlike Jackie Brown, Neil and Vincent are the source of the ambivalence, and as they do what they "have to" do, they show little regard for the world around them. Herein lies the source of the credentials for *Heat* as a neo-noir. Again, not all Police Procedurals qualify as noir, but *Heat* qualifies on the basis of its ambivalence: neither lead character cares about the world outside of their profession, and both leads make noir decisions taking them deeper into the darkness of their identities. Vincent has even convinced himself that he is one of the good guys. Justine (Diane Venora), Vincent's wife, lays out Vincent's neo-noir status:

You don't live with me. You live among the remains of dead people. You sift through the detritus, you read the terrain, you search for signs of passing, for the scent of your prey, and then you hunt them down. That's the only thing you're committed to. The rest is the mess you leave as you pass through.²

Vincent embodies the "death and alienation" espoused by Palmer. Vincent, like Neil, rationalizes his behavior as professionalism ("I gotta hold onto my angst. [...] It keeps me sharp, on the edge, where I need to be").

Neil, on the other hand, aspires to a post-thief idyllic life. And as in so many heist noirs, the last job will make that dream come true. As demonstrated by the opening armored car robbery and the interpretation of the crime scene afterward by Vincent, Neil and his crew are stone-cold professionals. The key to their ambivalence lies with the violence they can and will unleash on the public (which will be discussed shortly). Nobody gets in their way. Waingro, a last-minute addition to their crew for the armored car robbery, provides the vehicle for Neil and his crew to balance their professionalism and ambivalence: Waingro went off-script during the heist (killing a guard), and the crew cannot accept that breach of etiquette (nor express sympathy for the guards). They plan to kill Waingro in the parking lot of a diner, but Waingro escapes. Waingro then weaves in and out of the film—the audience learns he's a serial killer of young prostitutes, he provides information about Neil and his crew to the cops, and Vincent uses Waingro as bait in the end. The darkly poetic justice of Neil killing Waingro at the end closes a case the cops have not been able to solve and saves the city from additional murders. Neil cares nothing of that; his vengeance rests solely with Waingro's lack of professionalism during a job. And that vengeance, the crack in his professional identity, leads to Neil's demise and the end of his dream world, which was just in his grasp.

The aspiration of identity defines the oneiric state of these films. To understand how the ambivalent hero engages the 1990s, we must understand their dreams. Jackie Brown aspires to self-identity beyond the confines of oppressive misogyny, racism, and ageism. Vincent aspires to unobtainable hero/savior status. Neil aspires to a dream on the opposite side of the world (New Zealand) with his new girlfriend. Interestingly, and appropriate to the 1990s, each hero achieves their goal but also ends up alone. Jackie's dream does not exist in Los Angeles; she drives off to Mexico. Neil's dream exists on the other side of the ocean, which he

studies from his empty beach house. Vincent's dream of stopping Neil only leaves Vincent alone again. The irony of the aspirational dream permeates Nineties Noir: the Narrator/Tyler Durden dynamic in *Fight Club*; the Lieutenant's dreams of redemption in *Bad Lieutenant*; the conflicting dreams of Mills, the cop, and John Doe, the serial killer, in *Se7en*; the aspirations of Corky and Violet in *Bound*; or the dream state of Lynch's *Lost Highway*. The 1990s, according to Palmer, may be the decade of "sex and death, and alienation," noir territory indeed, but the neo-noir films of the 1990s approached these subjects as oneiric states—aspirational dreams to which the characters aspired, but, as with *Jackie Brown*, often suppressed by the socio-political climate.

Of the core group of films, *Fight Club* and *Lost Highway* become the dream—that is, watching the film means being in the dream. The other films' oneiric qualities belong to the characters, and through dialogue and action, we learn of their dreams. Most of the films were made with a singular directorial vision, ranging from the garish and heavily stylized (e.g., *Fight Club* and *Lost Highway*) to the more subtle (e.g., *Heat*, *Jackie Brown*, *The Limey*). The oneiric state, in other words, lies within the films' visual style, which we will discuss shortly. At this point, the emphasis rests upon the visual style enhancing the oneiric state of Nineties Noir. Take, for example, a brief scene in Act I (at about 21 minutes) of *Heat*. At the denouement of the opening heist, Neil arrives at his beach house in the evening. Mann's filmic style relies on camera elements (composition, lighting, color saturation) and built environs to frame the audience's viewpoint and understanding of characters' inner dimensions or dreams. Mann uses composition to connect space and narrative, "based on an Alex Colville painting from 1967, entitled *Pacific*" (Ambrose). At the beach house, Mann positions Neil so that the interior frames the view of Neil and the ocean beyond. Discrete music plays. Awash in blue light, Neil stands with his back to the camera, looking out at the ocean. Mann's composition uses the design of the building to frame the shot. The framed windows direct the audience to the space beyond the windows, the ocean, a motif Mann develops throughout the film. Mann emphasizes the connection with a rack focus from Neil to the ocean, and the ocean becomes the key image of Neil's dream. The room, like Neil, is balanced; full of sharp, clean angles; and empty of any signs of inhabitation. The space becomes a metaphor for the character within it. Mann also works out a similar strategy between space and character for Vincent, associating him with cluttered, crowded, and messy spaces (Fig. 5.1).



Fig. 5.1 Neil defined by space and connected to the ocean. *Heat*, Michael Mann, dir., 1995, 20th Century-Fox Blu-ray

In *Jackie Brown*, the oneiric quality lies less with the visual style (Ordell's beach house bears none of the mood Mann gives to Neil's beach house) and more with the aspirations of Jackie and Max Cherry. Like Neil, the heist is meant to get Jackie to the place of her dreams. Visually, Tarantino fills *Jackie Brown*, as he does with all of his films, with objects, references, and designs of his pop culture influences, an ongoing explication of his dream-version of Los Angeles. Along with muscle cars and music of the seventies, Tarantino also inserts a faux movie or TV show ("Chicks with Guns"), casting choices usually of a movie or TV star from the seventies (Robert Forster as Max Cherry, Pam Grier, Sid Haig) along with many of his stock company (e.g., Samuel L. Jackson, Michael Bowen [Dargus]). *Jackie Brown* contains a Venn diagram overlap point that includes the world of Elmore Leonard (Michael Keaton's Ray Nicolette returns in Steven Soderbergh's adaptation of Leonard's *Out of Sight* [1998]) and Tarantino's Los Angeles-based "universe." Nineties Noirs share a common trait of directors with distinct visions; hence, the oneiric state of the film comes from the world created by the director.

As with the oneiric state, the violence in Nineties Noir balances between the interest of the director and the socio-cultural context. As a unique group of films, Nineties Noirs contain metaphorical similarities. The violence wells up from a private place and, because of the ambivalence of the main characters, often spills out into the general public. The most epic scene of violence in Nineties Noir is the famous/notorious bank robbery

shoot-out in the streets of Los Angeles in *Heat*. It is eerily realistic in technical execution (Mann had the actors trained by ex-SAS [UK] and special forces in weapons use and maneuvers) and emotional impact (the film takes the time to detail the reaction of women involved with Neil's crew), surreal (a visual and audio tour de force), and excessive (ten-minute sequence shot in real time, expending an amazing amount of bullets, wrecking an untold number of cars, causing death and destruction to law enforcement and innocent bystanders) simultaneously (Ambrose). The key aspect of this scene, which brings it into the world of neo-noir, belongs to the ambivalence of the cops and the robbers toward the innocent people around them. As Vincent and his crew attempt to ambush Neil's crew as they come out of the bank, Vincent tells his people "watch your background." Vincent's crew move through the bystanders, telling them to "get out of the way." Neil and his crew react as Neil promised Vincent earlier, "without hesitation." Again, the innocents become obstacles or shields as Neil and his crew shoot their way out. Cheritto picks up a little girl while attempting his escape, but Vincent kills him by taking a very dangerous shot (the kill shot misses the little girl by inches). Mann said of Cheritto, "He's Mr. Family Values, loves his kids, but he doesn't love your kids" (Ambrose). The ethical question this sequence raises is why the cops engage (through their presence) the robbers in a gun fight? They could have followed them and engaged them at some other point—was the money from the bank really that important? Vincent's noir decision instigates the shoot-out. Vincent acts out Cheritto's rationalization: "For me, the action is the juice."

The violence in Nineties Noir consistently brings the oneiric state to conclusion. The dream, or the aspiration, can end no other way except in violent confrontation. Jackie Brown is able to move the pieces around her to the exact points they need to be for her to achieve her goal. Vincent and Neil similarly work the people around them until Neil makes his fatal mistake, giving into professional error in taking his revenge on Waingro.

Because of the fragmentation into sub-groups, Nineties Noir never establishes a distinct visual style as Eighties Noir did. Even the sub-groups fail to establish a consistent visual style. Rather, the visual style becomes individualistic, with directors adopting a neo-noir sensibility to their personal style. The visual style takes on a post-classical approach in that it is a fragmented approach, incorporating multiple options within an intertextual discourse, all of which depends upon our understanding of the relationship between the film and where it stands in the neo-noir mosaic.

Heat and *Jackie Brown* provide two archetypal approaches visual style and act as models that may guide the deconstruction of visual style in other Nineties Noir.

The ability to define identity according to the space one inhabits dominates *Heat*. Vincent comes home at one point to find his wife with another man. Vincent screams, “You can lounge around here on her sofa, in her ex-husband’s dead-tech, post-modernistic bullshit house.” In his rage, Vincent defines character with architecture. Throughout the film, Vincent defines the space others inhabit. Neil, fittingly, uses space to disguise his identity. As a “criminal,” Neil often redefines the space he inhabits by using non-place for unintended purposes. The inevitable collision of Vincent and Neil depicts the final definition of Los Angeles as Marc Auge’s concept of non-place. The visual style of *Heat* emphasizes the tension between place and non-place, suggesting space drives the narrative and reveals character. The Los Angeles of *Heat* establishes a landscape of non-place, “a space that cannot be defined as relational, historical, or concerned with identity” (Auge 77–78). For example, *Heat* opens with images of a commuter train and train station to establish architectural design as generating attitudes and understanding of Neil, the thief (he works in travel spaces that reduce people to passengers or travelers). The station alludes to Neil’s arrival in non-place, and the night setting alludes to a neo-noir world. Neil emerges from the train, a part of a crowd, but Mann, using a narrow field of focus, blurs the surrounding, nameless commuters. The hospital, in the second setting, furthers the allusion with nameless patients (foreshadowing the victims of the upcoming gunfight in the streets). Neil “inhabits” the space, but his determined movement sets him apart from the excess of patients. In *Blood in the Moonlight: Michael Mann and the Information Age Cinema* (2005), Mark Wildermuth demonstrates how Mann’s framing limits the options for the viewer to define the space inhabited by the characters: “Neil moves into the hospital—a place of electronics, computer screens, and antiseptic whiteness, until Neil glances in one room and we see a bleeding victim’s body in close-up, first sign of what this all means, anything can be invaded, nothing is secure, and nothing is sacred in this fragmented world of incongruities” (136–137).

Mann’s film style uses the camera to frame the perception of space to “manage” the characters inhabiting and re-acting to the space. The sequence of shots following the hospital scene locates the members of Neil’s crew. Mann takes the audience through doorways and windows (transitional spaces) into the world of Neil’s crew: Train doors open and

Neil steps out; doorways frame views of Neil as he moves through the hospital; Chris Sheherlis (Val Kilmer) passes through a large door into a warehouse at a construction equipment depot; Waingro first emerges through a door embedded in a large wall painted in street art at a taco stand; a car door also frames Trejo (Danny Trejo); and a large tow truck's door and window frame the first view of Cheritto (Tom Sizemore).

With Vincent, Mann associates space and structures of movement (stairs, roads, cars, helicopters, communication networks), none of which seem to lead anywhere, other than to Neil. According to Auge, the non-place of modern communication technology "puts the individual in contact only with another image of himself" (79). Mann's film style emphasizes this point with a mirror effect by consistently presenting Neil and Vincent in shot/reverse shot when they have a scene together. When Neil's crew breaks into a gem distributor's warehouse, Vincent's team secretly watches. While the crew works inside the warehouse, Neil appears in a doorway and stands guard. Vincent watches an infrared image of Neil's face on a screen. Mann edits the diner scene with Vincent and Neil entirely in shot/reverse shot and shot/reverse shot dominates most of the shoot-out scene at the end. Mann's composition and editing consistently puts Vincent in contact "with another image of himself"—Neil.

Space also comments on the interaction between Neil and Vincent. Their encounters take place in four settings (on the shoulder on the interstate, a restaurant interior, an industrial pier, and an airport runway), each a comment on a different aspect of their relationship. Let's focus on the restaurant and runway encounters, as they bring together Mann's emphasis on spaces depicting his neo-noir visual style. After pulling Neil over on the interstate, Vincent suggests they get coffee. In the upscale restaurant (non-place), Mann uses the excess of people to comment on the personal nature of the encounter. Mann frames the scene so Neil and Vincent (again, only shot/reverse shot) exist within a narrow plane of focus among a blurry crowd of diners. Appropriately, they discuss their personal lives and the people in their dreams: sex, death, and alienation in the 1990s. The last encounter takes place at the end of a runway at the Los Angeles airport, where, again, Mann emphasizes the excess of identity-less people within a non-place. The showdown between Neil and Vincent becomes a crescendo of architectural and narrative convergence: the end of a runway at LAX becomes the large-scale version of the opening train station, jets full of passengers fly in and out over the ocean, and red and white checkered boxes provide the corners to enact images from the "heat" mantra.

Neil and Vincent seem small, insignificant to the space and objects around them. Once Vincent shoots Neil, Moby's "God Moving Over the Face of the Waters" rises on the soundtrack and elevates the grandeur of the water/ocean imagery associated with Neil. The ocean becomes abstract film space, existing just off-screen (most flights fly out over the ocean at LAX) and in the music. The "place" Neil sought on the other side of the ocean remains a mystery.

As Neil faces the ocean, Vincent faces inland to the airport and city, taking Neil's hand as he dies. In this gesture, Neil brings Vincent to a halt and transfers his loss to Vincent. This act culminates the motif of Vincent's literal connection to people dying, having started with the cold and calculated execution of the armored car guards and increasing in intensity with the dead prostitute and her mother, Lauren's suicide attempt, and finally Neil, the last individual. In this transference of identity, Vincent becomes the prototypical existential neo-noir hero in a world of non-place, a hunter figure adrift within the physical and virtual network of the Los Angeles. He moves without ever leaving or arriving, seeking to "relieve" identity from anyone whose presence should redefine the space they inhabit. Justine's definition of Vincent could become Mann's reading of life within the Los Angeles of Nineties Noir, realized by the central characters in this final moment of transference among the swirl of non-place imagery: "You don't live with me. You live among the remains of dead people. You sift through the detritus, you read the terrain, you search for signs of passing, for the scent of your prey, and then you hunt them down. That's the only thing you're committed to; the rest is the mess you leave as you pass through." In Auge's words, what confronts the Traveller [sic] in the space of non-place, "finally, is an image of himself, but in truth it is a pretty strange image The space of non-place creates neither singular identity nor relations; only solitude, and similitude" (103). With *Heat*, Mann presents a neo-noir world in the 1990s over-run with non-place that forces one to define/redefine themselves before the world takes it away either through sex, death, or alienation.

A neo-noir visual style need not be pre-ordained. Rather, the filmmakers work out their noir style, as does Tarantino with *Jackie Brown*. *Jackie Brown*, in Foster Hirsch's breakdown of neo-noir, would fall in the same camp as *The Killers* (Don Siegel 1964), as a film "cleansed of noir motifs," since *Jackie Brown* contains very few film noir visual motifs—no rain-slicked streets, no overcoats, and no "ceiling shots" or "mirror shots" (Hirsch 38). Since the visual style is not about contemporary versions of

classic tropes, it lies elsewhere. Tarantino negotiates the spaces his neo-noir characters inhabit with a straight-ahead sense of composition (no canted angles, balanced two-shots, lighting that fits the spaces). As the film progresses, Jackie Brown re-negotiates the spaces, moving the action from the familiar “underworld” settings of jails, bail bonds offices, and bars to more public spaces, well-lit spaces, like the different places within the shopping mall. At the same time, Jackie’s appearance becomes more assured as her plan unfolds. Tarantino’s visual style for *Jackie Brown*, then, tracks Jackie’s neo-noir adventure, a descent into Ordell’s underworld (including the police and ATF investigation), where she meets a significant ally in Max Cherry, who helps her negotiate the trail through criminals and law enforcement. As we linger in the spaces belonging to the characters, the visuals reveal as much neo-noir engagement as the dialogue or action (at times, more). Contrast Ordell’s beach house with Jackie’s place. Ordell’s beach house appears oddly normal, normal in the sense that it contains none of the tropes of the evil lair—it’s bright, sunny, and lacks any sense of personal design. In fact, Ordell’s place bears almost no signs of identity. The key object of his place is the TV set, on which Ordell and Louis watch “Chicks with Guns.” By contrast, Jackie’s place, a modest apartment, is full of objects that reveal Jackie: her record collection, art on the walls, books on shelves, pictures on her refrigerator, etc. Similarly, Jackie’s look improves over the course of the story—as she comes into her identity—a 44-year-old black woman asserting her power over those who would oppress her. Tarantino offers an evolving set of non-places in *Jackie Brown* and lingers with long scenes within those places, so that the viewer can take in the information. As neo-noir, the information loaded in the places becomes the engagement with the historical context as well as with how the characters assert their identity.

Jackie’s confrontation with Ordell at the film’s end bears important similarities to the conclusion of *Heat*. Again, the scene acts as a collision of theme and identity in a sight of non-place (a bail bonds office). Ordell, who has attempted to eliminate anyone who might upset his scheme to bring his money in from Mexico (e.g., killing Beaumont before the police figure it out), is done in by Jackie, who has become, for Ordell, an “image of himself.” Jackie has asserted her identity, that is, her ability to redefine herself, within these neo-noir spaces where she convinces the cops (who Jackie has played with virtuoso skill) to kill Ordell. She denies non-place its opportunity to render solitude and similitude. As with *Heat*, the representative of non-place, Ordell, confronts the person attempting to



Fig. 5.2 The ending: Jackie Brown finishes her redefinition. *Jackie Brown*, Quentin Tarantino, dir., 1997, Miramax Blu-ray

redefine the space, Jackie. This time, though, Jackie exorcises her non-place demon and returns to the world. Significantly, leaving Los Angeles, the setting of so much noir (Fig. 5.2).

As with Eighties Noir, the femme fatale dominates other genres. The difference in the 1990s is that the femme fatale came to dominate her own movement of neo-noir films, specifically the Erotic Thriller. Most often, cable TV and direct-to-video/DVD was the Erotic Thriller's venue, and the mode of production fit that form of filmmaking. However, a sub-set of the Erotic Thriller worked in A pictures, the most prominent being Paul Verhoeven's *Basic Instinct* (1992) (followed by a direct-to-DVD sequel in 2006), which encouraged the career of screenwriter Joe Eszterhas, who would write similar material with *Sliver* (1993) and *Jade* (1995). Other A versions of the Erotic Thriller include *Bound* (1996), *Wild Things* (1998), *Color of Night* (1994), and *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999) (which deserves more attention as neo-noir). Some of the best writing on these films, as neo-noir and as a specific movement, comes from Linda Ruth Williams' *The Erotic Thriller in Contemporary Cinema* (2005) and Samantha Lindop's *Postfeminism and the Fatale Figure in Neo-Noir Cinema* (2015). As they relate to this chapter, I would point out Lindop's contention as she cites Williams: "Not only is 1980s and 1990s *noir* marked by the emergence of

the highly erotic, sexually aggressive, often sexually ambiguous *femme* (and *fille*) *fatale*, it is also a period where the deadly woman acts with increasing independence and significantly, where she begins to get away with her crimes. [...] the 1980s and 1990s spider woman who, as Williams points out, is no longer motivated purely by money, but is also driven by a lust for exciting sex, a desire for wealth and the power that it brings (Williams 2005, p. 100)” (51 and 53).

These women, though, are mostly absent from the other movements of Nineties Noir (with the exception of *Homage Noir* in the 1990s). Professionalism as a code of conduct seems to inoculate men in Nineties Noir against sexual seduction. What sexual relations we do encounter seem almost chaste next to *Basic Instinct* and *The Last Seduction* (1994). If we return to Palmer’s thesis concerning the 1990s, a decade concerned with identity in relationship to “sex and death and alienation in so many ways,” professionalism, be it law enforcement or law-breaking, becomes a vehicle for determining identity. What Lindop claims defines the *femme fatale* characters also applies to other neo-noir heroes in the 1990s: Neil acts independently, motivated less by money and more by achieving his aspirational dream; Jackie Brown also asserts her independence, significance, and “gets away with” her plan—and she does it without using sex as a weapon. The Erotic Thrillers and other Nineties Noirs provide a multi-faceted approach to establishing identity within the darker aspects of 1990s culture.

APPENDIX

Nineties Noir Film List

Adaptations

After Dark, My Sweet (1990), d. James Foley (adaptation of Jim Thompson novel)

The Grifters (1990), d. Stephen Frears (adaptation of Jim Thompson novel, adapted by Donald E. Westlake)

A Rage in Harlem (1991), d. Bill Duke (adaptation of Chester Himes novel). Also Nostalgia Noir

The Silence of the Lambs (1991), d. Jonathan Demme (adaptation of Thomas Harris novel)

Devil in the Blue Dress (1995), d. Carl Franklin (adaptation of Walter Mosley novel). Also Nostalgia Noir
Clockers (1995), d. Spike Lee (adaptation of Richard Price novel)
Jackie Brown (1997), d. Quentin Tarantino (adaptation of Elmore Leonard novel *Rum Punch*)
U-Turn (1997), d. Oliver Stone (adaptation of John Ridley novel)
Payback (1999), d. Brian Helgeland (adaptation of Donald E. Westlake/Richard Stark novel *The Hunter*—same source as *Point Blank*)
Fight Club (1999), d. David Fincher (adaptation of Chuck Palahniuk novel)

Police Procedural Noir

Internal Affairs (1990), d. Mike Figgis
Homicide (1991), d. David Mamet (original screenplay by Mamet)
Basic Instinct (1992), d. Paul Verhoeven (original screenplay by Joe Eszterhas)
Heat (1995), d. Michael Mann (original screenplay by Mann)
Se7en (1995), d. David Fincher (original screenplay by Andrew Kevin Walker)
Primal Fear (1996), d. Gregory Hoblit
Copycat (1995), d. John Amiel
Bodily Harm (1995), d. James Lemmo

Sub-category: Undercover Cop

State of Grace (1990), d. Phil Joanou—undercover
Point Break (1991), d. Kathryn Bigelow—undercover
Rush (1991), d. Lili Fini Zanuck—undercover
Deep Cover (1992), d. Bill Duke
Beyond the Law (1993), d. Larry Ferguson (original screenplay by Ferguson)—undercover

Sub-category: Corrupt Cop

Bad Lieutenant (1992), d. Abel Ferrara—corrupt cop
Romeo Is Bleeding (1993), d. Peter Medak—corrupt cop

African American Noir

A Rage in Harlem (1991), d. Bill Duke. Also Nostalgia Noir
New Jack City (1991), d. Mario Van Peebles
One False Move (1991), d. Carl Franklin
Deep Cover (1992), d. Bill Duke

Juice (1991), d. Ernest Dickerson
Clockers (1995), d. Spike Lee
Glass Shield (1995), d. Charles Burnett
Devil in the Blue Dress (1995), d. Carl Franklin. Also a Nostalgia Noir
Bad Company (1995), d. Damian Harris
Ambushed (1998), d. Ernest Dickerson

Sex/Sexuality/Erotic Noir (Often Featuring a New Femme Fatale)

Alligator Eyes (1990), d. John Feldman (original screenplay by Feldman)
Basic Instinct (1992), d. Paul Verhoeven (original screenplay by Joe Eszterhas)
The Last Seduction (1994), d. John Dahl. Also Homage Noir
Body Chemistry (1990), d. Kristine Peterson (multiple sequels)
Bitter Moon (1992), d. Roman Polanski
Body of Evidence (1992), d. Uli Edel
Sliver (1993), d. Phillip Noyce (screenplay by Joe Eszterhas, based on Ira Levin novel)
Killer (aka *Bulletproof Heart*) (1994), d. Mark Malone
China Moon (1994), d. John Bailey
Jade (1995), d. William Friedkin (original screenplay by Joe Eszterhas)
Bound (1996), d. Larry Wachowski and Andy Wachowski (original screenplay by Wachowskis)
Wild Things (1998), d. John McNaughton (multiple direct-to-DVD sequels)
Color of Night (1994), d. Richard Rush
Eyes Wide Shut (1999), d. Stanley Kubrick

Puzzle Plot/Nonlinear/Untrustworthy Narrator

The Usual Suspects (1995), d. Bryan Singer (original screenplay by Christopher McQuarrie)
Pulp Fiction (1994), d. Quentin Tarantino (original screenplay by Tarantino). Also Homage Noir
The Game (1997), d. David Fincher
The Spanish Prisoner (1997), d. David Mamet (original screenplay by Mamet)
Lost Highway (1997), d. David Lynch

Innocent Stumbles upon Treasure/Terror

White Sands (1992), d. Roger Donaldson

True Romance (1993), d. Tony Scott (original screenplay by Quentin Tarantino). Also *Homage Noir*
The Net (1995), d. Irwin Winkler
Nick of Time (1995), d. John Badham
Breakdown (1997), d. Jonathan Mostow
The Blackout (1997), d. Abel Ferrara
A Simple Plan (1998), d. Sam Raimi
Best Laid Plans (1999), d. Mike Barker

Femme Fatale/Homme Fatale

Bad Influence (1990), d. Curtis Hanson—homme fatale
Revenge (1990), d. Tony Scott
Unlawful Entry (1992), d. Jonathan Kaplan—homme fatale
Kalifornia (1993), d. Dominic Sena—homme fatale
Brokedown Palace (1999), d. Jonathan Kaplan—homme fatale
The Fan (1996), d. Tony Scott

Identity/Amnesia

Shattered (1991), d. Wolfgang Petersen—amnesia
Suture (1993), d. Scott McGehee and David Siegel—new identity
Face/Off (1997), d. John Woo—new identity

Miscellaneous

The King of New York (1990), d. Abel Ferrara—out of prison
Miami Blues (1990), d. George Armitage—out of prison
Final Analysis (1992), d. Phil Joanou
Jennifer Eight (1992), d. Bruce Robinson (original screenplay by Robinson)
Little Odessa (1994), d. James Gray (original screenplay by Gray)
Natural Born Killers (1994), d. Oliver Stone (original screenplay by Quentin Tarantino)—couple on the run
Blink (1994), d. Michael Apted
Things To Do in Denver When You're Dead (1995), d. Gary Fleder
Buffalo 66 (1996), d. Vincent Gallo—out of prison
Bullet (1996), d. Julien Temple—out of prison
Hard Eight (1996), d. Paul Thomas Anderson (originally titled *Sydney*)
City of Industry (1997), d. John Irvin—revenge
Cold Around the Heart (1998), d. John Ridley (original screenplay by Ridley)—revenge
Rounders (1998), d. John Dahl—gambling
The Limey (1999), d. Steven Soderbergh—revenge

NOTES

1. Much has been made of Tarantino's work as postmodern and his use of pastiche. For a detailed analysis of the postmodern versus the post-classical, see Catherine Constable's *Postmodernism and Film: Rethinking Hollywood's Aesthetics* (London: Wallflower), 2019.
2. This dialogue comes from the original theatrical release, which is also the original DVD release. This scene was re-cut by Mann for the "director's cut" of the Blu-ray release and omits the line about detritus.

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CHAPTER 6

Digital Noir, 2001–Present

Key Films

Collateral (2004), d. Michael Mann

Man on Fire (2004), d. Tony Scott

Miami Vice (2006), d. Michael Mann

Before the Devil Knows You're Dead (2007), d. Sidney Lumet

Taken (2008), d. Pierre Morel (sequels)

Inception (2010), d. Christopher Nolan

John Wick (2014), d. Chad Stahelski (sequels)

The Accountant (2016), d. Gavin O'Connor

The tech crash of 2000 and the terrorist attack on September 11, 2001, changed the world. And many film genres bear a post-9/11 sensibility—the zombie horror genre is a strong example—but these events took prominence in other genres. Neo-noir, sometime during the early 2000s, turned its concentration to a new focus on the digital world. The digital world, in effect, achieved hegemony during this time, and as Raymond Borde and Etienne Chaumeton guide, “[Film Noir] exists in response to a certain mood at large in this particular time and place. Accordingly, one who seeks the root of this ‘style’ must think in terms of an affected and possibly ephemeral reaction to a moment in history” (19). Digital Noir,

like Eighties Noir, rejects nostalgia, homage, parody, and recreation and concentrates on the dark angst within our highly technologized, deeply networked, digital world. Digital Noir finds noir heroes lost or adrift in the digital world, that is, a world in which technology offers constant connection to networks of media, social, and cultural institutions, from micro- and macro-worlds. The other film genres reaffirm the physical and virtual status quo at multiple levels of the film-viewing experience. At the level of content, romantic comedies and dramas often depict characters relying on technology and networking to save the day. From the ubiquity of cell phones to adulation and reaffirmation of technology to solve mysteries in television shows like *CSI* and *NCIS*. Texting bubbles appearing on-screen depicting a conversation have become a norm. Success, as depicted in Hollywood genre films, often entails easy accumulation and access to technology and connectivity, such as miraculous creations of Tony Stark/Iron Man or Bruce Wayne/Batman. Iron Man's virtual assistant, Jarvis, even becomes a sentient being, the Vision. At another level, technology makes a new world of characters in film possible. The average viewer understands that the special effects in a superhero movie are "digital" and that Spider-Man, at times, is a digital effect, or the Transformers are entirely digital, or that Andy Serkis wears a motion-capture suit and digital technology turns him into Gollum, or Kong, or Caesar. With few exceptions, the non-neo-noir genres reaffirm and celebrate the hegemony of the physical and virtual networked digital world—that surrounds everyday life as well as our film-viewing experience in the 2000s.

In reaffirming technology and supporting its hegemony, stories of technology and "becoming" dominate, as in *The Social Network* (2010), where Mark Zuckerberg becomes Facebook and "Mark Zuckerberg." Tony Stark uses crude technology, then sophisticated tech to become Iron Man, and Dr. Xavier, leader of the X-Men, creates "Cerebro," which allows him to connect with a network of mutants. Similarly, digital networks also emphasize identity. We assume identities, some accurate, some exaggerated, within networks, while other networks amass information about us and reflect back our digital identities (witness the ads appearing around your web browser's borders or ads on your Facebook page after you've made an online purchase). The digital world is eminently concerned with identity and where you exist within its networks. Not surprisingly, Digital Noir focuses on its darker implications.

Whereas other genres reaffirm identity (you are somebody), Digital Noir sees identity called into question and in danger of being rendered

impotent and meaningless (you are nobody). Vincent (Tom Cruise) describes Los Angeles in *Collateral* (Michael Mann 2004) and articulates the dread of non-person status:

To tell you the truth, every time I'm here I can't wait to leave. Too sprawled out. Disconnected ... 17 million people. This was a country, it would be the fifth biggest economy in the world. But nobody knows each other ... I read about this guy that gets on the MTA here, dies. Six hours he's riding the subway before anybody notices this corpse doing laps around LA. People on and off, sitting next to him, nobody notices.

The Digital Noir hero's existential crisis involves a fear of becoming a non-person, that is, someone without meaning, without purpose or history, indistinguishable from everyone else. Darker still are those Digital Noirs that center on a hero who has achieved his aspiration only to have it revoked, as happens to the eponymous John Wick and Robert McCall of *The Equalizer* (2014).

This chapter focuses on a group of neo-noir films that form a response to this unique moment, a digital era of technology threatening our ability to define ourselves as unique individuals. In Digital Noir, the ambivalent hero invariably struggles with identity and identity is inherently connected to technology and digital networks. The hero moves between place and what Marc Auge terms “non-place” (transitory places so repetitively similar and familiar they lack unique identity and strip the “traveler” of identity) and confronts the darker discourse of self-identification.

Digital Noir's placement within the post-classical Hollywood cinema works as a movement of films existing for a determined period of time among other movements, or groups, of films existing at the same time. As with Nineties Noir, Digital Noir does not, and cannot, hold all that is neo-noir occurring since 2000. Digital Noir is, however, made distinct by directly engaging the socio-cultural context of its time and exhibiting consistent and recurring motifs. Other neo-noir movements forming during this time, or bound together by thematic similarities, include groups of films found in contemporary versions of the B-movie, such as direct-to-DVD (consider the films of Nicolas Cage, John Travolta, or Danny Trejo over the last 15 years), or made-for-streaming services or cable channels. Also, Nostalgia Noir sees contributions during this time with such films as *Black Dahlia* (Brian De Palma 2006), *Hollywoodland* (Allen Coulter 2006), and *Gangster Squad* (Ruben Fleisher 2013). Genre hybrids, deeply

influenced by neo-noir, also flourished, as seen in *Batman* trilogy (Christopher Nolan 2005–2012), *Daredevil* (2015–2018) and *Jessica Jones* (2015–2019) series on Netflix, and *Blade Runner 2049* (Denis Villeneuve 2017).

The key Digital Noir films for this discussion include *Man on Fire* (Tony Scott 2004) and *John Wick* (Chad Stahelski 2014). A more complete list of Digital Noir films may be found in the appendix at the end of this chapter. These archetypal Digital Noir films represent post-classical Hollywood filmmaking in the 2000s. Both films work within a style indicative of post-classical and display patterns that unite the filmmakers into a core group. And like most of the films of Digital Noir, both films exemplify the idea of the \$100 B-movie, not recreations, as we find in Remake and Homage Noir. These films work best when considered as B-movies; the exploitation of action and violence is upfront with the deeper implications just below the surface. As we saw with William J. Palmer's notion of "spin" in Nineties Noir, *John Wick* and *Man on Fire* offer an intertextual discourse between the elements of noir, the digital era, and in some cases the filmmakers' personal expressions as artists. Digital Noir, then, serves multiple purposes while engaging the times.

Tony Scott typifies much of the post-classical and its approach to neo-noir in the 2000s. Like many of the innovators of classic noir, Scott is an émigré to Hollywood. He was a key player in a second British Invasion of directors beginning in the late 1970s along with his older brother, Ridley Scott. Jerry Bruckheimer and Don Simpson hired Tony Scott to direct *Top Gun* (1986), based on Scott's work making commercials, including a car ad featuring a fighter jet. Scott apprenticed with Bruckheimer and Simpson on films like *Beverly Hills Cop II* (1987) and *Days of Thunder* (1990), but soon took control of producing. With more control of his films, Scott turned to B-movie material, but always done with an A budget and major stars (a Digital Noir motif). The first effort, *Revenge* (1990), was a neo-noir, featuring the classic noir element of the ambivalent hero who drifts down to Mexico. Scott, who demonstrated a keen ability to spot talent early in their careers, then bought the *True Romance* screenplay from Quentin Tarantino before Tarantino began his directing career. According to Scott, he would have also bought *Reservoir Dogs*, but Tarantino changed his mind about selling it (Emery 31). Prior to *Man on Fire*, Scott also directed neo-noirs, *The Fan* (1996) and *Spy Game* (2001) and the surveillance thriller *Enemy of the State* (1998). Scott worked in Hollywood from the 1980s to 2012 in a vein similar to Andre De Toth or Fritz Lang, and

the British directors from Transitional Noir movement, John Boorman and Peter Yates. Within this mode of production, Tony Scott created an archetypal Digital Noir with *Man on Fire* and showed how a director could use neo-noir for personal expression. *Man on Fire*, like most of Scott's other films, features an ambivalent hero. Creasy (Denzel Washington) seeks guidance from a mentor, Rayburn (Christopher Walken). This is the dominant theme in Tony Scott films, from Maverick and Viper in *Top Gun*, Clarence and his father in *True Romance*, the submarine Captain (Gene Hackman) and the new Executive Officer (Denzel Washington) in *Crimson Tide* (1995) to Scott's last film, *Unstoppable* (2010), with the new train engineer (Chris Pine) working with the experienced engineer (Denzel Washington). Scott continually returned to the metaphor of himself and his brother/mentor, Ridley Scott, hiding the self-revelation behind layers of style—again, not unlike the personal themes of the classical Hollywood studio directors.

Keanu Reeves shepherded *John Wick* to production, having become involved at the level of the original screenplay and working on its development. Derek Kolstad's screenplay, originally titled *Scorn*, evidences *John Wick*'s B-movie heritage: Kolstad's previous credits consisted of a Dolph Lundgren action flick (Moe). Reeves brought directors Chad Stahelski and David Leitch, who had been stuntmen and stunt coordinators and aspired to be directors (Stahelski had been Reeves' stunt double on *The Matrix*). Like many classic noir, the director came from another aspect of filmmaking and the first directing effort was in a low-budget noir, as were the early directorial efforts of Don Siegel, John Sturges, and Robert Wise. Stahelski and Leitch proceeded with the idea that *John Wick* could be a discourse with previous noir films and other genres. In one interview, Stahelski and Leitch list their noir influences (among others) as *Point Blank* (John Boorman 1967), *Le Cercle Rouge* (Jean-Pierre Melville 1970), John Woo films, Quentin Tarantino, and Steve McQueen (More). Like most neo-noir directors, they understand the history of the noir that preceded *John Wick*. And as with other neo-noir movements, the directors seem little aware that they are working in a common mode with other directors or articulating a movement of neo-noir.

John Wick and *Man on Fire*, then, make a case for how the neo-noir sensibility, reflecting the darker side of the time, works in the digital age. *Man on Fire* combines multiple layers of style and technique, along with a layer of personal expression and identity. *John Wick*, while not working as

personal expression, forefronts its sense of identity and place in Hollywood, international cinema, and popular culture.

The ambivalence of the Digital Noir hero is a dramatically male ambivalence. While previous neo-noir movements featured female heroes, they are noticeably absent in this movement. Close to a neo-noir hero, we find similarly angst-ridden heroes, male and female, in espionage films of the same time. While the espionage hero may question identity and appear to be lost, they invariably achieve clarity and identity. In *Atomic Blonde* (2017), a twist at the end reveals Lorraine's (Charlize Theron) identity was just a ruse—she was fully aware of her identity throughout. The espionage heroes, be it Bond, Bourne, Salt, or Lorraine, invariably come to understand, if they did not already know, their identity and place within their networks. The angst ridden neo-noir hero, on the other hand, often assumes a false identity to penetrate one network, then loses sight of their identity, and in the end sacrifices one form of identity to save another—control of identity and place, if any, alludes the Digital Noir (male) hero. In *Man on Fire*, Creasy drifts down to Mexico to reunite with Rayburn, who runs a security business and lives a luxurious life. After a prologue about kidnapping in Mexico City, a border-crossing sequence introduces a worn out, shaggy, and alcoholic Creasy. Creasy leaves one network, America, and enters another, Mexico, specifically the network of security, Rayburn's business. The first scene between Creasy and Rayburn establishes Creasy's bona fides as an ambivalent noir hero—they were mercenaries together. Creasy then wandered for many years, looking for something which, the backstory implies, he never found. Rayburn sets Creasy up with a family in need of a bodyguard for their little girl, but who are unwilling to pay top dollar. Creasy, readily admitting to his alcoholism, tells the father, "The service will be on par with the pay." The young girl, Pita (Dakota Fanning), is, of course, kidnapped and Creasy seriously wounded. Creasy recovers and becomes much like Walker (Lee Marvin) of *Point Blank*, setting out on a singular mission of revenge. As Rayburn explains to a sympathetic authority, "Creasy's art is death. He's about to paint his masterpiece." Creasy tracks down the kidnappers, eventually discovering that Pita is still alive. Having been shot again, Creasy arranges an exchange for Pita. Creasy turns himself over to the hoodlums, but dies as they drive him away, and the movie ends with a denouement explaining the fates of the characters.

John Wick arrives at a similar point, but from a different starting position. *John Wick* begins by setting up the oft-used flashback structure:

Wick, gravely wounded, pulls out a picture of who we will soon learn is his wife. Into the flashback, Wick achieves the aspiration of many noir heroes, a home (modern, sophisticated) and a wife. But his wife dies of cancer, and Wick is alone, except for a dog gifted to him by his wife to help him through his grief. While driving his 1969 dark green Ford Mustang GT (very similar to Steve McQueen's 1968 Mustang GT in *Bullitt*), his masculinity displayed through his "muscle car," the car catches the attention of some wandering Russian gangsters. Tracking the Mustang down leads the gangsters to Wick's home, where they nearly kill Wick and, nefariously, kill Wick's dog. This event causes Wick's violent resurrection—the reemergence of his previous identity, a top-line paid assassin. Wick's ambivalence leads to his mission of revenge not only to reassert his violent self on the underworld but also to avenge the symbols of his modern masculinity: his cool house, his cool car, and his dog.

Creasy's and Wick's ambivalence of the world around them, corrupt networks of networks, lets them find a purpose, if not an identity, in violent rampage. For Creasy, his "art" becomes a rampage through the operation of "The Voice," who heads up the kidnapping organization. Creasy blasts through barriers, each a reminder of his masculine failure: to get to the Voice, Creasy tortures the Voice's brother and threatens his pregnant wife; when Creasy learns Pita's father was in on the kidnapping, Creasy breaks into his home and convinces the father to shoot himself. In restoring Pita to her mother, Creasy performs one last gesture of defiance against the networks that stripped him of identity.

Wick's purpose lies in his rampage through the underworld, which seems to exist in specific places and remains hidden to the "real" world, where he reaffirms his mythical status (which revolves around having killed three men with a pencil). Wick's resurrection reminds many of the Russian bad guys of a legendary demon. Wick fights his way through multiple versions of himself, that is, other assassins who think they can aspire to Wick's success. Appropriately, if oddly, Wick seems to know most of his assailants—they acknowledge each other and then set to the lethal fighting. Wick's defiance of the controlling networks takes the form of demonstrating how ineffectual its assassins have become, having been reduced to non-persons.

The matter of race bubbles to the surface for a brief moment in *Man on Fire*: in the first scene of Creasy driving Pita to school, Pita asks, "Being black, is that a positive or a negative for a bodyguard in Mexico?" Creasy responds, "Time will tell." As with *Collateral* (2004) and *Miami Vice*

(2006), which also feature lead African American characters, acknowledging race rarely occurs, unlike Nineties Noir like *Jackie Brown*, where it frequently gets pushed to the foreground. Race in Digital Noir works at the inferential level, because the characters and the narrative contexts rarely offer any guidance or reaction. Race and ethnicity are present (the crime organization through which Wick rampages is distinctly eastern European), but they are not overt issues for the characters (e.g., race is not an obstacle for Creasy, nor is it an issue in *Collateral* or *Miami Vice*). Marilyn Yaquinto (2008), however, suggests a troublesome aspect in *Man on Fire* in her analysis of Denzel Washington's career: "Washington reprises an aspect of his previous *Virtuosity* role, sacrificing himself on behalf of a young white girl, reiterating another long-standing Hollywood tradition of black characters" (10). When *Man on Fire* "spins" the Digital Noir, the factor of race may present a continuing problem in Hollywood cinema.

Gender drives Digital Noir, as the male heroes, of any race, slip through the malaise of their own anxiety. Creasy, for example, wandered the grid to return to his friend's place in Mexico City where, beaten down by guilt for his sins as a mercenary and his inability to find his "place" within a network, he attempts suicide. Wick wanders a grid unsure of his status as widower, until fate provides him direction. In *Collateral*, Max (Jamie Foxx) dreams of his own business while he drives his cab, only to have Vincent, the hit man, point out to him how truly lost in the network Max has become: "Someday my dream will come? [...] Didn't happen, and it never will, because you were never going to do it anyway." Digital Noir ties masculinity and identity to professionalism, defining yourself through your chosen occupation. Those with a clear vision, like Vincent in *Collateral* or Sonny (Colin Farrell) in *Miami Vice* or Cobb (Leonardo DiCaprio) in *Inception*, work at the top of their profession (and masculinity) but do so with a twisted/corrupted sense of purpose. On the other hand, identity and masculinity are "saved" in Digital Noir when the events pull the hero out of their confused sense of identity and place them in the network that provides a path to restoring their identity *and* their masculinity. Often this process involves violence inflicted upon a woman. For Creasy, Pita's kidnapping provides that moment of clarity. For Mills (Liam Neeson) in *Taken*, his daughter's kidnapping provides the opportunity to ascend from his emasculated life as divorced father. Russian gangsters also spur the return of McCall (Denzel Washington) in *The Equalizer*. Even in *Collateral*, Max awkwardly enters a violent confrontation with Vincent to save a woman he recently met. Violent resurrection redeems masculine

identity through saving or avenging a young woman in Digital Noir and clarifies place on the grid, or in the network, for the wandering hero. Ambivalence stems from the emasculated non-identity position in the contemporary digital world, and the dark discourse of neo-noir suggests only violent resurrection can ameliorate the situation, so that a dream may be realized. With Creasy, he dies, as he intended earlier. For John Wick, as well as Mills in *Taken*, and McCall in *The Equalizer*, it becomes a sentence to eternal sequels, living variations of the same nightmare over and over.

Consistently, Digital Noirs concern central characters searching for their place in an increasingly fragmented world. In Tony Scott's hands, *Man on Fire* becomes a vehicle for grappling with an excessively fragmented world, filled with questions of identity and male anxiety. Scott connects the film-viewing experience to Creasy's experience by constructing a concentrated subjectivity of film technique. Scott explains: "With *Man on Fire* I had a rule of thumb—if Denzel thought it, I would see it ... And I would articulate it with the different techniques from a hand crank camera to the flashbacks" (Morgan). On the Blu-ray's commentary track, Scott elaborates:

[The kidnap scene] feels like part documentary, part grabbed real footage, and part opera. And the opera part comes from being inside Denzel's head ... [Visual technique is] a new way of telling what your lead actor's thinking.

Scott strategically places the viewer within the narrative experience, the oneiric state, through his concentrated subjectivity style. And like the more aggressive post-classical Hollywood cinema, the audience must organize the fragments and make connections—not in a sense of complete abandonment of the classical Hollywood's reliance on continuity editing, but relying on the contemporary audience's educated sense of film style and narrative and thereby expanding the time and space of continuity editing to find new time and new spaces.

Man on Fire builds a subjective, fragmented narrative wherein the act of watching the film bears similarities to the experiences of the character, who, in effect, represents the film's director. The viewer, like Scott and Creasy/Washington, connects bursts of images to find meaning. The technique is most explicit (and expected) in the action scenes, such as the kidnapping scene at the middle of the story. As Creasy waits for Pita in the park across the street from the music teacher's home, he notices the cars forming for the kidnap and new angles on Creasy appear, such as overhead

shots and lateral movements in inverse of the moving cars; Pita appears moving in slow motion, breaking up the temporal continuity; quick pans digitally enhanced further the break-up of time and place; and when Creasy shoots his pistol to warn Pita, images repeat. As Creasy looks for the assailants, the camera searches the scene, offering flash cuts and repetitions (we see the second bullet hit Creasy five times). The scene builds to an intense subjectivity of distorted images and concludes with Creasy losing consciousness and the screen going black. The editing style, in effect, expands continuity allowing for new time and space. As the sequence unfolds, the audience pieces together the narrative logic from Scott's bursts of images and movement. Granted, most narrative films force viewers to construct time and space, but the hegemony of continuity editing, and its near invisibility, dominated classical Hollywood to the extent that few viewers ever notice the work they must do. In the post-classical Hollywood, continuity editing loses its hegemony. Continuity remains, but in an expanded form, offering fragments within a collection of fragments. David Bordwell labels this "intensified continuity" in *The Way Hollywood Tells It* (2006) and applies it to Tony Scott's films in his blog "Tony and Theo" (121–138). While the crux of Bordwell's argument about intensified continuity lies outside the interests of neo-noir, his explanation does allude to the oneiric state set up by the method: "These techniques are motivated to some degree by story demands: the need to suggest a mental state, to portray a heroic posture, or to amp up a fight or chase" (2013) (Fig. 6.1).



Fig. 6.1 Fragmentation. Watching the film bears similarities to Creasy's experience. *Man on Fire*, Tony Scott, dir., 2004, 20th Century-Fox Blu-ray

While *John Wick* also contains much intensified continuity, Stahelski's technique remains outside of Wick's mental state. The oneiric state, then, exists not in Wick's perception, but in his experience. That is, we enter the oneiric with him, not through him. Though the film spends little time in the "real" world, it exists to differentiate the "dream world" into which we follow Wick (as propelled by his reaction to the home invasion). Very little of the violence spills out into the "real" world; instead Wick stays within the dream underworld. For example, the Continental Hotel. The exterior uses the 1 Wall Street Court, but inside the Continental Hotel operates according to an underworld code of conduct monitored by Winston (Ian McShane), who knows well the legend of John Wick. A labyrinth of passageways and an ornate code of conduct distinguish the Continental—it is another network within a series of interconnected networks (e.g., the Russian mob, a cadre of assassins, etc.). With Wick we enter a Digital Noir world made oneiric by being simultaneously modern and retro (a modern world filled with retro objects). As we learn, Wick has been a much-appreciated customer, but on his current adventure he has become lost in this network and its connections to other networks—the archetypal Digital Noir hero.

Being inside of Creasy's seeing and feeling raises a post-classical consideration of Laura Mulvey's concept of the "male gaze." *Man on Fire* certainly embraces the idea in that the view of the world belongs to Creasy, yet it becomes more than just what he sees and the direction of the "gaze." Tony Scott's concentrated subjectivity makes possible a deeper sense of a controlling gaze. If watching the film equals experiencing the dream, the "gaze" implies another level of control, beyond how the characters in the film see one another and how that influences the viewer's point of view. In *Man on Fire*, the "gaze" becomes the dream. We witness, in Mulvey's language, the male dream. With *John Wick*, Mulvey's "gaze" remains intact—we see things from his superior position of male control and the film's style articulates its oneiric state. The intertextuality of post-classical film, like Digital Noir, may operationalize elements of film theory, such as gender representation and point of view, in a fashion progressed from previous, more classical, consideration.

Many classic noir elements are evoked by *Man on Fire* and *John Wick*. *John Wick* establishes its flashback structure in its opening scene—the viewer sees the events through the lens of Wick's memory, just as Neff

related the story of *Double Indemnity* (1944) or Jeff's story in *Out of the Past* (1947). In *Man on Fire*, Creasy periodically blacks out, such as after his drunken suicide attempt and at the end of the kidnap scene, just as *Murder, My Sweet* fades to black when Marlowe loses consciousness. But Scott does not use the fades as an entry into a dream sequence. Instead, it's more like a curtain closing at the end of an act in the middle of a play. The oneiric quality of the film resides in its post-classical experience. As Scott said, if Creasy sees it, I "articulate" it with film style. Therefore, watching the film becomes an experience similar to the one the hero experiences on-screen. Scott works with a knowledge of film and the audience's film experience: we recognize a major movie star in a contemporary take on a familiar genre (neo-noir), we intuit *Man on Fire* as more of a B-movie than A-movie or prestige picture (it's neither historical nor epic nor based on a major literary work—not a Ridley Scott film), and like the 1940s and 1950s B-movies it evokes, *Man on Fire* offers a surrogate hero, whose experience guides the viewing of the film. The film, not coincidentally, ends when Creasy dies and for the careful viewer the imagery in Creasy's death scene (he stares at a mountain from the backseat of a car) explains images that were flashed early in the film. For example, when Creasy crosses the border into Mexico, he rides in the back of a taxi. He has shaggy hair and scraggly beard, and to introduce the oneiric editing style to the audience, the scene consists of a flood of images, mostly of the border town but also of a clean-cut Creasy and a mountain—images from the end of the film. The last scene of Creasy in the back of hoodlums' car parallels the first time we saw Creasy (in the back seat, his head against the window) and, again, includes a flood of images we recognize as memories for us and for Creasy (and when you see the film for a second time, you understand the flash-forward images of the opening scene). Creasy's death is another threshold crossing, of having entered a series of networks, such as the kidnapper's operation, the corrupt police network, the Federal police network, and the reporter's network of information and sources, and exited the networks. His hostility and single-mindedness acts like a virus within these networks; it disrupts their hegemony (the kidnappers and the corrupt cops have been at it for a long time) so much so that the corrupt are unaware of their eminent demise (or mutilation). The kidnappers keep asking Creasy, "don't you know who I am?" Creasy's ambivalence mystifies them: he knows but he does not care.

The violence Creasy inflicts on kidnappers and the corrupt cops is exceedingly up-close and personal. Whereas previous movements, like the

1980s and 1990s, pushed the violence out into the real world, *Man on Fire* reins it in, though one scene involves blowing up a rave club, where the dancers applaud Creasy's appearance and blasts of his shot gun—instead of running, they cheer. The henchmen working for the Voice shoot Creasy from many yards away, but when Creasy goes after them, he gets up-close and personal—a violent reaction of male anxiety. He duct-tapes the hands of the Voice's brother to the steering wheel of a car and then cuts off one finger at a time (and then cauterizes the wound with the car's cigarette lighter) demanding more information. Creasy captures the corrupt cop and plants a small bomb in the cop's rectum—that he triggers from a countdown timer. Creasy shoots one suspect point blank with a sawed-off shotgun and later blows off what's left of the brother's hand with the same shotgun. The violence inflicted by Creasy becomes analogous to a network virus—he corrupts systems, breaks in, and steals information; he inflicts devastation from the inside out.

Wick's presence also seems virus-like, and the violence he inflicts certainly disrupts the networks. But Wick's violence is not the up-close and personal style of torture as male anxiety. Rather, Wick's violence, intricately choreographed, celebrates his masculinity and dominance. As Tarasov (Michael Nyqvist), the Russian mob boss, recounts the “legend” of John Wick to his wayward son:

John is a man of focus, commitment, sheer will... something you know very little about. I once saw him kill three men in a bar... with a pencil, with a fucking pencil. Then suddenly one day he asked to leave. It's over a woman, of course. So I made a deal with him. I gave him an impossible task. A job no one could have pulled off. The bodies he buried that day laid the foundation of what we are now. And then my son, a few days after his wife died, you steal his car and kill his fucking dog.

Wick's revenge rampage becomes violence as performance, like a dance number in a musical, but instead of expressing love through dance, Wick expresses his neo-noir anxiety with the digital world (Fig. 6.2).

The visual style of *Man on Fire* amplifies the ambivalent hero and the violence, but it also provides an important connection between the oneiric state and the element of engaging the times. *Man on Fire* is very much a movie of the digital era—and not surprising that it would come from Tony Scott. No dinosaurs or superheroes CGI their way through *Man on Fire*; instead *Man on Fire* relies on its B-movie heritage to entice the viewer into



Fig. 6.2 John Wick disrupts the network. *John Wick*, Chad Stahelski, dir., 2014, Summit Entertainment Blu-ray

its high-intensity (i.e., excessive and fragmented) experience of the darker male impulses and frustrations. First, there is simply *more* of *Man on Fire* to take in. On Cinemetrics, a web site that measures average shot length (ASL), *Man on Fire* measured at 2.1 seconds—as an average. For comparison, *The Killers* (1946) measured at 12.1 seconds, and *Bullitt* (1968) measured 6.9 seconds (Cinemetrics). *John Wick* registers 4.0 seconds as an average (roughly average for Digital Noir).

John Wick's style, while combining influences, as Stahelski and Leitch noted earlier, also bears the look of a graphic novel—one that seems to have come to life. *John Wick* evokes much classic noir imagery in a modern digital age fashion, such as urban streets lit for night, seedy bars, alleys, hotel rooms, etc., the elements Foster Hirsch (2006) cites as “noir motifs” (38). Not only does *John Wick* evoke the noir places, but it also evokes the noir’s composition style with ceiling shots, mirror shots, canted angles (Hirsch 38), and lighting techniques. But *John Wick* engages a visual discourse with more than just classic noir style; it also bears elements of previous neo-noir movements, especially Eighties Noir, the pastel pallet diffused in favor of more primary colors, as Lynch used in *Blue Velvet* (1986), and neon, as Michael Mann used in *Thief* (1980). *John Wick* manipulates a singular visual style (a composite of influences) evoking a network of networks in the digital age.

Tony Scott’s use of technique in the sequences of concentrated subjectivity/intensified continuity employs multiple styles and types of footage: hand-cranked camera; “part documentary, part grabbed real

footage, and part opera”; flashbacks; and repetitions. What Scott challenges the viewer to do is process visual and aural information, not for consumer culture, but for the emotional experience. It being neo-noir, the experience becomes a darker consideration. Scott came to feature films after a decade of working for Ridley Scott’s production company, where Tony specialized in high fashion commercials. Again, his sports car commercial in which he associates the car with the jet plane brought him to the attention of Bruckheimer and Simpson, the producers of *Top Gun* (1986). The point is Tony Scott is adept at selling with images and could focus that ability on selling Creasy’s experience in *Man on Fire*. The style, therefore, works the way advertising can work, at a subliminal level of emotion and attraction. The film style—the visuals, the editing, and the sound—sells us on identification with Creasy and his male anxiety, his displacement in the modern world, and the validity of his only way out—death.

The femme fatale is again missing in action in *Man on Fire* and *John Wick*. Had these films been made during the time of classic noir, very likely some transformation of Lisa, Pita’s mother, into a femme fatale would have happened (a sex scene between Creasy and Lisa exists in the screenplay). Instead Lisa becomes an ally of Creasy, even siding with him against her husband when she finds out the husband’s part in the kidnapping scheme. The prominent female character in *John Wick*, Ms. Perkins, is also an assassin—someone almost as good as Wick. And again, in the classical era, she may have been portrayed as a femme fatale. Like other Digital Noirs, the sexual allure and danger of the femme fatale never develops into a major motif. The reasons seem varied and I can only offer guesses. One, the directors of Digital Noir are not directors who emphasize or explore sophisticated female characters. Though Michael Mann, Christopher Nolan, and Sidney Lumet have made films with strong female characters, their Digital Noir efforts leave much room for improved female characters. Michael Mann stepped into femme fatale territory with Isabella (Gong Li) in *Miami Vice*, but the character never developed into the complex figure it could have been. For the remaining directors, their Digital Noir films consistently rely on women as narrative devices (e.g., women to be rescued or avenged). Two, as part of the lost identity theme, many of the stories take place post-relationship (e.g., *Taken*, *Inception*, *John Wick*). To work around the weakness of female characters, the writers and directors strategically set narratives outside of relationships. John Wick and *Inception*’s Cobb are widowers. Creasy, Max of *Collateral*, Wolff of *The Accountant*, and McCall of *The Equalizer*(s) are non-participants. Mills of

the *Taken* franchise is a divorced dad. Three, part of being adrift on the digital landscape(s) and not knowing one's place takes the form of being unattached or detached from sexual relationships—the allure of the noir adventure is not one spurred by sexual anxiety, but one focused on the darker side of self-identification (how do I fit into this world of excess and fragmentation?) without challenging sexual identity through a femme fatale character.

Digital Noir concerns wanderers, metaphors of male social anxiety in the digital age. The Digital Noir hero wanders the grid, interacting with networks, but unable to make substantial connections until the key plot event motivates them to unleash the violent rampage they have managed to keep tamped down. In exerting their identity through violence (i.e., Creasy painting his masterpiece), they establish, or re-establish, identity. Yet, in Digital Noir exerting identity invariably becomes a suicide mission—Creasy dies, but, typically, the Digital Noir hero manages to eke out a survival against incredible odds, establishing identity, but always returning to an identity they sought to abandon, an identity that was not their true self. In the digital age, we constantly establish and re-establish identity within networks, and no single identity accounts for our true, or complete, self. Identity, instead, fragments across numerous, excessive networks and Digital Noir fulfills its purpose as a vehicle for exploring the darker implications of identity in this age.

APPENDIX

Digital Noir Film List

Spy Game (2001), d. Tony Scott
Training Day (2001), d. Antoine Fuqua
The Salton Sea (2002), d. D.J. Caruso
Collateral (2004), d. Michael Mann
Man on Fire (2004), d. Tony Scott
Domino (2005), d. Tony Scott
Miami Vice (2006), d. Michael Mann
Déjà Vu (2006), d. Tony Scott
Before the Devil Knows You're Dead (2007), d. Sidney Lumet
Gone Baby Gone (2007), d. Ben Affleck
Taken (2008), d. Pierre Morel (sequels)
Inception (2010), d. Christopher Nolan

Unknown (2011), d. Jaume Collet-Serra
John Wick (2014), d. Chad Stahelski (sequels)
The Equalizer (2014), d. Antoine Fuqua (sequel)
Blackhat (2015), d. Michael Mann (recut 2017)
The Accountant (2016), d. Gavin O'Connor

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PART II

Thematic Movements



CHAPTER 7

Nostalgia Noir

Key Films

- Badlands* (1973), d. Terrence Malick
Chinatown (1974), d. Roman Polanski
Farewell, My Lovely (1975), d. Dick Richards (Raymond Chandler adaptation)
The Postman Always Rings Twice (1981), d. Bob Rafelson (James M. Cain adaptation)
Miller's Crossing (1990), d. Joel Coen
A Rage in Harlem (1991), d. Bill Duke (Chester Himes adaptation)
Devil in the Blue Dress (1995), d. Carl Franklin (Walter Mosley adaptation)
L.A. Confidential (1997), d. Curtis Hanson (James Ellroy adaptation)
The Nice Guys (2016), d. Shane Black (set in the 1970s)

Classic noir, for the most part, is set in the contemporary world, sometimes with flashbacks to a year or two previous. Classic noir never evokes nostalgia. Being in the post-classical makes possible the concept of a noir that recalls or recreates a previous era of noir. Katherine Farrimond, using the term “retro,” in *The Contemporary Femme Fatale: Gender, Genre, And American Cinema* (2018), contends, “[T]he retro noir genre extends as far as 1974’s *Chinatown*, [and] the 1990s and 2000s saw a more intensive proliferation of these period crime texts” (25). In other words, retro noir, I prefer the term Nostalgia Noir for reasons to be laid out shortly, comprises another piece of the post-classical mosaic of neo-noir: a group of

films similar in that they depict the past, a very specific past—the era of classic film noir.

The notion of nostalgia, noir, and *Chinatown* begins with John Cawelti's seminal essay, "*Chinatown* and Generic Transformation in Recent American Films" of 1978. Cawelti asserted:

The invocation of many other traditional elements of the hard-boiled myth, the *film noir* tone and the 1930s setting cue us to expect the traditional mythical world of the private eye hero. But the presence of color, along with increasing deviations from established patterns of plot, motive and character give us an eerie feeling of one myth colliding with and beginning to give way to others. (499)

Filmmakers deploy elements of plot, character, setting, and style in an effort to recreate a previous time, or, more accurately, a sense of a previous time. "The power of nostalgia," Cawelti writes, "lies especially in its capacity to evoke a sense of warm reassurance by bringing before our mind's eye images from a time when things seemed more secure and full of promise and possibility" (506). Neo-noir, of course, serves a different purpose and calls into question the "reassurance" and "promise" of nostalgia. Nostalgia Noir emphasizes Paul Schrader's notion of film noir possessing "subtle qualities of tone and mood" (53). Farrimond, in post-classical fashion, breaks retro noir into two types: one, period films set in the classic noir era and, two, films not explicitly set in the classic noir era "which rely heavily on an aesthetic of pastness" (24). Similarly, Andrew Spicer (2002) contends, "Two basic tendencies are at work in postmodern noir, revivalism, which attempts to retain the mood and atmosphere (*stimmung*) of classical noir, and hybridization where elements of noir are reconfigured in a complex generic mix" (150). This chapter concerns Farrimond's period films and Spicer's revivalism and uses the term Nostalgia Noir to mean neo-noir films that recreate the classic noir era or, keeping in mind that neo-noir is about 60 years old, an era of neo-noir. The second type indicated by Farrimond as "retro" focuses more on objects and distinct visual signifiers, along with Spicer's hybridization tendency, I label as Hybrid Noir or Homage Noir in upcoming chapters (e.g., *Sin City: A Dame to Kill for* as Hybrid, *The Last Seduction* as Homage). In the years since *Chinatown*, neo-noir generated an ample amount of films recreating past periods, and these films constitute Nostalgia Noir. Farrimond demonstrates the significant possibilities of Nostalgia Noir through her

examination of the femme fatale because she gives emphasis to the political and cultural themes, which, in her words, aim “to showcase the grit and corruption of noir, bringing racism and classism of the period to the surface” (26).

Nostalgia Noir also opens this new section on neo-noir movements bound more by thematic similarities and less by chronology. A variety of movements make up the post-classical Hollywood cinema, and neo-noir specifically, expanding further the notion of fragmentation as a key element of the post-classical. Nostalgia, as the basis of a thematic group, forces us to reconsider how we cluster together neo-noir films. For too long, neo-noir has been relegated to two major cycles of films (Spicer, Bould), lumping together the nostalgic with contemporary and missing the critical differences between the two. The implications of nostalgia, just like the implications of genre hybridity and remake and homage, lie within the intertextuality of the agents involved. With Nostalgia Noir we focus on the layers of how filmmakers evoked the past in search of the strategy within their recreation and, ultimately, how Nostalgia Noir achieves the purpose of neo-noir’s dark discourse of American culture.

In this chapter, three films serve as examples for the discussion: seminal *Chinatown* (Roman Polanski 1974), based on, after a difficult revision process, Robert Towne’s original screenplay; *L.A. Confidential* (Curtis Hanson 1997), based on the James Ellroy 1990 novel; and *The Nice Guys* (Shane Black 2016), one of the first neo-noir films to give neo-noir the nostalgia treatment. Each film represents a style or mode of nostalgia: one establishing the idea or recreating the era of classic noir; one relying on literary adaptation, itself a bitter recreation of noir fiction; and one reminding us that neo-noir, too, now evokes nostalgia.

While *Chinatown* may not technically be the first Nostalgia Noir (*Badlands* [Terrence Malick 1973], set in the 1950s, precedes it by a year), it is the first to film to fully deploy the retro signifiers of classic noir from the contemporary world. Not only do we get the venetian blinds of the detective’s office, the fashions of the era, the bad habits of cigarettes and casual racism, and the familiar character types, including the femme fatale, but we also get another layer of retro signifiers that *seem* to be of the era but in fact were not prominent in the classic films. In 1974, *Chinatown* made a major contribution to the growing mythology that “noir” would become. Hirsch articulates this idea:

“Noir” is not only the name of a cycle of historical crime films, it is also a come-on for promoting new crime movies [...], the brand name for a literary genre, the name of an album by Carly Simon and a perfume; and noir-inspired imagery has invaded fashion and advertising. [...] Co-opted by a range of pop cultural discourses, noir has been dispersed across the social fabric. (5)

Nostalgia Noir clarifies, for example, a “co-opted” feature, an element that feels/seems “noir,” but in fact was a rarity—the moody, jazz score featuring a lone muted trumpet or a lone saxophone. Most classic film noirs featured traditional orchestral scores. Richard R. Ness (2008) provides a detailed music-savvy analysis of film noir and neo-noir scores. Ness explains “The scores for *noir* films eschewed the European-influenced, neoromantic style of film music in favor of a more modernistic, ‘urban’ American sound that incorporated contemporary techniques and popular musical idioms” (52). Bluesy jazz scores did not dominate classic noir. “Such elements,” writes Ness, “often were subtly incorporated within a more symphonic structure or relegated to scenes meant to demonstrate the nocturnal urban environment” (55). The retro signifier of Nostalgia Noir came to include a style of music that was not dominant in classic noir but came to dominate the collective memory, or mythology, of classic noir films. *Chinatown* probably did more to establish retro music than any other film. By the 1980s, according to Ness, the style and purpose of “noir” music reached clarity: “The melodic horn themes that dominate many *noir* films of the 1970s and 1980s are meant to evoke a sense of a musical past. They are intended to generate a feeling of the way audiences think *films noirs* sounded” (69).

Nostalgia Noirs that recreate the classic noir world, or a neo-noir world, combine visual and audio element motifs prominent during the depicted era (Miklitsch 2009), such as retro signifiers like venetian blinds, private detectives, and femme fatales, along with signifiers not of the period films but ones that have become a part of the cultural mythology associated with “noir,” like the saxophone solos. Because of the Production Code in effect during the classical Hollywood era, sexual elements were implied. Similarly, ethnicity was often whitewashed and acceptable stereotypes reaffirmed. For example, from Chandler’s novel, *Farewell, My Lovely*, we know that the nightclub where Velma once worked has become an African American nightclub. In the 1946 version, *Murder, My Sweet*, the patrons are white. What few African Americans and Asian Americans we see in

classic noir are in stereotypical roles, such as servants. Nostalgia constantly reminds us that we look to the past through the prism of the current moment and the dark discourse in which Nostalgia Noir engages rests in an intertextual negotiation between the past and the present.

Chinatown, *L.A. Confidential*, and *The Nice Guys* offer three negotiations of the past, or three modes of nostalgia, and because each offers a different “dream” of the past, the element of oneiric state, or oneiricism, comes to the foreground. By coincidence, each film goes back about 40 years (*Chinatown*, 1974–1937; *L.A. Confidential*, 1997–1953/1954; *The Nice Guys*, 2016–1977). At an obvious level, *Chinatown* evokes a dream of classic noir, but with a distinctly modern purpose. As Thomas Doherty (2012) puts it, “[*Chinatown*] is not genre revisionist exactly but genre stretching, pushing the tropes of Hammett and Chandler, and Huston and Hawks, into new terrain” (19). But *Chinatown* is also Roman Polanski’s very personal vision, one in which he uses/manipulates neo-noir and nostalgia to excise his own demons. Polanski offers “a dark parable about human nature, expressing a fatalistic world view shaped by his childhood in Nazi-occupied Poland” and then reinforced when the Manson family murdered his wife, Sharon Tate, in 1969 (Benedetto 49). Polanski’s “dream” concerns the present, using nostalgia as invoked by *Chinatown* as disguise. In Eaton’s words, “*Chinatown* tells a story which was absolutely modern, which was so much a product of its time, even though it is set nearly forty years before [...]. It is a story which says, sure, wrongs can ultimately be *uncovered* but the seeker after truth is not only completely incapable of righting them, but his very search will only make matters worse” (21).

Sam Wasson, in *The Big Goodbye: Chinatown and the Last of Hollywood* (2020), documents Towne and Polanski’s conflicts over revising Towne’s lengthy and wandering first draft of *Chinatown*. The contentious process of paring Towne’s early drafts not only became a battle of what *Chinatown* would become but also a battle for its soul. Wasson writes:

Not only was the pursuit of narrative economy intellectually taxing, but condensing the story forced Towne, at every turn, to sacrifice creative darlings he had nurtured for years. Removing them from his script at this point would be removing parts of himself.... Resigned to the natural course of production, Town understood: There was nothing he could do. *Chinatown* was Roman Polanski’s now. (iBook)

For neo-noir and the ascendancy of *Chinatown*, a crucial point needs stating: in re-structuring the screenplay for the film version, Polanski, in effect, wrestled Gittes (Jack Nicholson) as a surrogate character away from Towne. Polanski signs Gittes' surrogacy with *Chinatown's* notorious ending. Towne has come to agree that Polanski's ending was better than the ending in Towne's first draft (Benedetto 1999). In explaining what he once believed was Polanski's "literal and ghoulishly bleak" ending, Towne also explains how the film became Polanski's oneiric state: "Roman's argument was: That's life ... Beautiful blondes die in Los Angeles. Sharon had. He didn't say that, but that's what he felt" (Towne ii, Biskind 72, Benedetto 53, Hirsch 153). *Chinatown's* oneiric state demonstrates the possibilities of personal expression, not only in film writ large but also in neo-noir and nostalgia. Noir and nostalgia, as *Chinatown* makes clear, may be very personal.

L.A. Confidential, on the other hand, begins with dark, complex source material and moves the oneiric state to much lighter territory. As Lyons (1997) contends, "The Hanson-[Brian] Helgeland script is a miracle of excision, condensation, compression, and heightening" (11). Hanson and Helgeland work within Cawelti's conception of nostalgia as "reaffirmation" and "full of promise and possibility" (506). In condensing the novel, Helgeland developed the Rollo Tomasi plot device, which brings about a tidy ending not seen in Ellroy's novel. *L.A. Confidential*, the film, re-negotiates similar nostalgic territory as *Chinatown* but it also negotiates *Chinatown*. As Palmer contends, "*L.A. Confidential* is the nineties version of *Chinatown* neo-noir. [...] Even the central imagery of *L.A. Confidential*, that of eyes, of seeing clearly, of spying and voyeurism, or photography, is directly lifted from *Chinatown*" (57). In *L.A. Confidential*, beautiful blondes do not die and corrupt cops make noir decisions to take down other cops more corrupt than themselves. The aspirational dream of redemption comes to fruition. Hence, the dream of *L.A. Confidential* takes place in a much different Los Angeles than that of *Chinatown*.

Yet another Los Angeles appears in *The Nice Guys*, which re-negotiates neo-noir of the 1970s from the position of 2010s. Whereas previous Nostalgia Noirs, like *Chinatown* and *L.A. Confidential*, negotiated the classic noir period from the post-classical neo-noir era, with *The Nice Guys* neo-noir begins a contemplation of itself, or, more accurately, an earlier piece of Hollywood's post-classical cinema. Comic irony tints Shane Black's sense of nostalgia, neo-noir, and oneiric state in *The Nice Guys*. Whereas the nostalgic past of Los Angeles seen in *Chinatown* or

L.A. Confidential portrays a beautiful, glamorous world, below which hides an ugly noir world of corruption and evil, in *The Nice Guys* the nostalgic past operates in a smog-shrouded, corruption-laced Los Angeles, and the beauty of the city lies below the surface. The nostalgia of *The Nice Guys* does not evoke a beauty to be undone; rather it evokes a gritty world in which being a “private eye” still seemed possible—and fun (Fig. 7.1).

The nostalgic dream, then, involves coming to understand the noir hero as a person of the past with a contemporary problem. The key to understanding Gittes, and *Chinatown*, is the title. What does “Chinatown” mean? From the elements of noir, we see “Chinatown” pointing to the oneiric state. If Towne had had his way, the story would never have gone to Chinatown (yet the first draft contains much more expository information about what Gittes and Escobar did in Chinatown) and the Chinatown Dream would linger over the film. In Polanski’s film, though, the events move toward an inevitable conclusion in Chinatown. Chinatown, as the film guides us to believe, acts as the source of Gittes’ ambivalence. Like other aspects of the film, Gittes appears beautiful on the outside: sharp suits, successful business, and ascendancy. Polanski limits (edits?) our knowledge of Gittes’ time in Chinatown. In the post-coital scene with Evelyn Mulwray (Faye Dunaway), Gittes confesses two key pieces of information about Chinatown: one, “it’s bad luck ... you can’t always tell what’s going on,” and two, “I was trying to keep someone from being hurt, I ended up making sure that she was hurt.” Gittes’ ambivalence



Fig. 7.1 Los Angeles shrouded in smog. *The Nice Guys*, Shane Black, dir., 2016, Warner Bros. Home Video Blu-ray

stems from believing he has escaped “Chinatown,” when in fact his actions only set in motion his return and end up making sure that someone will be hurt again. Gittes’ ambivalence reflects Polanski’s fatalism. “Chinatown,” then, becomes a metaphorical presence of inevitable violence and powerlessness, neo-noir territory for Gittes/Polanski, as well as the early 1970s’ world view haunted by Vietnam, Watergate, assassinations, and social oppressions.

In *L.A. Confidential*, inevitable violence and powerlessness exist not as end points or world views, but as narrative obstacles to be overcome. For Gittes, the noir journey went from a faux sense of well-being to darkness, but for the heroes of *L.A. Confidential*, the noir world exists as a temporary state—you realize how it surrounds you and then you get yourself out of it. The noir world, according to *L.A. Confidential*, is temporary. Therefore, the ambivalence that motivates the three central characters also becomes temporary. The three main characters, Ed Exley (Guy Pearce), Bud White (Russell Crowe), and Jack Vincennes (Kevin Spacey), begin the narrative at low levels of police work. The machinations of Dudley Smith (James Cromwell) eventually reach the three main characters. The secret story, the story the main characters (and the audience) do not know, details Smith’s aim to oust organized crime from L.A. and run it himself. Exley represents the political/intellectual noir journey (he must eventually compromise his principles), White is brute force experiencing an existential crisis (he must decide upon whom he will direct his violence), and Vincennes stands in for the “flash” associated with Hollywood—he helps Sid Hudgens (Danny DeVito) with celebrity busts and passes along pay-offs (he must decide to finally act like a “real cop”). Hanson and Helgeland infuse *L.A. Confidential* with concerns of the 1990s: redeeming imperfect heroes, like Bill Clinton or Andy Dufresne of *The Shawshank Redemption* (1994). In adapting Ellroy’s tainted dream of Los Angeles (e.g., Vincennes, known as “Trashcan Jack” because he left jazz great Charlie Parker in a trashcan, is arbitrarily killed), Hanson and Helgeland dial back Ellroy’s narrative (excising and condensing characters and structuring the plot into conventional three-act, reaffirming form) and rely on the “retro” use of objects and visuals to establish the nostalgia. In other words, the film adds hope and redemption, along the lines of Cawelti’s conception of nostalgia, the 1990s are acted out in 1950s costumes and settings, and ambivalence becomes a temporary state on the path to a new identity. For similar hope and redemption in 1990s films, see *The Shawshank Redemption* (1994), *Pulp Fiction* (1994), and Nineties Noirs such as *Heat* (1995), *Jackie*

Brown (1997), and the sub-group of films about an innocent character stumbling upon a treasure (e.g., *True Romance* [1993]) or a terror (e.g., *Nick of Time* [1995]). In the mode of Nineties Noir, *L.A. Confidential* circles back to identity. Each of the three heroes eventually answers the question Dudley Smith poses to Exley, “Why did you become a cop?”

The Nice Guys reject the idea of nostalgia below a beautiful surface. Instead of a beautiful Los Angeles, we see a smoggy, crowded, a bit run-down, and corrupt city. And instead of beautiful central characters like Gittes, Evelyn Mulwray, Jack Vincennes, and Lynn Bracken, the heroes of *The Nice Guys*, Holland March (Ryan Gosling) and Jackson Healy (Russell Crowe), appear slovenly, one overweight, one alcoholic, and both rather dumb. The heroes become equally as shabby as the city they navigate. Whereas *Chinatown* had the water motif and *L.A. Confidential* had Hollywood glamor as a theme, *The Nice Guys* makes pollution its central motif. The skyline is consistently smoggy, families are consistently broken, and what movies we see are pornography. The hidden ugliness of previous Nostalgia Noir has become the norm in the 1970s. March and Healy each begin the story with much ambivalence—March’s alcoholism seems to get worse over the course of the narrative, he remains a terrible father to his 12-year-old daughter, and his only redeeming value seems to be he managed to obtain a private investigator’s license. Healy, on the other hand, begins as a thug working for high school girls and then becomes the closest thing to “brains” when the heroes team up. At one point, Gosling and Crowe launch into an Abbott and Costello routine with Gosling as the goofy Costello character who cannot get out his partner’s name because he is so overcome with fear. The heroes of *The Nice Guys* know the world is corrupt; they know they cannot do anything about it; they just want to make a couple of bucks as private detectives and show no interest in changing the world—it was okay to do that in the 1970s. They are not noir heroes with violent pasts, but rather a couple of losers who find themselves in a violent world.

Most of the violence in *Chinatown* happens off-screen, “repressed” in Naremore’s (1998, 207) words, except for a few shocking moments. Faces, specifically eyes, bear the brunt of the violence: Curly’s wife’s black eye, Gittes’ nose, Evelyn’s face when Gittes slaps her, and Evelyn’s eye at the end. Most writers (e.g., Eaton and others) acknowledge eyes/glasses and water as major motifs in *Chinatown*, and the violence amplifies those motifs. Polanski associates the violence with seeing: Curly beats his wife after he has seen Gittes’ photographic evidence of her infidelity in the

opening scene and the “midget,” played by Polanski, cuts Gittes’ nose because Gittes has seen too much. The famous ending of *Chinatown* not only brings the narrative full circle, but it also brings the violence and eye/seeing motif to a logical conclusion. Gittes’ impotence culminates in being handcuffed to the detective, Loach, who shoots Evelyn as she drives away. Gittes can only watch the violence happen. Katherine, Evelyn’s daughter/sister, screams in horror in the car until Noah Cross (John Huston), her “grandfather,” wraps one of his big hands over her eyes. According to Naremore, “*Chinatown* becomes a study in the sadistic gaze, and it ends when Gittes finds himself an unwitting accomplice in the death of the woman he is spying upon” (207). In *Chinatown*, the up-close, personal violence inflicted upon faces and eyes accentuates the film’s sense of malaise. Escobar demands Gittes’ assistants, Walsh and Duffy, take Gittes away, and Gittes takes a few steps and gestures as if he wants to look again, which is when Walsh steps up to him and tells him, “Forget it, Jake. It’s Chinatown.” Violence, as *Chinatown* demonstrates, can enhance/amplify a neo-noir’s thematic concerns. It can also reflect the director’s world view (Fig. 7.2).

Violence in *L.A. Confidential*, on the other hand, becomes a part of the entertainment. Like *Chinatown*, *L.A. Confidential* ambles toward an inevitable violent conclusion, yet Hanson and Helgeland fail to bring any thematic value to the violence. The casual voyeurism seems a humdrum part of the job—Sid Hudgens giggles as he takes elicited photos of Exley and Lynn Bracken and the cops stifle yawns as they look through the samples



Fig. 7.2 The up-close violence inflicted upon faces. *Chinatown*, Roman Polanski, dir., 1974, Paramount Blu-ray

of pornography—disconnected from any thematic connection to violence. The big shoot-out at the end, at the appropriately named Victory Motel, works as a crowd pleaser rather than a summation of the film's themes. However, two moments of violence amplifying themes in the film do bubble to the surface. The first happens when Jack Vincennes, having been overcome with guilt about sending the struggling actor/male prostitute to seduce the DA, arrives at the motel too late. The actor/prostitute has had his throat slit and died with his eyes open—eerily staring up at Vincennes. The main characters experience brief moments of seeing something of themselves in their victims, an exchange of looks—as if the noir hero were looking in a mirror. Earlier in the film, Exley exchanged looks with Inez, the gang-rape victim, and Bud White looks over the dead body of Pierce Patchett, the pimp who controlled Lynn Bracken. These moments, though, do not build to any conclusion (Fig. 7.3).

The violence in *The Nice Guys* usually plays for comedy, but it also mocks the corrupt world that Los Angeles has become in the 1970s. Much of the violence occurs in public spaces, often destroying family homes. The film opens with a car careening down a hill—and through a house, nearly killing a teenage boy. March and Healy fight some henchmen at the home of a pornography producer, who they later find dead (Robert Downey, Jr., in an uncredited cameo). A major gun fight breaks out at March's rented home, tearing the place up. People get hurt and blood sprays when the bullets hit, but the violence never attains the resonance of the violence in *Chinatown*. The rough action and violence motivate the



Fig. 7.3 The exchange of looks. *L.A. Confidential*, Curtis Hanson, dir., 1997, Warner Bros. Home Video Blu-ray

comedy of the film; the action scenes work as comedic routines. The violence, such as it is, fuels a dark sense of humor, just like the other aspects of the film.

Chinatown and *L.A. Confidential* are very beautiful films. *The Nice Guys*, not so much. Nostalgia often casts an angelic glow on its subject, and *Chinatown* and *L.A. Confidential* rely on that expectation, but *The Nice Guys* plays against that expectation. *Chinatown*'s visual style relies on the angelic glow of nostalgia, only to twist it against expectations as the film progresses to its dark conclusion. The Los Angeles settings are beautiful; the main characters, especially Gittes and Evelyn Mulwray, are attractive; many of the retro objects that help build the world are also alluring (e.g., the pocket watches, the cars, the restaurants, the office spaces). But as we enter these spaces and get to know them, the darkness they contain reveals itself. For example, the Mulwray home, when we first see it, appears beautiful, with appointed rooms, a patio, and manicured lawns tended by the Asian gardeners. Later, we find out that Noah Cross killed Hollis Mulwray in this garden—drowned in the pond.

Polanski takes us through these spaces in a strategic fashion. Polanski shoots most of the film from Gittes' point of view. Importantly, it's not a subjective view (i.e., we do not see his vision), but a companion view—we are not Gittes per se; we are with Gittes, usually looking over his shoulder or turning as he turns. Polanski subtly reminds us we are *not* one of the characters, but we do accompany the main character as he moves through the space of the story. We are complicit in Gittes' adventure, not necessarily an accomplice as much as we are casual voyeurs allowed a privileged point of view. Polanski, in other words, creates a neo-noir viewing experience, one which relies on a mistaken sense of nostalgia only to shock us with the ugliness of the underworld we have entered.

Along with a recreation of Los Angeles circa 1937, the visual style in *Chinatown* emphasizes two dominant motifs: seeing and water. These motifs take a variety of forms. For example, the seeing motif consists of many references to eyes, often Evelyn's eyes. Evelyn often touches her eyes, Jake spots the flow in her eye, and of course the culmination of being shot through the eye in the ending. But Polanski also adds the seeing motif with windows and lenses and photographs. The film opens with the black and white photos of Curly's wife—the work of Gittes and his team, Gittes photographs Hollis Mulwray and we see a reflection in the camera's lens, Gittes berates Walsh for his photography work when Walsh takes pictures of Noah Cross and Hollis Mulwray, we first see Noah Cross in

photographs, when the orange grove farmers beat Gittes they break out one lens in Gittes' sunglasses, the clue that gives Cross away as the murderer is his bifocals, to follow Evelyn's car Gittes breaks one tail light, and Gittes, with the camera/us right over his shoulder, looks through many windows. The characters in *Chinatown* look through prisms that often distort what they see—not unlike the audience watching the film.

The water motif builds to a complex set of considerations. Noah Cross finds a starting point when he explains to Gittes that Hollis Mulwray was fascinated by tide pools, because “that’s where life begins.” But, ironically, life seems to end in water in *Chinatown*: Cross drowns Mulwray in the pond and then dumps the body in the reservoir, the homeless guy in the morgue drowned while sleeping under the bridge during the draught, and the orange grove farmers are terrorized by someone poisoning their wells. Polanski also adds smaller, subtler touches of the water motif and death throughout the film: during the barbershop scene an overheated car with steam pouring from the radiator can be seen through the window (!); in Towne’s first draft, Noah Cross’s first name is Julian—Polanski changed it to Noah, and the utility Mulwray heads is called “Water and Power.” Again, *Chinatown* flips expectations, turning the hopeful water motif, as Michael Mann used it in *Heat*, into an association with the darker and primal aspects of human nature. When Noah Cross tells Gittes, “Most people never have to face the fact that at the right time and the right place, they’re capable of anything,” we know the “anything” contains diabolical events. The visual style of the film does much more than build the nostalgia; it contributes to the darker themes and experience of the film.

The visual style of *Chinatown* also works with the violence the film contains. Consider, again, the ending of the film—all the narrative and themes coming together in Chinatown. Elements of the visual style also contribute to the impact of this scene. Evelyn is shot by Loach, the police including Gittes still handcuffed to Loach, and bystanders hurry to car. Katherine screams and Cross takes her away. We look over Gittes’ shoulder to see Evelyn’s body fall from the car and glimpse the awful, disturbing exit wound in her face—a glaring detail of the aftermath of violence rarely seen in films. It’s not that the exit wound is realistic, but that we see it at all, when in most films, even in the 1970s, such extreme consequences of violence were rarely witnessed. Again, we see it as we accompany Gittes. At this point, all the beauty of *Chinatown* has been drained from the film, leaving us, with Gittes, as impotent viewers—in Polanski’s Los Angeles of 1974.

The visual style of *L.A. Confidential* never rises to the thematic level of *Chinatown*, which is certainly a lot to ask of it. But, as Palmer points out, *L.A. Confidential* does instigate a “spin” on *Chinatown*, but so much of *L.A. Confidential* is about spin and the visual style works to accentuate the irony of glamorous beauty. The opening montage sets the tone for the visual irony. As we hear the song “Accentuate the Positive,” we see travelogue images of Los Angeles in the early 1950s, of people enjoying life in Los Angeles. Sid Hudgens, the reporter for *Hush-Hush* magazine, narrates in his hipster style, undercutting much of the imagery. Sid claims Los Angeles is “paradise on earth. That’s what they tell ya anyway, because they’re selling an image.” Sid then concludes, “How could organized crime exist in the city with the best police department in the world?” For Palmer, “This opening credits montage combines the images plus the ironic song plus the voice-over narrative to create a layered effect that embodies the concept of spin” (58). The surface beauty and glamor of the film provides for ironic contradiction; everyone is spinning in *L.A. Confidential*. The color film faithfully recreates the black and white world of *Badge of Honor* (a reference to Jack Webb’s *Dragnet*), itself an ironic juxtaposition to the corrupt cops and politicians. Lynn Bracken, the prostitute imitating Veronica Lake, also spins her beauty in femme fatale fashion, luring men into her web (where they become black and white photos of illicit behavior—not unlike the photos that open *Chinatown*).

The visual style of *L.A. Confidential* relies on beauty, more specifically, our memory of beauty. Like the characters in the film, *L.A. Confidential* lures the viewer in with beautiful imagery only to undercut the beauty with other aspects of the filmmaking, like Sid’s recurring narration, the periodic violence, or the corruption of the politicians and law enforcement. This is a key point of nostalgia as a point around which a movement of neo-noir films may cluster. *L.A. Confidential* evokes a dream of Los Angeles and the beauty of the images influences how we remember those times—especially as film noir. We see the characters of classic noir, compromised male heroes on the edges of the underworld, femme fatales luring men to their doom, real places and people that filled classic noir (Lana Turner, The Brown Derby), and the corrupt world in which the stories took place. Crucially, the imagery of *L.A. Confidential* evokes our dream of how the film noir world may have existed—not how it really existed, but how we, the 1990s audience, wished it existed.

The Nice Guys, on the other hand, dispense with any concept of the beautiful dream. The opening image of the film sets the tone for what’s to

come: the camera rises from behind the dilapidated Hollywood sign to see Los Angeles at night. The famous “sign” establishes the film’s view of the nostalgic world we’re about to enter, dirty, broken down, and well beyond any days of glory (not unlike the heroes of the film). Shane Black seems determined to not go the route of *Chinatown* or *L.A. Confidential*. His visual style sets up the dirty Los Angeles, asking us to recall a time when things were not as good (or clean) as they are now. What had been beneath the surface in previous Nostalgia Noir becomes the surface in *The Nice Guys*.

The Nice Guys, nevertheless, share many traits with *Chinatown* and *L.A. Confidential* and the bulk of Nostalgia Noir that paints the past with beautiful imagery. First, *The Nice Guys*, like other Nostalgia Noirs, works as a dream of a previous time, ironic and jaded but very much a neo-noir dream of the past. All the neo-noir character types appear—private detectives, femme fatales, henchmen, the Chandleresque rich man at the center of the corruption, and the usual assortment of minor characters often seen in noir, like bartenders, politicians, and traitors. When Gittes asks Noah Cross what he wants to buy with his millions that he cannot already buy, Cross responds, “The Future.” *The Nice Guys* offers a version of that future, a “dream” or nightmare that many Nostalgia Noirs suggest—the noir world becomes the norm, not the underworld.

Much of the dream, within the three sample films, revolves around the femme fatale. And unlike much of neo-noir, the femme fatale still plays a dominating role in Nostalgia Noir. How the femme fatale fares within the narrative speaks to the point of view of the nostalgia, or the historical position from which the films were made. Evelyn Mulwray of *Chinatown* represents the collateral damage of 1970s politics as well as Polanski’s own nightmare vision. Evelyn seems a 1970s recreation of the doomed femme fatale, echoing Helen Grayle/Velma Valento (Claire Trevor) in *Murder, My Sweet* (1944), Cora Smith (Lana Turner) in *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (1946), or Kathy Moffat (Jane Greer) in *Out of the Past* (1947). Lynn Bracken of *L.A. Confidential* aligns with the femme fatales of classic noir who reform, often miraculously, at the end of the film and ride off with the hero, as does Gilda (Rita Hayworth) in *Gilda* (1946) and Elizabeth (Ava Gardner) in *The Bribe* (1949). *The Nice Guys* offers a panoply of femme fatales, all of whom work their devious and not-so-devious plans. For the women of *The Nice Guys*, the two heroes are just men to be manipulated. One of them is even played by Kim Basinger, who played Lynn Bracken in *L.A. Confidential*. *The Nice Guys* opts out of an explicit

femme fatale but doles out bits of femme fatale-like character business. Amelia, the young woman whom the heroes are tasked with finding, resonates with Kathy in *Out of the Past* or Velma in *Murder, My Sweet* or its remake *Farewell, My Lovely* (1975) and has her own agenda. Being found by the heroes will only upset her plan. Like the other aspects of *The Nice Guys*, the complicated women the heroes encounter are lost on them. March and Healy fare even less well than Ned Racine in *Body Heat* (1981), who, at least, figures out Matty's plan in the end.

As Farrimond points out, not only do femme fatale characters have their own iconography (costume, hair, makeup, cigarettes, etc.), but they also have narrative tropes, a significant one being the glamorous entrance. The entrance not only establishes the femme fatale character, but it also sets up the male gaze and a set of narrative expectations. The real Evelyn Mulwray first appears in the "Chinaman Joke" scene of *Chinatown*. Polanski's use of obstructed view and positioning gives Evelyn the dominant position in the scene (Gittes does not realize she stands behind him as he tells his racist joke). Evelyn's costuming (glamor circa 1937) immediately identifies her as the femme fatale, positioning establishes her as superior to Gittes (she always knows more than Gittes) and it is also one of the few moments where the audience knows more than Gittes, and Polanski frames her within a doorway (one of many she will pass through in this scene), very stern and very still. After Gittes' joke falls flat, he turns to Evelyn and her superiority humiliates him. Place and Peterson (1974) deconstructed the frame-within-a-frame motif, pointing out how a doorway may separate the character from others, and of women "the silently omniscient framed face becom[es] a mocking reminder of the threat of the real woman" (68). Polanski's view of Los Angeles begins with Gittes and Evelyn Mulwray's connection and her femme fatale iconography foreshadows her inevitable doom.

Lynn Bracken, on the other hand, makes her glamorous entrance at the liquor store when Bud White picks up the police department's booze for the Christmas party. Farrimond describes Lynn's entrance, noting the Veronica Lake impersonation (Lynn imitates a femme fatale from the 1940s), and her costume, the hooded cloak, recalls Kathy Moffett in *Out of the Past*. To this I would point out how the camera positioning establishes Bud's male gaze. The camera's move mimics Bud's POV; we see Lynn as Bud sees her. Not only is Lynn established as a femme fatale in her glamorous costume but also as the object of Bud's vision. In the 1990s, as Farrimond contends, "the femme fatale is identifiable initially not because

of her deadly and deceptive behavior, but because of her visual coding” (30). Nostalgia Noir, then, relies on that dream imagery to evoke a familiar starting point, but the historical context of the film’s making determines that path for the femme fatale in Nostalgia Noir. Evelyn Mulway headed to her doom, but Lynn Bracken heads in the opposite direction. Farrimond explains:

L.A. Confidential disarms Lynn’s femme fatale appearance in a very different way. She too moves from the status of potential threat to victim after she is beaten up by Bud following her participation in blackmail photos as ordered by her pimp. Following this, she is styled very differently from her previous satin Veronica Lake outfits. [...] Her role changes again at the end of the film, as she says goodbye to Ed before taking the injured Bud to Arizona with her. In this scene, the Veronica Lake hair has been cut short and styled into a shorter, frothier Marilynesque affair [...]. Lynn finally finds a bright and optimistic future as a model of 1950s femininity in the position of dress shop owner and as Bud’s partner and nurse. (31–32).

Like Gilda, the narrative redeems Lynn. Tying in with Nineties Noir, Lynn finds a new identity, rejecting the ruse of the femme fatale. Jans B. Wager (2005) refers to Lynn Bracken as a “pastiche femme fatale” (83). Visual coding builds up her femme fatale identity, but “unlike the dangerous dames of film noir, she in no way drives the narrative or influences the outcome of events” (84). Nostalgia Noir may rely on pastiche, a collection of retro objects, to imply one aspect of the past, but end up revealing attitudes of the present. For Wager, the pastiche femme fatales, like Lynn Bracken, “accept or ignore male lack” and “offer a toned-down, bland, and domesticated version of femininity” (88).

The femme fatale of *The Nice Guys* rejects the visual coding of classic noir. Periodically, Black teases us with the possibility. For example, March develops a crush on Judith Kuttner’s (Kim Basinger) assistant, Tally, who ends up betraying March and Healy, but March fails to see the betrayal because Tally’s glamorous appearance stuns him. Even Amelia, the object of their task, baffles them with her explanation of how her art/porno film can bring down the car industry. About the only aspect of her motivation March and Healy understand is that Amelia is the daughter of Kuttner. Thinking they have secured the “prize,” March and Healy stash Amelia with March’s daughter and her friend in a closet while they shoot it out with Kuttner’s assassin. During the shoot-out, Amelia slips away from

March's house. The gunfight ends, but the assassin manages to get away in his car. As he drives out of the neighborhood, he comes upon Amelia hitch-hiking. He pulls over and shoots her. Ultimately, *The Nice Guys* bears similarities to the Digital Noir of the 2000s in that the femme fatale becomes a missing figure. The crazy, dark dream of *The Nice Guys* affirms the male bonding seen in so many neo-noir movements and simply opts out of the sexual anxiety of the femme fatale. Sexual tension/anxiety is replaced with violence/action anxiety as March and Healy worry much more about their ability to "perform" as private eyes, as fathers, and as professionals within the "polluted" world, because irony keeps beating them—as it does when Amelia meets her violent end.

Nostalgia Noir, then, becomes a consideration of neo-noir as a dark dream of the past. If the purpose of neo-noir is to reflect the darker aspects of the culture, then Nostalgia Noir focuses on our collective memories. Consequently, seeing, media, and media spin appear consistently as motifs of Nostalgia Noir, a neo-noir movement much more concerned with analyzing its precedents than other neo-noir movements. *Chinatown* and *L.A. Confidential* evoke beautiful, dream-like imagery to undercut the collective memory of classic noir. *Farewell, My Lovely* (Dick Richards 1975) offers a more faithful (but not entirely) adaptation of Chandler's novel and thereby demonstrates the many things the 1944 version, *Murder, My Sweet* tamped down because of production standards. Nostalgia Noir concentrates on the intertextual past/present dynamic, but each film brings something new to conversation: Bob Rafelson's version of *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (1981) brings the sexual content to the foreground, Carl Franklin challenges notion of race in neo-noir with *Devil in the Blue Dress* (1995), and the Coen Brothers work through multiple layers of Chandler referencing in *The Man Who Wasn't There* (2001). From the sample films of this chapter, we see that the dream can be very personal and in the case of *Chinatown* aspire to art film. The point of view of the 1990s, nostalgia for a past era of prosperity can reinforce the prosperity of the current moment. From Wagers' point of view, Nostalgia Noir, like neo-noir in general, "almost never feature real femme fatales; pastiche femmes fatales tend to take their places.... retro-noirs ameliorate the threat of a powerful woman by erasing her entirely from most narratives" (76). Wager sees neo-noir building "an ideologically safe site for the portrayal of reactionary representations of gender; of muscular, violent, and successful white masculinity; and of passive and objectified femininity" (76). And by the time of *The Nice Guys*, the "safe site" of nostalgia, as

well as neo-noir, becomes a target for parody. And parody returns us to Cawelti's concepts of the transformation of genres, as parody is one of his modes of transformation. Neo-noir is constantly transforming, as is our nostalgic memory of what was once film noir and neo-noir.

APPENDIX

Nostalgia Noir Film List

Note: Set in the period of classic noir (late-thirties to 1960), unless otherwise noted. If based on a novel, titles are the same unless noted.

- Badlands* (1973), d. Terrence Malick
Chinatown (1974), d. Roman Polanski
Thieves Like Us (1974), d. Robert Altman (Also Remake Noir)
Farewell, My Lovely (1975), d. Dick Richards (Raymond Chandler adaptation, also Remake Noir)
The Brink's Job (1978), d. William Friedkin
True Confessions (1981), d. Ulu Grosbard
The Postman Always Rings Twice (1981), d. Bob Rafelson (James M. Cain adaptation)
Philip Marlowe, Private Eye (1982 and 1986), HBO TV series
Dead Men Don't Wear Plaid (1982), d. Carl Reiner (parody using clips from classic noir films)
Hammett (1982), d. Wim Wenders
Poodle Springs (1998), d. Bob Rafelson (Chandler adaptation)
Crime Story (1986–1988), TV series, Chuck Adamson and Gustave Reininger, creators, Michael Mann, producer (set in the early 1960s)
Private Eye (1987–1988) TV series, Anthony Yerkovich, creator
The Two Jakes (1990), d. Jack Nicholson
Miller's Crossing (1990), d. Joel Coen
The Hot Spot (1990), d. Dennis Hopper (adaptation of Charles Williams' *Hell Hath No Fury* [1953])
A Rage in Harlem (1991), d. Bill Duke (Chester Himes adaptation)
Barton Fink (1991), d. Joel Coen
Devil in the Blue Dress (1995), d. Carl Franklin (Walter Mosley adaptation)
The Last Man Standing (1996), d. Walter Hill (adaptation of Kurosawa's *Yojimbo*)
L.A. Confidential (1997), d. Curtis Hanson (James Ellroy adaptation)

This World, Then the Fireworks (1997), d. Michael Oblowitz (Jim Thompson short story adaptation)
The Man Who Wasn't There (2001), d. Joel Coen
L.A. Confidential (2003) TV pilot
Black Dahlia (2006), d. Brian De Palma (James Ellroy adaptation)
Hollywoodland (2006), d. Allen Coulter
Mulholland Falls (2006), d. Lee Tamahori
Lonely Hearts (2006), d. Todd Robinson
The Killer Inside Me (2010), d. Michael Winterbottom
Gangster Squad (2013), d. Ruben Fleischer
Mob City (2013), TV mini-series, Frank Darabont, creator
Inherent Vice (2014), d. Paul Thomas Anderson (set in the 1970s)
Public Morals (2015), TV mini-series, Edward Burns, creator/director
 (set in the early 1960s)
The Nice Guys (2016), d. Shane Black (set in the 1970s)
Free Fire (2016), d. Ben Wheatley (set in the 1970s)
Live By Night (2016), d. Ben Affleck
I Am the Night (2019), TV mini-series, Sam Sheridan, creator

Nostalgia Gangster Films (Not Neo-noir, as They Belong to Another Established Genre—the Gangster Film)

Dillinger (1973), d. John Milius
The Untouchables (1987), d. Brian De Palma
Bugsy (1991), d. Warren Beatty
Hoodlum (1997), d. Bill Duke
Road to Perdition (2002), d. Sam Mendes
American Gangster (2007), d. Ridley Scott
Public Enemies (2009), d. Michael Mann

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CHAPTER 8

Hybrid Noir

Key Films

Science Fiction

Soylent Green (1973), d. Richard Fleischer

Blade Runner (1982), d. Ridley Scott

Robocop (1987), d. Paul Verhoeven

Blade Runner 2049 (2017), d. Denis Villeneuve

Comic Book/Superhero Adaptation

Batman (1989), d. Tim Burton

Batman Begins (2005), d. Christopher Nolan

Daredevil (2015–2018), Netflix series, Drew Goddard, creator

Jessica Jones (2015–2019), Netflix series, Melissa Rosenberg, creator

Horror

The Silence of the Lambs (1991), d. Jonathan Demme

The Addiction (1995), d. Abel Ferrara (Noir and Vampire Horror)

From Dusk Till Dawn (1996), d. Robert Rodriguez

Hannibal (2013–2015), TV series, Bryan Fuller, creator

Cowboy/Western Noir

The Border (1982), d. Tony Richardson*Red Rock West* (1992), d. John Dahl*No Country for Old Men* (2007), d. Joel and Ethan Coen*Hell or High Water* (2016), d. David MacKenzie

The idea of genre hybridity, as a Hollywood practice, pre-dates classic film noir. For example *The Phantom Empire* (1935), a serial, features a singing cowboy in outer space (Neale 237). For film noir and neo-noir, definition and boundaries have always been hazy, and genre hybridity further complicates the problem. Upon application of just the basic elements of noir, some films considered hybrids do not qualify as noir/neo-noir (e.g., *Psycho* or *The Manchurian Candidate*). The crucial issue is not neo-noir membership, or establishing in Mark Bould's (2013) words, "homogeneous, bounded categories" (35), but rather benefiting from the complement and intertextuality of genre hybridity. By mixing another genre with neo-noir, the resultant film engages the social context of its creation from a new, creative point of view. If the hybrid film qualifies as neo-noir, then it has to work as neo-noir, that is, engage the basic elements of noir, while simultaneously engaging the conventions of a second genre.

In making use of the post-classical as a method to clarify the era of neo-noir, genre hybridity should become a critical argument, not a label, and attaching "noir" to a preceding qualifier should be used with caution. As stated in Chap. 1, overuse of "noir" leads to meaninglessness. Neo-noir criticism needs more clear focus on genre hybridity. Works like Emily E. Auger's *Tech-Noir Film* (2011) add precision and insight into the melding of technology and neo-noir. Auger's clarification of Tech Noir highlights its noir qualities along with its science fiction, as when she states, "It is in tech-noir that the center of discourse shifts from the celebrated 'science' of science fiction to its consequences, particularly technology. And the ways it can be used, and indeed is being used for purposes that challenge just about everything: the environment, economic and social stability, and more" (21). What this chapter proposes begins with taking a step back and, instead of looking for specific hybrids, like Future Noir or Western Noir, considering the potential of neo-noir films using hybridity to further engage their socio-cultural context, as Auger did with Tech-Noir, that is, to let hybridity guide analysis. Hence, this chapter proposes a thematic group of neo-noir films, Hybrid Noir, bound by their genre mixing and fulfilling simultaneously the elements of noir and the conventions of another genre.

The two examples this chapter will deconstruct consist of the seminal *Blade Runner* (Ridley Scott 1982), which works as science fiction *and* neo-noir, and the Netflix series, *Jessica Jones* (2015–2019), created by Melissa Rosenberg, which works as comic book/superhero adaptation *and* neo-noir. As with previous chapters, the appendix includes a more extensive list, breaking the Hybrid Noir into non-neo-noir affiliations (e.g., sci-fi, horror, westerns). In establishing conventions of the non-neo-noir genre, overlap with noir becomes immediately apparent. Science fiction films, as Vivian Sobchack (1987) points out, create an “imaginatively realized world which is always removed from the world we know” (87). Sobchack adds, “The major impulse of all SF films is to pictorialize the unfamiliar, the nonexistent, the strange and totally alien” (88). For neo-noir, this idea coincides with the oneiric state element. By adding sci-fi to the mix in *Blade Runner*, we must consider the darker elements of the Los Angeles of the future. With *Jessica Jones*, a superhero adaptation, the ambivalent hero comes with a superpower to consider (along with a set of familiar problems).

This chapter proceeds, as the previous chapters, by working our way through the elements of noir. However, since this chapter concerns genre hybridity, another set of elements needs explication, which sets up a Venn diagram situation. The overlap space, it will be shown, demonstrates a certain common ground, but the spaces that do not overlap also provide guidance for understanding the unique quality of the hybrid. In this chapter, then, it becomes necessary to list the conventions of the sci-fi genre and the comic book superhero genre to find what hybridity adds to neo-noir.

Liam Burke’s (2015) definition of the comic book movie genre, though it applies all types of comic book adaptations, serves as a starting point. For Burke, the comic book/superhero genre “follows a vigilante or outsider character engaged in a form of revenge narrative, and is pitched at a heightened reality with a visual style marked by distinctly comic book imagery” (106). The definition contains many of basic elements of the superhero genre. First, the vigilante/outsider. The superhero archetype consistently achieves vigilante status by being outside the law—if in some cases just barely. Batman, for example, works with Lt./Commissioner Jim Gordon and the Avengers work with SHIELD. When the superheroes achieve anti-hero status, like Frank Castle, the Punisher, then they work even further from the law. The vigilante status becomes a matter of degree, but the outsider status can also be misleading. In their superhero guise,

yes, the superhero exists as an outsider. However, Peter Parker, Clark Kent, Barbara Gordon, and many of the holders of secret identities exist as fairly regular, if awkward, people, hardly outsiders. As outsiders, as Peter Parker remarks to Dr. Strange when they meet in *Avengers: Infinity War*, they use their “made-up names.” That is, outsider status is negotiable space. Some superheroes bypass the dual-identity aspect of being a superhero, such as Jessica Jones (or Luke Cage, the Fantastic Four, or Aquaman), which cements their outsider status and creates another set of identity issues.

Next, the vigilante/outsider engages in some form of revenge narrative. For some superheroes, the revenge narrative may be compacted so that the film can circle back to an opening, creating a sense of completeness. As Burke points out, Tim Burton’s *Batman* (1989) makes the young Joker the thug who killed Bruce Wayne’s parents (100) and in Sam Raimi’s *Spider-Man 3* (2007) Flint Marko/Sandman becomes an accomplice of the thug who killed Peter Parker’s Uncle Ben. At the other end of the revenge narrative spectrum, the revenge may arc over multiple films or episodes. This long form of revenge narrative drove Netflix’s collection of Marvel characters, Daredevil, Jessica Jones, Luke Cage, and Iron Fist, because it suited the mode of serialization (each received three 10–13-episode seasons and one crossover season of *The Defenders*). In the long-form revenge narrative, clues appear occasionally and work to motivate the hero as other aspects of their lives may distract from the revenge narrative. Generally, in serial television form, the revenge narrative becomes protracted; in feature film form it is more compact, restricted usually to the first film.

The next element of the superhero genre is much like the sci-fi convention of creating “an imaginatively realized world which is always removed from the world we know of” (Sobchack 87). In Burke’s words, the revenge narrative “is pitched at a heightened reality” (106). Within their world, the superhero has a community to protect. The classic versions consist of Superman/Metropolis and Batman/Gotham City, both thinly disguised versions of New York (where the comic books originated). The Marvel superheroes exist within what has become known as the Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU), and Jessica Jones exists in this world. *Jessica Jones* takes place in the Hell’s Kitchen neighborhood of New York (a world she shares with Daredevil and Luke Cage). Along with the physical space comes a set of characters who periodically need protection. Superman has his friends and colleagues at the *Daily Planet*. Spider-Man has his school friends and

his Aunt May. And Jessica Jones possesses a small circle of friends to protect, including her step-sister and a lawyer who helps her find jobs. Another set of Marvel characters, revolving around the X-Men, once owned by Sony/Columbia, exist in a separate world and multiple timelines, but as of 2020 Marvel/Disney has let it be known that many of the characters will be integrated into the MCU. As Deadpool quips in a bit of meta-reflexivity, “McAvoy or Stewart? These timelines can get confusing.” DC/Warner attempted a similar universe with Batman, Superman, and the Justice League characters, but met with limited success. Batman fans know that multiple worlds exist—the Tim Burton films, the Joel Schumacher films, the Christopher Nolan trilogy, the Ben Affleck appearances, and the upcoming Matt Reeves-directed version with Robert Pattinson, which may or may not connect with the DC Universe currently being promoted. For a parody of the multiple versions of Batman, see the scene in *The Lego Batman Movie* where Batman and Robin review the different versions of the Batman costume.

Another aspect of the superhero’s world, as Burke points out, is its verisimilitude—as an adaptation of a comic book superhero. Periodically, *Jessica Jones* reminds us that it is a comic book superhero world. When forced, she will lift a car or smash through a wall or leap from a three- or four-story building. Other superhero films may use comic panels in their visual designs or recreate well-known cover images. In Burke’s words, “These flourishes serve to inform the viewer that they are watching a comic book movie, not a film noir, and that it will therefore inhabit a different plane of reality” (103). More accurately, in a genre hybrid, elements of the dominant genre periodically express themselves.

A superhero needs a supervillain. The key interest in the supervillain lies with their thematic relationship to the superhero. Often, a doppelganger situation evolves, as with Batman and the Joker. As the Joker (Heath Ledger) in *The Dark Knight* explains to Batman (Christian Bale), who seems unaware of their relationship:

- Joker: I don’t want to kill you! What would I do without you? Go back to ripping off mob dealers? No, no, no! No. You ... you ... complete me.
- Batman: You’re garbage that kills for money.
- Joker: Don’t talk like one of them. You’re not! Even if you’d like to be. To them, you’re just a freak, like me!

For all that a supervillain may want to achieve, as a character they serve a purpose in helping the superhero come to an understanding of self-identity. The Green Goblin, in *Spider-Man* (2002), forces Peter Parker to accept the identity of Spider-Man. Jessica Jones' supervillain, Kilgrave (David Tennant), also plays a crucial role in forcing Jessica Jones' self-understanding.

Next, the superhero usually comes with a built-in weakness. Most famously, Superman has his Kryptonite—the one thing that can negate his superpowers. Most often, a superhero's "kryptonite" becomes a close friend or romantic interest, whom the villain may manipulate to control the superhero. Traditionally, as in patriarchal hegemony, the female love interest becomes a "prize" the superhero must win from the supervillain, as happens with Lois Lane, MJ Watson, Vicki Vale, etc. More recently, female superheroes seem not be burdened by male love interests who frequently need rescuing. Wonder Woman (Gal Gadot) has her secret island to protect and Steve Trevor (Chris Pine) becomes more of an ally and love interest rather than "kryptonite" to be used against her. Captain Marvel (Brie Larson), while she has her community to protect within the MCU, has no male love interest. What makes Jessica Jones a bit different is that she arrives with a substance abuse problem. Her alcoholism affects her superhero abilities and verges on becoming her "kryptonite."

The love interest character may exist just to provide someone for the superhero to save, but he/she also holds the potential to illustrate the superhero's self-identity or the aspirational dream. Christopher Nolan's *Batman* trilogy ends with Bruce Wayne escaping the Batman identity with Selina Kyle/Catwoman (Anne Hathaway)—having failed to save Rachel, his childhood friend, in *The Dark Knight*. Superman (Christopher Reeve) gives up his superpowers for a relationship with Lois Lane (Margot Kidder) in *Superman II* (1980). Captain America (Chris Evans) achieves his dream world with Agent Carter (Hayley Atwell) in *Avengers: Endgame* (2019) in an alternate timeline. The love interest, then, can indicate the direction or socio-political point of the oneiric state. In *Jessica Jones*, her dream wavers as possible love interests fade away.

To summarize:

The essential conventions of the superhero/comic book adaptation

1. Vigilante/outsider hero imbued with superpower
2. Community to protect
3. Revenge narrative

4. Heightened reality/world
5. Supervillain(s)
6. “Kryptonite”?
7. Love interest

JESSICA JONES

The depth and breadth of *Jessica Jones*’ neo-noir potential found a home in Marvel’s deal with Netflix. At first, *Jessica Jones* was slated to air on ABC as *AKA Jessica Jones* (Schneider 2010). It landed at Netflix as part of a project to develop four characters who would become *The Defenders*. *Jessica Jones* became the second series set in the Hell’s Kitchen neighborhood of New York, after *Daredevil*. The move to Netflix, away from network standards, changed the possibilities, and much of the “world” within which Jessica Jones could exist. Further, the 13 episodes of the first season formed an adaptation of the *Alias* series, one of the first series of the Marvel MAX imprint, offering R-rated content (Gonzales, Kindle). As Flannagan (2017) points out, being on Netflix allowed “visceral scenes of violence that aren’t to be found in the PG13/12A realm of the comic book violence seen in the cinematic releases” (epub). Hence, *Jessica Jones*, like many other neo-noirs, takes advantage of the possibilities of adult content to explore a deeper sense of a noir world, especially when compared to other Marvel characters on network television, such as *Agent Carter* and *Marvel’s Agents of SHIELD*.

Consider Borde and Chaumeton’s description of the male noir hero from 1955 and the Netflix version of Jessica Jones: “he’s often the masochistic type, his own executioner, someone hoist[ed] by his own petard, someone who gets tangled up in dangerous situations, not so much through a concern for justice or through cupidity as through a sort of morbid curiosity [...] Sometimes he’s a passive hero who is willingly taken to the frontier between lawfulness and crime” (9). Except for the gender reference, an accurate description of Jessica Jones. Jones’ ambivalence, as of the first episode of season one, amplifies her vigilante and outsider status. The opening scenes of the first episode establish Jones as a neo-noir hero *and* a vigilante/outsider: her surveillance work recalls Jake Gittes and the opening of *Chinatown* (Curly sees black and white photos of his wife *in flagrante* and grabs the blinds in Gittes’ office/Jones’ client gets angry and breaks through her office door window when Jones subdues him and the 8x10s of his wife’s cheating float down on him). In fact, Kiley

and Roman (2018) report that Executive Vice President of Marvel Television, Jeph Loeb, “revealed the decision to model Jessica after Jack Nicholson’s famous *Chinatown* (1974) character J.J. ‘Jake’ Gittes, a distinctly troubled iteration of the masculine noir detective” (Kindle). Kiley and Roman assert that a “tension” exists in *Jessica Jones* “vacillating between presenting a potentially transgressive female character and one rooted in male subjectivity and masculine expectations of the noir anti-hero” (Kindle). Though the opening scene of the first episode salutes the opening scene of *Chinatown*, Jessica, unlike Jake Gittes, joins multiple versions of Philip Marlowe by conveying ambivalence through voice-over narration. Jessica Jones: “A big part of the job is looking for the worst in people. Turns out, I excel at that. Clients hire me to find dirt, and I find it.” Philip Marlowe of *Murder, My Sweet*, 1946: “I’d been out looking under old Sunday sections for a barber named Dominick whose wife wanted him back. I forget why. The only reason I took the job is because my bank account was trying to crawl under a duck.” Philip Marlowe of *Farewell, My Lovely*, 1975: “Maybe it was the rotten cases I’d had. Mostly chasing a few missing husbands, and then chasing their wives once I’d found them—in order to get paid.” Jones even conducts business in traditional private eye office, fronted by a wood door half of which is opaque glass proclaiming, “Alias Investigations.” The signifiers build the case for Jones as a neo-noir ambivalent hero (Fig. 8.1).

The signifiers of her superhero status are doled out more slowly and judiciously. For those familiar with the *Jessica Jones* comics and graphic novels, the Netflix show picks up well into the Jessica Jones story. For those not familiar with the backstory, Jessica Jones’ superhero status becomes something like a secret to be revealed. In the first episode of season one, Jones leaps to a second-story fire escape and, later, casually lifts a man’s car a few inches off the ground so he cannot drive away. The man in the car, to whom Jones serves a subpoena, calls her “one of them.” While the degree of her “superness” may remain vague throughout the first season, her vigilante/outsider status is affirmed: she is “one of them.”

Jessica Jones, private eye, returns us to the notion that not all private eyes qualify for noir status, especially television versions. Peter Gunn and Johnny Staccato seemed like late film noir heroes, but they, like Mannix, Rockford, Remington Steele, etc., never make that noir decision to exist on the dark side of society. Jessica Jones, like Philip Marlowe, has made that noir decision, placing herself in Hell’s Kitchen and finding “dirt” on people. The visuals around Jessica Jones support that noir decision, unlike

Fig. 8.1 Jessica Jones' traditional private eye office. "AKA Ladies Night," *Jessica Jones: The Complete First Season*, S. J. Clarkson, dir., 2015



Johnny Staccato, for example, which almost achieves noir status in its early episodes, invoking a few noir elements (city streets at night, a “need” for jazz music), but they become window dressing and *Johnny Staccato* (John Cassavetes) becomes a traditional hero (a client comes to him with a job, which he solves without compromise). Jones’ outsider status is much more neo-noir than the Marvel superheroes in feature films, who exist more like alien arrivals from science fiction, which will be discussed in the next chapter, and deal with disasters that compel them to save the planet. Jessica Jones, on the other hand, works with the equally noir-tinged *Daredevil* and *Luke Cage* (Iron Fist less so), dealing with threats to their neighborhood and working with an awkward relationship with law enforcement—Jones, *Daredevil*, and *Luke Cage* by the third seasons of their individual shows become firmly established as vigilantes. The ambivalence of the noir hero complements the superhero’s vigilante/outsider status as well as the idea of protecting her community.

But Jessica Jones is also a neo-noir hero in the world of today, which aligns her with Digital Noir heroes such as Creasy in *Man on Fire*, Mills in *Taken*, John Wick, and most closely with Domino Harvey of *Domino* (2005). The Digital Noir heroes share an anxiety of not knowing their

place on the grid. Their outsider status comes from not belonging to the network in which they find themselves and, usually, searching for a network to which they can contribute, and in doing so, join. Jessica, like her Digital Noir counterparts, also wanders the grid. Jones and Domino find some solace in becoming, or attempting to become, samurai-like warriors, ideally helping those who cannot help themselves. Jones and Domino, having lost control of their identity, were assigned a place in a network from which they escape. Domino escapes a sorority trying to convert her into a stereotype, while Jones escapes her Kilgrave who forced her into femme fatale-like roles—manipulating men with her looks. As we pick up Domino's and Jones' story, they attempt to redefine themselves by breaking into hyper-masculine worlds in which they can replace the “pretty woman” signifiers (e.g., dresses, hair, makeup) forced upon them with masculine signifiers, like old jeans, boots, skills with weapons, and tough guy swagger. As they redefine themselves, they simultaneously search the grid/network for a place to fit in. Domino and Jessica Jones also pick up some non-gender-specific problems, like substance abuse and poor relationship choices. Hence, the core of Jones' neo-noir ambivalence, and Domino's, comes from the anxiety of not knowing her place in her network/world. Kiley and Roman characterize Jones with a description that also works for Domino: “In this unsanitized urban milieu, Jones is thus both the merciless male subject and the coveted female object [...], a troubled noir style anti-hero without problematizing that representation from a stronger feminine or feminist standpoint” (Kindle).

For Jessica Jones, specifically, her noir adventure ties into her revenge story, something not necessarily required of the neo-noir hero, but something to which neo-noir frequently returns. Walker's revenge desire drives *Point Blank* (1967)—his wife and best friend left him for dead during their heist. Chance (William L. Petersen) seeks revenge in *To Live and Die in L.A.* (1986) for the murder of his partner/mentor. In *The Limey* (1999), Wilson goes from England to Los Angeles to avenge his daughter's death. The revenge plot dominates the television versions of superheroes, particularly the Marvel neo-noir superheroes previously on Netflix, because of the adaptation situation—a serialized source (comic books, graphic novels) adapted to another serialized medium. The revenge plot line can arc over an entire season (or two, or three), while the hero works with a more immediate situation, which usually informs the greater revenge plot. For Jessica Jones, it involves her supervillain, Kilgrave.

Before seeing Kilgrave, we, from Jones' point of view, see a sample of his work. Parents of a missing girl arrive from Omaha and hire Jones. As in noir private eye fashion, Jones takes the case because she needs the money (as Sam Spade said in *The Maltese Falcon* [1941], "We didn't believe you, we believed your two-hundred dollars."), and she misses a bit of foreshadowing—that the cops sent the couple to her. Jones' search for the daughter begins to seem familiar and, when she presses the parents about who recommended her, she realizes (without stating it aloud) that Kilgrave has set the daughter up. Jones tells the parents to leave New York and she tries to book a flight out of the city, but her credit card is no good and she has no money. She tries to get some money from her one friend and step-sister, Trish, a popular radio talk show host, but Trish suspects the return of Jones' PTSD and that Jones obsesses on a responsibility to save the girl. Trish gives in and gives Jones money. On her way to the airport, Jones changes her mind and goes to the hotel where Kilgrave keeps the girl (repeating what he did with Jones) and finds a set of signs Jones well understands. The girl seems drugged and refuses to leave, but Jones subdues her. Back at Jones' office, she reunites the girl with her parents. As the parents and daughter get in the elevator, Jones' sees the girl has a handgun. The parents are killed and the girl escapes. Jones knows she has made a grievous error—knowing Kilgrave has sent her a message.

Kilgrave's message of the missing daughter provides a vehicle for expository information: we see some of Jones' backstory with Kilgrave reenacted. Along the way, Jones and Trish imply even darker events, that Jones is "special," that Jones suffered a psychological breakdown, for which she holds Kilgrave responsible. At the end of the first episode of the first season, revenge for the parents killed by their daughter folds into Jones' own revenge plot. And as the season unfolds, we come to understand how Kilgrave in effect created "Jessica Jones." In episode five of the first season, Jones captures Kilgrave and puts him in an isolation chamber, where she runs lab films of the experiments done on him as a child, trying to break him (Jones needs to convince her lawyer/mentor, Hogarth [Carrie-Anne Moss], of Kilgrave's guilt). Many supervillains become dopplegangers of the superhero, like the Joker and Batman or Dr. Doom and Reed Richards, and Kilgrave and Jessica Jones aspire to a similar relationship: both products of medical experimentation. Whereas Jessica Jones searches for her place on the grid, Kilgrave always knows his place and identity. He becomes a metaphorical representation of Jessica Jones' digital anxiety, amped up with his superpower of forcing other young women

into femme fatale-like roles. Kilgrave creates digital identities for those he controls; hence he creates the anxiety. Jones fights for control of her identity, whereas Kilgrave would create and control a false identity for her—anxiety of the contemporary world.

In a fashion, Kilgrave seems to have wanted to turn Jessica Jones into a femme fatale he could have manipulated to entrap men. *Jessica Jones* shares much in common with Digital Noir, specifically, the lack of a femme fatale character. Unlike the male-driven Digital Noir in which the femme fatale is ignored, *Jessica Jones* puts the character, or the possibility, into the backstory, thereby making the femme fatale trope less relevant. *Jessica Jones* sets the gender issues squarely with its noir hero, questioning her place on the grid and in the lives of the community she protects, through the trial and error process of redefinition. Jones starts at a low point (plagued by memories of Kilgrave, the loss of her family, and alcoholism), like many noir heroes, and finds the noir adventure becoming one of self-identity, more accurately redefinition.

Some of the terms above are easily relabeled with the elements of noir. Specifically, the oneiric state reflects the superhero/supervillain dynamic as well as the revenge storyline. Almost every episode of season one contains flashback scenes of Jessica Jones' backstory, and almost every episode contains Jessica Jones' voice-over narration. Eventually, she establishes a bond with Luke Cage, another superhero, and they hash out their similar dilemmas—anxiety of not knowing their place in the world. The oneiric state combines entry into Jones' inner life, through flashbacks and narration, with her aspirational dream of a positive place in her world once her revenge mission has been accomplished. The hybridity then combines the neo-noir world with a comic book world of eternal serialization, that is, this hybrid posits another dark contribution to neo-noir mosaic—the anxiety is endless and, even if one finds her place (i.e., redefines herself), the search never ends.

BLADE RUNNER

As a well- and long-established genre, the science fiction (sci-fi) film developed multiple sub-genres and multiple purposes. Taking in all the sub-categories is not possible; therefore this codifying focuses on the general elements of the sci-fi film. To begin, the most basic element is the hero, the central character who drives the story. Next, with sci-fi we understand the world portrayed to be different from the one in which we currently

live. Hence, a sci-fi film, or franchise, creates, in Sobchack's words, an "imaginatively realized world which is always removed from the world we know" (87). From Susan Sontag's precedent-setting 1965 essay, "Imagination of Disaster," in which she asserts, "Science fiction films are not about science. They are about disaster, which is one of the oldest subjects of art" (213), we draw the element of disaster. As Tellote (2001) points out, Sontag "roots" the sci-fi film "in a fundamental triad of reason, science, and technology" (19), which provides a heuristic for understanding the cultural aspects of the disaster. The next basic element of sci-fi is also a narrative feature—the mission. In one form or another, the hero of the sci-fi film becomes tasked with a mission and that mission often reveals the allusions the film may reference. The mission may propel the hero to a goal, what Sontag calls "utopian fantasy" (220). Often, the utopian fantasy is expressed through a dystopian vision. That is, we see the hero living in a dystopia, typically the world of the story's villain, dreaming of another world, even tasked with finding that world. Of the utopian fantasy, Tellote provides three themes that dominate sci-fi and will help guide our analysis: first, the "imposter" theme dominant in films about invasion and arrival of the "alien." Second, the "kiss and tell" theme in which feelings, passion, and desire override reason and science, as they do in the various versions of *Invasion of the Body Snatchers* but also in *Robocop* (1987), *Terminator* (1984), and *Blade Runner*. Third, the "don't rationalize" theme. As Tellote describes of the 1956 *Invasion of the Body Snatchers* and its ties to the horror genre, "they confront the potentially terrifying implications of that which might not be explained or even communicated" (23).

In sum:

The essential conventions of sci-fi adventure

1. Hero
2. Imaginatively realized world removed from the world we know
3. Disaster
4. Mission
5. Utopian fantasy

Blade Runner's circuitous path to production is well recounted, especially in Paul M. Sammon's *Future Noir: The Making of Blade Runner* (1996). *Blade Runner* as a genre hybrid of sci-fi and film noir is also well recounted. For Sean Redmond (2016), *Blade Runner* is "clearly marked by some of the key visual and narrative motifs of film noir" (23). For

Bukatman (1997), *Blade Runner* “borrows liberally from the private-eye genre, via the films noir of the 40s and 50s” (20). Redmond and Bukatman each go on to list visual and narrative signifiers of film noir found in *Blade Runner*, such as the alienated hero, the femme fatale, the Los Angeles setting, the voice-over narration (in the US theatrical version), and so on. Redmond goes on to point out that the “noir environment” is aided by the Vangelis score, with “saxophone blues solos that punctuate a number of the public/bar scenes” (24). I contend the critical work on *Blade Runner* remains incomplete, because the critics that do treat *Blade Runner* as neo-noir seem satisfied with identifying visual and narrative motifs, but never with finding how *Blade Runner* fulfills the purpose of neo-noir through its hybridity.

Blade Runner was released in 1982, well into the development of neo-noir. In fact, it follows significant contributions to Nostalgia Noir, specifically *Chinatown* (Roman Polanski 1974), *Farewell, My Lovely* (Dick Richards 1975), *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (Bob Rafelson 1981), and even the parody *Dead Men Don't Wear Plaid* (Carl Reiner 1982) arrived in theatres about a month before *Blade Runner*. *Blade Runner* as neo-noir manipulates genre hybridity by mixing sci-fi conventions with elements of Nostalgia Noir. That is, *Blade Runner* mixes in elements that remind us of noir, which is how Nostalgia Noirs operate. Reconsider the above quote from Redmond about music: the “saxophone blues” is a musical element that developed during the neo-noir era and was rarely heard in classic noir films. *Chinatown*, the first Nostalgia Noir to recreate the period of classic noir, featured jazzy, plaintive saxophone, and that sound came to be associated with a previous time. Richard R. Ness explained in his essay, “The Sound of Film Noir,” that “The melodic horn themes that dominate many *noir* films of the 1970s and 1980s are meant to evoke a sense of a musical past. They are intended to generate a feeling of the way audiences think *films noirs* sounded” (69). As stated in the Nostalgia Noir chapter, most classic noirs featured orchestral soundtracks, not the lonely saxophone or trumpet. This concept of memory also applies to the visual and narrative qualities of *Blade Runner*, which generates a cumulative feeling, or remixed hybrid, of the way audiences think film noir looked, and this is the realm of Nostalgia Noir—the darker discourse concerning our collective memories (Fig. 8.2).

As Hybrid Noir, *Blade Runner*'s hero, Deckard (Harrison Ford), must be considered simultaneously as an ambivalent neo-noir hero and a sci-fi hero. Typically, the sci-fi hero finds himself/herself in a “new” world,



Fig. 8.2 Sci-fi as Nostalgia Noir. *Blade Runner*, Ridley Scott, dir., 1982, Warner Bros. Home Video Blu-ray

often new to them and new to the audience. The sci-fi hero becomes an “entrée” character, someone with whom we can access the “new” world, be it dystopian or utopian. The sci-fi hero often qualifies as an “everyman/woman,” in that the average person in the audience should be able to relate to them—the hero is, on other words, just like us. Dorothy is an average Kansas farm girl that lands in the wonderful world of Oz. Scott Carey is an average suburban husband who gets covered in mysterious dust while boating and then begins to shrink in *The Incredible Shrinking Man* (1957). Or, the two astronauts in *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) appear so devoid of personality that they could be anyone. Gaff (Edward James Olmos), a police operative, arrives at the noodle stand to bring Deckard in to meet with Bryant (M. Emmet Walsh), Deckard’s former boss. Deckard, then, not only becomes our sci-fi entrée character hero but also our neo-noir hero.

As Redmond and Bukatman point out, Deckard’s costuming, his overcoat, signals his noir hero status. In the US theatrical release, Deckard’s voice-over narration also contributes to this signaling affect.¹ As a neo-noir hero, in a Nostalgia Noir, we look for the source of Deckard’s ambivalence, usually indicated by the “noir decision.” Deckard starts the story as an ex-Blade Runner, according to Bryant, the best. He excelled in “retiring” cyborgs known as “replicants.” His career, then, consisted of killing artificial people, people created by the Tyrell Corporation serving as slave labor “off world.” But, as Bukatman asserts, “*Blade Runner* refuses to explain itself” (8). So, we learn few details of Deckard’s past and

must infer based on the noir and sci-fi signifiers. Like Jake Gittes of *Chinatown* (1974), Deckard's past haunts his present. Unlike Gittes, Deckard wallows in his ambivalence. Gaff will say to him at the end, "It's too bad she won't live. But then again, who does?" Deckard is not "living" prior to his "noir decision"; he merely exists (perhaps asleep) in the city, "urbanism as a lived heterogeneity, an ambiguous environment of fluid spaces and identities" (Bukatman 12). The audience recognizes Deckard as a familiar type, like so much of the film he is *like* our memory of a noir private eye, but not quite, just as some of Vangelis' synthesizers create music that sounds like jazz saxophones, and the over-sized ceiling fans and angular light within the diffusion-filled spaces of the Tyrell Corporation *recall* classic noir settings while simultaneously recalling sci-fi settings. Deckard, then, is not living until he receives his "mission," to retire the replicants who have managed to escape from their off-world life and appear in Los Angeles. After a background briefing, which introduces us to the replicant nemeses, Deckard is sent to the Tyrell Corporation to apply the Voight-Kampff test to Rachel, Tyrell's latest prototype ("more human than human"). Rachel begins her own mission of proving her humanness to Deckard, who responds by almost raping her. Deckard makes his noir decision: to fall in love with Rachel. Similar to Gittes in *Chinatown*, in trying to keep a woman from being hurt, Deckard will end up making sure that she is hurt. Deckard, in other words, decides "to live" in the denaturalized, dehumanized, excessive, and fragmented (post-classical) world.

Deckard and Rachel pick up where Roy (Rutger Hauer) and Pris (Daryl Hannah) leave off. Deckard's final physical battle with Roy becomes one of transference—Roy transfers his will to live to Deckard. Roy leads his replicants to their maker—the Tyrell Corporation, seeking more life. Deckard fails to best Roy in the end, and Roy saves Deckard, that is, Roy makes sure Deckard lives. Roy's artificiality makes him the most human character in the film, and he passes his "vision" (in a film wherein vision is a prime motif) to Deckard so that Deckard may live something like a life.

The life Deckard imagines becomes one of two key oneiric states of *Blade Runner*. Deckard's imagined life acts as the aspirational dream that afflicts many Nostalgia Noir heroes. Jake Gittes' life for Evelyn Mulwray and her daughter in Mexico comes to disastrous conclusion to underline the meaning "Chinatown." Marlowe of *Farewell, My Lovely* aspires to a dream of success by working for rich people, only to be returned to his street-level world. Frank of *The Postman Always Rings Twice* dreams of a

new life with Cora, only to have taken away in the fatal car accident at the end. Deckard shares an aspirational dream with his fellow Nostalgia Noir heroes, but being within a Nostalgia Noir, even a hybrid mixed with sci-fi, sets up the other level of oneiric state: the film itself as a dream. As with most sci-fi, especially those set in the future, we readily accept the movie as a dream, utopian or dystopian—and as Sontag pointed out, sci-fi is about disaster (213). Disaster, then, commands our oneiric state, mixing the basics of sci-fi with the basics of neo-noir.

Since *Blade Runner* imparts nostalgia as it builds a dystopian future, the dream becomes schizophrenic. Redmond and Bukatman quote Ridley Scott on his visual concept for the design of *Blade Runner* as “set forty years hence, made in the style of forty years ago” (Redmond 23, Bukatman 19). The schizophrenia stems from its simultaneous “then” and “future” hybridity, leaving the audience in the “now.” We, the audience, exist in a space similar to Deckard: we see images from our cinematic and cultural past (a nostalgia of retro-fitted objects and spaces) set within utopian fantasy (sci-fi conventions) gone awry. Like Nostalgia Noir, *Blade Runner* wants to bury the sins of the contemporary world, in part, within a vision of the past, while portraying an end product of our collective sin. Interestingly, the real dreamers of *Blade Runner* are replicants. The film forces us to consider the artificiality of our own anxieties and aspirations by positing their source in our collective past.

The most artificial beings of *Blade Runner* have the most human dreams. Two of the characters we know to be human, J. F. Sebastian and Tyrell, dream only of work—creating artificial beings. While Roy accumulated memories (“I’ve seen things you people wouldn’t believe”), Rachel doubts her existence because she learns her memories have been created. Rachel’s femme fatale role, in that her beauty attracts the male hero and she possesses a plan of her own (like Deckard, to live), ironically works to establish her as a whole person, a nurturer. Rachel’s femme fatale comes from the Gilda type—the alluring figure who becomes good and, ultimately, the prize for the noir hero. Rachel’s allure as a femme fatale builds on the oneiric state and pushes the viewer to question the legitimacy of dreams. Rachel, like Leon, possesses photographs, which she believes legitimates her memories/dreams/humanness. Leon cherishes his dreams in the form of the photographs (and is “retired” before his dreams can be taken from him), but Rachel is forced to question her dreams. Eventually, Deckard, in escaping with Rachel, accepts—normalizes—her identity as a

replicant. In leaving, Deckard and Rachel set out to create memories of their own, as Roy intended for them.

With its 1982 release, *Blade Runner* possesses a critical moment in the mosaic of neo-noir. It arrives just after Hollywood Renaissance Noir in the 1970s and before Eighties Noir fully forms. Yet, it also comes six years after *Chinatown* and a string of Nostalgia Noirs, which established a distinct connection between neo-noir and memory, but because of its sci-fi mix it seems apart from Nostalgia Noir. As sci-fi, *Blade Runner* appears between *Star Wars Episode V: The Empire Strikes Back* (1980) and before *Star Wars VI: The Return of the Jedi* (1983). Ridley Scott came to *Blade Runner* primarily based on his success with *Alien* (1979), a hybrid of sci-fi and horror. 1980 saw the release of *Flash Gordon*. 1981 saw George Miller's *Road Warrior*, Terry Gilliam's *Time Bandits*, and John Carpenter's *Escape from New York*. 1982 also saw the release of Steven Lisberger's *Tron*, John Carpenter's remake of *The Thing*, Steven Spielberg's *E.T.*, and Nicholas Meyer's reboot of the *Star Trek* franchise, *The Wrath of Khan*. Among these sci-fi, *Blade Runner* took a unique stance: it was not aimed at children or about children (*Star Wars*, *Flash Gordon*, *Time Bandits*, *E.T.*) or the revision of childhood memories (*Star Trek*). Nor was it about the games kids like to play (*Tron*), or reviving B-movies the directors loved when they were kids (*Road Warrior*, *Escape from New York*, *The Thing*). *Blade Runner* became that rare sci-fi for adults, using genre hybridity to question the dreams of how our past, like Nostalgia Noir, can twist our dream of the future. And as the cult developed around *Blade Runner* (it was not a box office success in 1982), thinking about the film, deconstructing its meaning, and debating elements only hinted at in the film (is Deckard a replicant?) makes watching the film today an experience much like that experienced by the replicant characters in the film—legitimizing our dreams with reality.

The idea of a Hybrid Noir means the purpose of neo-noir can function in various iterations. Noir does not own the darker discourse of culture, but it certainly dwells in it. When we dream of the future, which sci-fi pushes us to do, those dreams possess revelations about the dreamers. Similarly, when we dream of ourselves in super or enhanced personifications, those embodiments also reflect the darker aspects of our dreams. Hybridity can take the noir critic out of a purely noir/neo-noir context and help graft the elements of noir onto other aspects of our culture as parlayed through film.

APPENDIX

Hybrid Noir Film List

Science-Fiction

Soylent Green (1973), d. Richard Fleischer
The Lathe of Heaven (1980), d. Fred Barzyk and David R. Loxton
Blade Runner (1982), d. Ridley Scott
Trancers (1984), d. Charles Band (sequels)
Robocop (1987), d. Paul Verhoeven (sequels, reboot)
Naked Lunch (1991), d. David Cronenberg
Equinox (1993), d. Alan Rudolph
Strange Days (1995), d. Kathryn Bigelow
Gattaca (1997), d. Andrew Niccol
Dark City (1998), d. Alex Proyas
The Matrix (1999), d. The Wachowskis
The Thirteenth Floor (1999), d. Josef Rusnak
Minority Report (2002), d. Steven Spielberg
Blade Runner 2049 (2017), d. Denis Villeneuve

Comic Book/Superhero Adaptation

Batman (1989), d. Tim Burton
Dick Tracy (1990), d. Warren Beatty
Batman Returns (1992), d. Tim Burton
The Shadow (1994), d. Russell Mulcahy
Daredevil (2003), d. Mark Steven Johnson
The Punisher (2004), d. Jonathan Hensleigh
Batman Begins (2005), d. Christopher Nolan
Constantine (2005), d. Francis Lawrence. Adaptation of *Hellblazer*
The Dark Knight (2008), d. Christopher Nolan
The Dark Knight Rises (2012), d. Christopher Nolan
Daredevil (2015–2018), Netflix series, Drew Goddard, creator
Jessica Jones (2015–2019), Netflix series, Melissa Rosenberg, creator
Luke Cage (2016–2018), Netflix series, Cheo Hodari Coker, creator
The Punisher (2017–2019), Netflix series, Steve Lightfoot, creator

A note on Batman: From the character's beginning, in *Detective Comics* #27 (1939), Batman evoked imagery and narrative motifs that would find

their way into film noir. Since the 1970s reiteration of Batman, in comic book form, he has very much been a neo-noir hero, relying on noir storylines and noir-influenced art. The movies, beginning with Tim Burton's *Batman* in 1989, similarly invoked noir with varying degrees of hybridity, ranging between Burton's more comic characters and world come to life and Christopher Nolan's comic book characters living in our world. The three Nolan Batman films make this list, but so to would multiple animated versions, both feature and TV series.

Parody of this group appears occasionally, such as the Spider-Man Noir character in *Spider-Man: Into the Spider-Verse* (2018).

Horror

The Silence of the Lambs (1991), d. Jonathan Demme

The Addiction (1995), d. Abel Ferrara (Noir and Vampire Horror)

From Dusk Till Dawn (1996), d. Robert Rodriguez

Hannibal (2001), d. Ridley Scott

Red Dragon (2002), d. Brett Ratner

Hannibal (2013–2015), TV series, Bryan Fuller, creator

A note on Horror-Noir hybridity: many questions here. Often, horror films may evoke some noir imagery—maybe just being in black and white—and we readily call it Horror Noir. Case in point: Alfred Hitchcock's *Psycho* (1960). *Psycho* contains virtually none of the essential noir elements, yet some (Schwartz 2005) claim it as noir. When Horror and Noir work as Hybrid Noir, the resultant film works as noir *and* as horror. Do the *Saw* films work as noir because they feature a detective? More accurately, these films may borrow elements of noir without becoming noir—fully succeeding as horror, but not as neo-noir.

Cowboy/Western Noir

The Killer Inside of Me (1976), d. Burt Kennedy

Red Rock West (1992), d. John Dahl

Blue Desert (1992), d. Bradley Battersby

The Border (1982), d. Tony Richardson

Bright Angel (1991), d. Michael Fields

Clay Pigeons (1998), d. David Dobkin

No Country for Old Men (2007), d. Ethan and Joel Coen

Hell or High Water (2016), d. David MacKenzie

NOTE

1. As Sammon, Merchant, and Redmond point out, Harrison Ford did not want to do the voice-over narration. In my opinion, this helps the narration—you can hear the anger in Ford's voice, which completely fits Deckard's ambivalence.

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CHAPTER 9

Remake and Homage Noir

Key Films

Remake Noir

Farewell, My Lovely (1975), d. Dick Richards. Remake of *Murder, My Sweet* (1944) and *The Falcon Takes Over* (1942). Also Nostalgia Noir
Against All Odds (1984), d. Taylor Hackford. Remake of *Out of the Past* (1947)

No Way Out (1987), d. Roger Donaldson. Remake of *The Big Clock* (1948)

Underneath (1995), d. Steven Soderbergh. Remake of *Criss-Cross* (1949), based on same novel

Mildred Pierce (2011), d. Todd Haynes (HBO miniseries)

Homage Noir

Blow Out (1981), d. Brian De Palma

Body Heat (1981), d. Lawrence Kasdan

Pulp Fiction (1994), d. Quentin Tarantino

The Last Seduction (1994), d. John Dahl

True Detective (2014–2019), HBO series, Nic Pizzolatto, creator

Fargo (2014–2017), FX series, Noah Hawley, creator

The Killers (Don Siegel 1964), one of the first neo-noirs, represents a second adaptation of Ernest Hemingway's short story of the same name, the first being the classic noir *The Killers* (Robert Siodmak 1946). In adapting the same source, the 1964 version begs comparison with the 1946 version. From the beginning, then, neo-noir has been a conversation with previous noir, a variation on classic noir's conversation with an amalgam of previous film types (e.g., crime, hard-boiled detective, French Poetic Cinema, German Expressionism). Add to this the notion that film noir developed as a critical concept among French critics in the 1950s (later elaborated by American film critics in the 1970s), and not as a mode of the Hollywood system (i.e., traditional genre), and as a consequence, classic noir and neo-noir developed with a self-reflexiveness much more pronounced than in traditional genres. And now that neo-noir is about 60 years old, its sense of itself has become sophisticated, multi-faceted, and, perhaps, cannibalistic. When neo-noir turns its intertextuality on itself, either through remake or homage, the films share a common thematic intent: the noir-literate, or in Robert Stam's words, those with "spectatorial competence," recognize the meta-conversation and manipulation of characters, themes, and motifs in the service of a contemporary neo-noir film-viewing experience (211). Remakes and homage bring intertextuality to the foreground, and while all of neo-noir is in some form intertextual, Remake Noir and Homage Noir embrace the notion and rely upon it, finding unity in the post-classical Hollywood cinema's excessiveness and fragmentation in the act of meta-conversation.

This may tip into the postmodern, especially the concept of pastiche, but as post-classical criticism, the borrowings from outside of noir (e.g., muscle cars for the 1960s, pop music from the 60s and 70s, and actors from 60s and 70s TV shows in Quentin Tarantino films) are less interesting than borrowings from noir (e.g., Lawrence Tierney, fragmented narratives, femme fatales in Quentin Tarantino films), and how filmmakers rework the elements of noir, and in some cases specific stories, to reflect the undercurrents of their contemporary world. Verevis (2006) reviews the taxonomies of remakes proposed by Druxman (1975), Greenberg (1991), and Leitch (1990) and points out Druxman's range of remake works on a spectrum of three categories: (1) the disguised remake in which a "property" is "either updated with minimal change, *or*, retitled and then disguised by new settings and original characters (e.g., *Colorado Territory* [1949] a disguised western version *High Sierra* [1941])"; (2) the direct remake, in which a "property may undergo some alterations [...], but the

new film and its narrative image do not hide the fact that it is based upon an earlier production (e.g., multiple versions of *The Great Gatsby*"); and (3) the *non*-remake, wherein "a new film goes under the same title as a familiar property but there is an entirely new plot (e.g., Don Siegel's 1964 version of *The Killers*)" (Verevis 7). Greenberg's terminology is very similar to Druxman, but Leitch suggests adding the labels "Homage," which "situates themselves as secondary texts whose value depends on their relation to the primary texts they gloss" (144). For example, *Body Heat* (Lawrence Kasdan 1981) and *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (Bob Rafelson 1981). A range exists between Remake and Homage. At one end, a classic definition of remake, undisguised, acknowledged, and, in Leitch's words, "true." At the other end, a film's remake qualities are no longer clear and may take a disguised or unacknowledged form of Homage. The term that works for a post-classical intertextuality is "remix." Remake and Homage Noir remix noir elements to reflect the intent of the contemporary filmmaker. "Remixed media," according to Lawrence Lessig, take a range of "texts," or "quotes," and combine them to produce "the new creative work—the 'remix'" (69). Eduardo Navas (2012), speaking of music remix, further explains a remix can be reflexive, allegorizing and extending "the aesthetic of [the] sampling, where the remixed version challenges the 'spectral aura' of the original and claims autonomy even when it carries the name of the original; material is added or deleted, but the original tracks are largely left intact to be recognizable" (66). Siegel's 1964 version of *The Killers* remixes Hemingway's short story more than it remakes Robert Siodmak's 1946 version, just as *The Underneath* (Steven Soderbergh 1995) remixes Don Tracy's *Criss-Cross* novel more than it remakes the 1949 *Criss-Cross* (Robert Siodmak). Whether the remixed film establishes autonomy becomes the central feature of its intertextual meta-conversation. The producers of Remake Noir and Homage Noir may "sample" the transmediated mythos of noir and create a film remix: a transformation of neo-noir that acknowledges previous iterations while aspiring to its own autonomy. Remix, as a theoretical concern, reaffirms the post-classical consideration of neo-noir as an ongoing (never ending?) negotiation, or intertextual (re)referencing, of neo-noir as a discourse of the darker aspects of culture and of our relationship to neo-noir film.

This chapter relies on two films and an HBO series as discussion samples. The three works together demonstrate the range of remixing between remake and homage. First, *Farewell, My Lovely* (Dick Richards 1975), the third filmed version, after *The Falcon Takes Over* (1942) and *Murder, My*

Sweet (1944), of Raymond Chandler's novel, *Farewell, My Lovely* (1940). Richards' *Farewell* is an acknowledged/undisguised/true remake. Most remakes of Hollywood noirs are also revisions of novel adaptations. In the middle of the range lies *Body Heat*, one of the first Homage Noirs and almost a remake of *Double Indemnity* (1944). Verevis sees it as a remake of *Double Indemnity* (13), and Foster Hirsch labels it "a remake in a general sense" (19), while others see it as homage (Stam 211, Neale 235, Naremore 211). While *Body Heat* relies on nostalgia, it does so in a much different fashion than *Farewell, My Lovely*. *Body Heat* is set in the present, but constantly reminds the viewer of the past. At the other end of the spectrum, seeming extremely modern in that it is not a feature film, but the first season of the HBO series, *True Detective*. As Homage Noir, *True Detective* evokes noir tropes, and at 7-plus hours in length (eight 55 minutes episodes) the narrative features complex nonlinear construction. While critics (Maslin, Canby, Ebert) identify *Body Heat*'s direct linkage to *Double Indemnity*, *True Detective*'s intertextuality connects to classic noir in an abstract sense, making more allusions to neo-noir as its heroes track down a killer who leaves symbols to be decoded, just as the Tooth Fairy did in *Manhunter* (1985) or John Doe in *Se7en* (1995). Placing *True Detective* at one end, where the allusion seems the most abstract, emphasizes the viewer's relationship to neo-noir—while some realize *True Detective*'s qualification as neo-noir, some may not realize its sense of homage. The elements of noir provide a vehicle to deconstruct the various conversations, or degrees of intertextuality, between the remake and homage films and their precursors.

The ambivalence of Robert Mitchum's Philip Marlowe in *Farewell, My Lovely* is announced in his voice-over narration in the first post-credits shot. Marlowe starts with, "This past spring was the first that I felt tired and realized that I was growing old." While fidelity to Chandler's novel may seem to be going on, seeing Mitchum as Marlowe compromises that issue (Chandler's Marlowe is 30-something; Mitchum was 57 when he made *Farewell*). Also, seeing Mitchum, fully loaded with the associations the noir-literate would make to his classic noir era films ("Baby, I don't care"), seems to emphasize nostalgic ambivalence (and this film qualifies as Nostalgia Noir), but *Farewell*'s primary intent lies in remixing the past, which begins by remixing notions of the archetypal private eye, Philip Marlowe. *Farewell* opens with voice-over narration, similar to Edward Dmytryk's 1946 version, *Murder, My Sweet*. Not the same narration, but the same style. Dmytryk (1995), in the episode "Film Noir" of the

American Cinema series, explained the purpose of the narration: “[W]e wanted to get the flavor of Chandler. Chandler writes differently than any other writer ever wrote. He has ... his own style.” Oddly, Dmytryk goes on to cite lines from *Murder* that do not appear in Chandler’s work. Perhaps, the “flavor” of Chandler comes from adapting Chandler’s use of first-person narrative, with many clever metaphors, to a plot device that sets up a reason for Marlowe to be talking. In *Murder* and *Farewell*, Marlowe explains himself to the cops. *Farewell*’s remix consists of the “flavor of Chandler” to accommodate Mitchum’s age, world-weariness, and angsty ambivalence, along with sampling a few direct quotes (“She had a full set of curves which nobody had been able to improve on”). Through voice-over Marlowe controls the narrative in that he tells the story to the film’s audience, unlike Bogart’s Marlowe in *The Big Sleep* (1946) or Jake Gittes in *Chinatown* (1974), who we follow through the story. Mitchum’s Marlowe remixes the classic private eye combining many classic noir signifiers (e.g., hat, raincoat, office with a glass pane door announcing his agency, and venetian blinds), with new elements. In *Murder*, Marlowe ends up with a “prize,” Helen Grayle’s younger sister, Ann (they ride off together in a car, kissing, at the end), but in *Farewell*, Marlowe ends up with an extra \$2000 he did not expect to have and he takes it to Tommy’s widow and mother of the mixed-race child, adding a weary atonement and sensitivity to Marlowe, one not seen in the Forties versions of Marlowe, nor in Altman’s revision in *The Long Goodbye* (1973). *Farewell* remixes Marlowe as a 1970s era in-over-his-head good guy—he takes on corruption and helps out the innocent, and while the world may not be right at the end, at least he tried. This Marlowe stands less in the Altman camp, not quite as dark as Jake Gittes, and more in line with Steve McQueen in *Bullitt* (1968) or *The Getaway* (1972), or Robert Redford in *Three Days of the Condor* (1975). The darkness of his noir world, Los Angeles 1941 as seen from 1975, makes Marlowe into a tarnished knight (Fig. 9.1).

Whereas Marlowe controls the narrative in *Farewell*, *My Lovely*, Ned Racine (William Hurt) of *Body Heat* lacks any form of control. Lawrence Kasdan, *Body Heat*’s writer and director, remixes the other type of noir hero, the one who succumbs to the femme fatale. Marlowe remixed the private eye/police detective archetype; Racine remixes the archetype of the man who gives into his sexual anxieties and is duped by the femme fatale—the 1981 brother of Walter Neff in *Double Indemnity*, Al Roberts in *Detour* (1945), Christopher Cross in *Scarlett Street* (1945), Frank Chambers in *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (1946), and the Swede in



Fig. 9.1 Robert Mitchum as Philip Marlowe. *Farewell, My Lovely*, Dick Richards, dir., 1975, Shout Factory Blu-ray

The Killers. By considering Racine as a remix, and comparing him to his precedents, Kasdan's strategy of stripping away any male superiority becomes immediately clear. Neff (Fred MacMurray), in *Double Indemnity*, takes control by dictating his ultimate redemption to his insurance company colleague, Keyes (Edward G. Robinson), and even the Swede takes control by allowing the hitmen to catch him, but in *Body Heat*, Racine's blindness to his sexual anxieties never allows him any control. "What else do you like?" Racine asks Matty (Kathleen Turner), "Lazy, ugly, horny? I got 'em all." What control he may achieve exists because Matty set it up. Once in jail at the end of the film, his debauched lifestyle denied, Racine figures out what happened. Like the heroes in other genres at this pivotal point between the 1970s and what would become the 1980s, he fails to achieve control. By 1981, the comedy genre in particular established the loveable losers as heroes of adventure and vengeance in films like *National Lampoon's Animal House* (1978), *Caddyshack* (1980), and *The Blues Brothers* (1980). Simultaneously, the adventure drama reaffirmed male identity as expressed through professionalism and violence in films like *Raiders of the Lost Ark* (1980) (Kasdan was one of the screenwriters), *Thief* (1981), and the films of Clint Eastwood and Burt Reynolds. Kasdan wrote screenplays in the 1970s that paid homage to other genres, such as *The*

Bodyguard (screenplay 1975), a romance intended for Steve McQueen and Diana Ross (Hunter 1992), and *Continental Divide* (Screenplay 1977), a romantic comedy (Arnold 1981), before being hired by George Lucas to write homage films, the *Star Wars* films, and *Raiders*. As Homage Noir, Kasdan remixes *Body Heat* to create a neo-noir hero whose best attribute may be “lovable loser.” Where the comedy hero-loser achieves a grand, if pointless, gesture of defiance, Kasdan’s noir hero is beyond redemption, unable to see the trap around him, and unable to stop himself from inevitable destruction; 1981 not only allows for sexual explicitness, but it also allows Kasdan to push at the boundaries of ambivalence for the noir hero and to source the ambivalence in the character’s lack of intelligence. Did a 30-something Mitchum, Fred MacMurray, Edmond O’Brien, or Robert Ryan ever play a hero as dumb as Racine? Racine’s “losing” though becomes a combination of his ineptitude and cunning plans of the femme fatale, Matty. Kasdan establishes a noir hero and then mixes in a new depth of incompetent male identity as it existed in 1981.

The two heroes of the first season of *True Detective* (hereafter, just *True Detective*), Rust Cohle (Matthew McConaughey) and Marty Hart (Woody Harrelson), control the narrative through the familiar device of the police interrogation that becomes the voice-over narration. Being an eight-episode season, the complexity of the narrative they control expands beyond previous neo-noir possibilities. Unlike *Farewell, My Lovely* and *Body Heat*, *True Detective* invokes neo-noir to serve its modernity. That is, *True Detective* evokes the elements of noir but never seems “old fashioned.” As with the two heroes: Marty’s ambivalence seems “classic,” in that he bears the traits of the oft-used noir hero, the weary, jaded-by-experience cop or private eye. In the 2012 timeline, no longer a cop, Marty does security and private investigation work—a path shared with Philip Marlowe and Jake Gittes of *Chinatown*. In the 1995 timeline, when Marty is a cop, we learn Marty bends the rules of investigation, cheats on his wife, and struggles with his strange, new partner. Marty’s ambivalence stems from having been in the gutter for so long. Rust, on the other hand, seems very much like a neo-noir hero, obsessive and emphatic, like Will Graham in *Manhunter* (1986) and *Hannibal* (2013–2015) or Harry Caul in *The Conversation* (1974). Rust becomes a mystery to Marty and the audience. From the 1995 timeline, we come to learn that Rust had been married and that he and his wife had a daughter who died. The daughter’s death ended the marriage and Rust threw himself into his police work, developing a reputation as an eccentric but also a successful analyst. In the

2012 timeline, Rust appears to be a washed-up alcoholic. Something happened in the 1995 timeline that turned Rust in the 2012 version. Rust, like neo-noir, brings an inner ambivalence, wherein he seems to want to work out the issues that brought him to the current moment—with little regard for anything else. The ambivalence of the *True Detective* heroes lies squarely in their dreams of the past and present. At a previous point they cared about the world they lived in, but something—the mystery of the narrative—altered that dream. Whereas, *Farewell, My Lovely* and *Body Heat* set up a conversation between a contemporary representation and our memory of a noir hero, *True Detective* offers a self-contained dialectic of noir: one hero who dreams in the classic noir vein vs. one who dreams in a neo-noir vein.

The oneiric qualities *Remake Noir* and *Homage Noir* explore often work at multiple simultaneous levels. Within the film, as with *Farewell, My Lovely* and *True Detective*, the noir heroes relate their stories to the police interrogators and by extension to the audience. As Borde and Chaumeton contend in *Panorama of American Film Noir* (1955), “confusion is at the very heart of the oneiric quality specific to [film noir]. A number of titles could readily be found in which the action is deliberately situated at the level of the dream” (11). *Farewell* and *True Detective* establish the confusion upfront, taking us in to the “dream” of their about-to-be-revealed narrative. Marlowe says, “Well, it’s the middle of July now and things are worse than they were in the spring. In the spring, I wasn’t holed up a dingy hotel ducking the police.” In *True Detective*, the establishment of the two timelines creates a compelling narrative confusion. First, a woman has been murdered in what seems to be a ritualistic killing, leaving behind abstract visual clues that need to be “decoded.” Second, in the modern timeline, we learn that the two heroes are no longer with the police force. Rust, in particular, looks dramatically different. In the 1995 timeline, he appears neat and overly organized, but in the 2012 timeline, he looks shaggy and seems to have become a shameless alcoholic. Something happened in the interim, a confusion we expect to be clarified. The narration puts us in the minds of the heroes, into their oneiric state and confusion—enhanced at the end of episode one when Rust tells the two cops to “start asking the right fucking questions” (Fig. 9.2).

At one level, then, as with Marlowe and the *True Detective* heroes, we work through the confusions of their minds. For the noir-literate, the device creates expectations of achieving clarity (e.g., the narrator should explain things to us and, hopefully, do it in a clever fashion). Within the



Fig. 9.2 Rust and the police interrogation. “The Long Bright Dark,” *True Detective: The Complete First Season*, Cary Joji Fukunaga, dir., HBO Home Entertainment Blu-ray

narrative conveyed to us through the heroes, we come across another layer of oniricism—the aspirations of the characters, or in the words of Sam Spade at the end of *The Maltese Falcon* (1941), “The stuff dreams are made of.” Marlowe achieves clarity through the revelation of Helen Grayle’s femme fatale dream (she eliminated those men who could reveal her secret identity). Racine finally figures out Matty’s femme fatale dream, which, unlike most (all?) classic noir tales of femme fatales, she achieves. *True Detective* weaves a complex of dreams. Episodes one through six rely on the police interrogation device, and by episode six a gap develops between the events portrayed and the story told by Rust, Marty, and Marty’s wife, Maggie (Michelle Monaghan). The interrogating cops ask about the end of Marty’s and Maggie’s marriage, and while we see Maggie striking back at Marty by having sex with Rust, the three characters tell the cops a different story. We still see the events through their eyes, but we also become implicated in their lies. While the long form allows for complexity, *True Detective* circles back to the current moment at the end of Act II, and Act III—the events leading to the conclusions (episodes seven and eight) are presented in linear time, a narrative structure also followed by *Farewell, My Lovely*. In *True Detective*,

Rust and Marty abandon the police interrogation and work together in 2012 to track down the serial killer. In *Farewell*, the same thing happens when Marlowe stops narrating, which convinces Lt. Nulty to help Marlowe get to the gambling boat where the Moose Malloy and Helen Grayle storylines will come together. The long-form mini-series allows the aspirational dreams of the characters to develop into intertwined existential dark contemplation of family: Marty's work to find lost daughters parallels the emotional loss of his wife and daughters and Rust's dream of the daughter he lost when she was infant). Marty and Rust reach a state in which no one believes them—that their case remains unsolved—and the cops who interrogated them make a solid case for why Rust may be the killer. Solving the case brings their dream to fruition: they find the serial killer, who wounds both Marty and Rust, and they are resurrected in slightly improved forms. Marty's family comes to the hospital to see him and, more spiritually, Rust explains his near-death vision of seeing his infant daughter.

The very nature of Remake Noir and Homage Noir creates another level of oneiricism: the film itself is a dream of neo-noir. *Farewell, My Lovely*'s nostalgic dream recreates *Murder, My Sweet*; an older, weary Philip Marlowe; and a dreamy vision of Los Angeles in 1941. *Body Heat* works as a dream of the noir past in the contemporary world fixated on the 1940s, with big band concerts, Florida mansions of the early twentieth century, and cigarette smoking, along with bars, hotels, diners, and offices that seem to have persisted from the 1940s. And *True Detective*'s episodic nature constructs a dream state as we penetrate the lives of the heroes to a degree not typically seen (e.g., Marty's deteriorating relationship with his wife, explicit and fetishistic sex scenes, metaphorical imagery), through which we, the post-classical audience, work our way to clarity. In other words, we decode fragmented and excessive content as our part in the relationship with neo-noir in the post-classical Hollywood cinema (Fig. 9.3).

In dreaming a vision of neo-noir, Remake Noir and Homage Noir de-emphasize the violence that often dominates classic noir and many neo-noir movements. The three samples of this chapter seem rather pedestrian in their violent content compared to other movements and a few films within this cluster. I define pedestrian violent content as material commonly seen in all types of mainstream films, such as fighting and people being shot by guns—for good or bad, common occurrences in Hollywood films. Interestingly, as violent content decreases, explicit sexual content



Fig. 9.3 *Body Heat* dreams of the noir past. *Body Heat*, Lawrence Kasdan, dir., 1981, Warner Bros. Home Video Blu-ray

increases, as all three samples include nudity and sex scenes. The films that do contain violent content, for example Quentin Tarantino's *Reservoir Dogs* (1992) and *Pulp Fiction* (1994), exploit the anticipation of the violence. In *Reservoir Dogs*, Mr. Blonde (Michael Madsen) torments the captured policeman and cuts his ear off with a razor. The build-up to the violent act increases the queasiness, and then when the ear is cut off, the camera pans away from the act. In *Pulp Fiction*, Vincent (John Travolta), resting a large handgun on the back of the front seat, accidentally shoots Marvin, their passenger, in the head. At the moment of the gun's firing, Tarantino cuts to an exterior shot of the car as blood sprays on the back window. We then return to inside the car with Jules and Vincent splattered in blood. Again, Tarantino opts out of the explicit depiction for a different viewer experience. As Tarantino explained upon *Pulp Fiction*'s release in 1994, "I like movies that mix things up.... like the OD sequence ... Oh my God, this is so fucking intense, all right; at the same time, it's also funny. Half the audience is tittering, the other half is diving under the seat" (Smith 34). The violence in Homage Noir rarely rises to explicitness (as it is in *Chinatown* or *Renaissance Noir* or *Eighties Noir*). The dreams of Remake Noir and Homage Noir evoke a violence

that plays into our memory of the action in previous noir, and, on occasion, our expectations of violence may be used in unexpected ways.

Since more explicit sexual content exists in the three samples (and many other Remake Noirs and Homage Noirs), the violence becomes sexualized. Marlowe ends up in a house of prostitution and drugs run by Amthor, a lesbian (a change from the original novel and *Murder, My Sweet*). She slaps Marlowe and Marlowe slaps her back. Later, Amthor flies into a rage when she finds one of her favorite prostitutes in bed with one of the male thugs (an early role for Sylvester Stallone). Marlowe watches as Amthor throws around the naked young woman until the thug finds a gun and shoots Amthor. *Body Heat* features a few rough sex scenes, including one in which we think Matty is in pain, only to find out the opposite. *True Detective* features explicit sex scenes which involve fetishism (Marty's girlfriend puts him in handcuffs). *Pulp Fiction* features a homosexual rape scene, which becomes the cause of Butch (Bruce Willis) returning to the torture room to save his former enemy, Marsellus Wallace (Ving Rhames). Violence becomes sexualized, and sexual situations become explicit—something impossible to see in classic noir. So, while *Farewell* remakes a classic noir, its quotient of sex and violence reminds the audience that it is *not* a classic noir. And the sex and nudity of *Body Heat* certainly adds to the sexual tension but also reminds the audience that this is not the past, but an homage to the past. In *True Detective*, explicit sex and violence brings its contemporariness to the forefront, putting before us elements we once trusted the Hollywood film to put out of frame or to imply. Again, *True Detective* implicates the audience's voyeurism as a part of the meta-conversation about the types of film to which it pays homage.

Each sample also represents a particular visual style motivated by its particular neo-noir purpose. *Farewell*, as a remake, concerns recreation and nostalgia. It recreates a common visual sense of the private eye film noir (it's in widescreen and color, so it opted out of faithful recreation). In other words, *Farewell* remakes what we thought, dreamed, film noir looked like (and sounded like, as we also get the lonely saxophone style of music). The visual style represents an end product of intertextual conversation: distilling the traditional visual tropes (venetian blinds, angular shadows, trench coats and hats, dingy hotel rooms, Robert Mitchum, etc.) in a modern form (widescreen, color, sexual explicitness) and modern revisionism (adding ethnic and racial identities only hinted at in *Murder* but explicit in Chandler's novel) into a nostalgic dream of our filmic past. With *Body Heat*, however, the visual style distills a number of film noir

visual tropes into the contemporary world. Whereas *Farewell* portrays nostalgic material in a modern film, *Body Heat* portrays a modern film evoking nostalgic material. But *True Detective*'s visual style abandons nostalgic iconography (the episodes rarely evoke any sense of the "old fashioned") to refocus on the neo-noir dream as complex of points of view. *True Detective* takes that basic film noir narrative of the cop/private eye narrating the events and works that into a multi-layered, complex web, and the visual style keeps the viewer focused on the conflicting viewpoints. *True Detective* evokes a rural south Louisiana, endlessly flat and featuring many ghost buildings (empty strip malls, dilapidated schools and churches, remnants of a military structure from the 1800s), bringing new territory to the neo-noir landscape. As homage, *True Detective* evokes neo-noir, like Eighties Noir and Digital Noir that adapted their unique visual styles to contemporary neo-noir storytelling, thereby burying its connection to classic noir within deeper levels of referencing.

True Detective's first episode establishes its visual pallet: it bypasses the vivid colors of *Farewell* and *Body Heat* (nostalgic dreams) for a more monochromatic, neutral scale of color (mostly a gray/beige scale accented with gray-tinged blues and browns). While the detectives frequent a few noir locations (bars, shabby store fronts, police stations), they rarely recall any nostalgia. Also, its rural Louisiana location connects it to other neo-noir set in rural spaces, like *No Country for Old Men* (2007) and *Red Rock West* (1992). As in neo-noir outside the Homage movement, *True Detective* connects its heroes to their surroundings, which consistently emphasizes an emptiness of people. For example, in the first episode, Marty and Rust visit the morgue (not an uncommon scene in noir and crime fiction), but when they walk out of the morgue, we see its location in an empty shopping center—Marty's car is the only vehicle in acres of parking, boarded-up stores, and endless flatness. Rust lives in an almost-empty apartment and Marty lives in suburban rambler identical to the other houses on his block. In the 2012 timeline, Marty ends up in an apartment as empty as Rust's 1995 apartment. The dead body that calls them on their noir adventure (in the 1995 timeline) is left under a large tree in a large field of sugar cane associated with no one's place or ownership. *True Detective* pays homage to neo-noir by setting familiar narrative events into its own visual style, in which emptiness slowly becomes filled with understanding (i.e., the visual style helps guide the viewer to clarity).

Since *True Detective* alludes to neo-noir, it also bears a similar trait of bypassing the femme fatale character. Rust and Marty deal with the darker

aspects of their sexual anxieties, but not at the hands of a femme fatale. Conversely, *Farewell, My Lovely* and *Body Heat*, being in direct conversation with classic noir, bring the femme fatale to the foreground—as if the nostalgic dream would not work without her. Again, *Farewell* acts as an old-fashioned movie made in modern context, which means the femme fatale, Helen Grayle (Charlotte Rampling), becomes a familiar character in a modern recreation. *Body Heat*, being a contemporary film with a sense of nostalgia, puts the familiar character into a contemporary R-rated movie: we're not going to cut away during the sex scenes, luring the viewer, just as Racine is lured.

Helen Grayle, like *Farewell*, fulfills a film noir dream in a contemporary movie. She lures Marlowe into her plot (or web), which we find out involved her luring other men to their doom. That is what the classic femme fatale did in film noir, and in the end the male hero manages to escape her clutches and either reform the femme fatale or see to it that she dies. In *Farewell*, as in *Murder, My Sweet*, Mrs. Grayle is killed. In *Farewell*, Marlowe shoots her in self-defense. In *Murder*, Mrs. Grayle and Moose Malloy shoot each other simultaneously. *Farewell* evokes the femme fatale, so that Marlowe can become the heroic savior (he vanquishes the evil Mrs. Grayle and gives her money to Tommy's widow and her mixed-race child). When Marlowe meets Mrs. Grayle for the first time, it instigates multiple levels of referencing. After the butler lets Marlowe into the mansion, he looks up and sees Mrs. Grayle at the top of a stairway, much as Neff first saw Phyllis in *Double Indemnity*. After she walks down the stairs, Marlowe follows her to room where they will meet with her husband. Marlowe's voice over reminds us of the familiar situation and that he knows it is a familiar situation (Mrs. Grayle's femme fatale powers already undercut). Marlowe tells us, paraphrasing Chandler, "She was giving me the kind of look I could feel in my hip pocket." *Farewell* reduces the femme fatale to the simple role of "bad guy." Marlowe achieves clarity without succumbing to her wiles and eliminates her. In other words, the femme fatale of *Farewell, My Lovely* plays right into our uncomplicated dream of film noir. The memory of the femme fatale, as depicted in *Farewell*, reaffirms our nostalgic dream without threatening it.

Matty Walker (Kathleen Turner), of *Body Heat*, evokes our memory of the femme fatale *and* threatens our dream of film noir. *Body Heat*, again, is a modern movie remixing old-fashioned noir tropes with contemporary possibilities. Ideas of how noirs proceed and what functions the characters fulfill are systematically worked out by Kasdan. While Racine acts as the

familiar male hero, he is uncharacteristically inept. Matty, like the traditional femme fatale, lures Racine into her plot/web using her sexuality (more accurately, using Racine's lack of awareness against him). As with *Farewell*, with the exception of the sex scenes, Matty's femme fatale clicks off the elements that the femme fatale brings to the narrative. She redirects the male hero's motivation (their affair becomes a murder and escape plan) and seems to control the story. In classic noir, she rarely controls the story to the end. As stated, the femme fatale typically ends up either reformed (e.g., Gilda or Elizabeth in *The Bribe*) or dead (Cora in *The Postman Always Rings Twice* and Kathie in *Out of the Past*). What makes Matty unique in the world of noir is she gets away with her plan, and that notion turns the homage in an unexpected direction: the powerful woman can overcome male hegemony. Unlike her precedents, Matty achieves her goals and personifies male sexual anxiety. Kasdan uses the familiar character, and the expectations that go along with the femme fatale, to take the story to its twist ending. And like the best of neo-noir, uses our sense of a film's intertextuality—its dream of homage to film noir—to remind us of the darker possibilities of our memory of noir. We, like Ned Racine, get manipulated by the plot of the femme fatale—something truly new to consider in neo-noir. Matty becomes a key figure in neo-noir—the femme fatale who not only lives at the end but also achieves her goal. Later, Catherine (Sharon Stone) in *Basic Instinct* (1992) and Bridget (Linda Fiorentino) of *The Last Seduction* (1994) offer variations on Matty, with the tension of the narratives aided by the fact that Matty achieved her desire in *Body Heat* and that could happen again. In almost 60 years of neo-noir, very few femme fatales achieve their goal. Perhaps, the femme fatale ends victoriously in the Erotic Thriller Noir, but not so in the mainstream offerings. Matty disrupted an ingrained set of expectations in noir: the femme fatale's evil plot is always vanquished. Catherine of *Basic Instinct* (1992) and Bridget in *The Last Seduction* continue that conversation. These femme fatales, who achieve their goals, as Lindop (2015) explains

are a projection of deeply paranoid fears about the potential potency of female power. Overwhelmingly, these dark ladies are supremely intelligent, educated, self-inventive, and active. They push conformist boundaries, get away with their crimes, and outmanoeuvre their adversaries every step of the way. Perfectly at home in the corporate realm and other typically male dominated spaces, they kill for thrills, reject conventional relationships and boast

complete mastery over their victims, using them for sex. As well as a device to aid their schemes. (57)

The dark discourse of neo-noir bears many possibilities—and the fact that few neo-noir movements deal with the femme fatale as a complex character (Nostalgia Noir evokes the character to return to classic binary of redemption or death) demonstrates the continuing fear of the powerful woman.

The samples offer three remixes of the femme fatale. One, as seen in *Farewell, My Lovely*, remakes the femme fatale into a nemesis, actuating all the familiar signifiers (e.g., her 1940s look, the elderly husband) but also relying on the redemption or death binary outcome. This femme fatale ultimately reaffirms the male hero. He may be temporarily misled, but he re-asserts dominance by vanquishing the femme fatale—and any threat to male sexual anxiety. Two, *Body Heat* recreates the femme fatale with a contemporary notion of success. Again, the femme fatale, Matty, evokes all the prominent signifiers of her character, but she defies the binary outcome of redemption or death, humiliates male sexual anxiety *and* gets the money (as does Bridget in *The Last Seduction*). The third remix, as seen in *True Detective*, forms a negative option: the femme fatale gets edited out of the homage in favor of more simplistic representations of women that reaffirm male hegemony (e.g., Marty must redeem himself for how he behaves with the women in his personal life and with the women his profession puts him contact. The femme fatale becomes a ghost presence—noted for her absence and indicating a move away from male sexual anxiety as a primary concern of a neo-noir movement.

Neo-noir, by definition, remixes the classical notions of film noir. In the post-classical Hollywood cinema, 60 years in the making, this notion grew fragmented and excessive—as is the wont of post-classical cinema. Among the fragments exists a group of films that bring their direct connections to film noir and neo-noir to the foreground. Remakes being the most obvious in their intent foreground the intertextuality—engaging the noir-literate viewer into a conversation of comparison between an earlier adaptation of the original and a more contemporary adaptation of the same source. If any common theme runs among the remakes it is the infusion of the more daring material that had once been prohibited. *Farewell, My Lovely*, along with *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (1981), *Against All Odds* (1984) that is a remake of *Out of the Past*

(1947), *Kiss of Death* (1994), and *Mildred Pierce* (2011), make sexual content explicit. In other words, we get to see content forbidden during the classic Hollywood era. Whether this leads to superior versions of the original material remains debatable. Pro: *Farewell, My Lovely*, *The Postman Always Rings Twice*, and *Mildred Pierce*, for example, incorporate explicitness to explore dark sexual themes. Con: *The Big Sleep* (1978) and *I, the Jury* (1982) verge on exploitation in their use of nudity or sexual content.

Homage Noir provides another angle on the conversation. With Homage Noir, the contemporary filmmakers evoke elements of the past with a contemporary neo-noir (a new film referencing older films). In keeping with the purpose of neo-noir, as expressed by Borde and Chaumeton: “[Film Noir] responds to a certain kind of emotional resonance as singular in time as it is in space” (5). Homage Noir filmmakers resurrect elements of noir to reflect the moment of their creation. They find these classic elements may be useful in a modern setting. Kasdan set up a sophisticated homage with *Body Heat*, playing with and against our expectations of noir. Tarantino similarly combined a wide array of noir elements, including a femme fatale, within a modern independent film in *Pulp Fiction*, and, like Kasdan, played with and against our expectations. Homage Noir also extends its self-reflexive nature to neo-noirs that pay homage in a more “disguised” fashion, as *True Detective* exemplifies. Referencing previous neo-noir becomes more subtle, because the emphasis is on using homage to push ahead other elements, like narrative complexity and deeper dive into the effects of the noir adventure on the noir hero.

Remake Noir and Homage Noir seem less concerned with defining noir and more focused on the recreation of the past with classic noir or neo-noir elements or creating a modern film with noir elements. We recognize the familiar elements which lead us into a new conversation about neo-noir. Of the remake we begin with comparison and juxtaposition. What can the new version do that the previous could not? What is the new version’s relationship to the source material? What prism does the contemporary world provide through which the filmmakers recreate the past? Of homage we ask how the filmmakers remix noir/neo-noir elements in the contemporary film. To what films does the new film pay homage? Is it a contemporary remix or is it intended as homage? Or, is it a remix in which the homage may be more disguised or subtle? How does the new film establish its autonomy? How do new forms of media consumption adjust/

adapt to noir conventions? Remake Noir and Homage Noir evidence the intertextual relationship of the remix of the past into the present and all the dark concerns that come with it.

APPENDIX

Remake Noir and Homage Noir Film List

Note: Most remakes remade a classic noir, but some remake foreign films, themselves homage to classic noir (e.g., Godard's *Breathless* [1960]).

Remake Noir (Title of Original the Same Unless Noted)

Cool Breeze (1972), d. Barry Pollack. Remake of *Asphalt Jungle* (1950)

Double Indemnity (1973), d. Jack Smight (TV movie)

Thieves Like Us (1974), d. Robert Altman. Remake of *They Live by Night* (1948)

Farewell, My Lovely (1975), d. Dick Richards (Raymond Chandler adaptation) Remake of *Murder, My Sweet* (1946) and *The Falcon Takes Over* (1942). Also Nostalgia Noir

The Big Sleep (1978), d. Michael Winner

Body and Soul (1981), d. George Bowers

The Postman Always Rings Twice (1981), d. Bob Rafelson (James M. Cain adaptation) Also Nostalgia Noir

I, the Jury (1982), d. Richard T. Heffron. Mickey Spillane novel adaptation

Breathless (1983), d. Jim McBride

Against All Odds (1984), d. Taylor Hackford. Remake of *Out of the Past* (1947)

No Way Out (1987), d. Roger Donaldson. Remake of *The Big Clock* (1948)

Dead of Winter (1987), d. Arthur Penn. Remake of *My Name is Julia Ross* (1945)

D.O.A. (1988), d. Rocky Morton and Annabel Jankel

Desperate Hours (1990), d. Michael Cimino

Narrow Margin (1990), d. Peter Hyams

A Kiss Before Dying (1991), d. James Dearden

Night and the City (1992), d. Irwin Winkler

Detour (1992), d. Wade Williams

Guncrazy (1993), d. Tamra Davis. Remake of *Gun Crazy* (1950)

Point of No Return (1993), d. John Badham. Remake of Luc Besson's *La Femme Nikita* (1990)

The Getaway (1994), d. Roger Donaldson (Jim Thompson novel adaptation)
Underneath (1995), d. Steven Soderbergh. Remake of *Criss-Cross* (1949), based on same novel
Kiss of Death (1995), d. Barbet Schroeder
The Deep End (2001), d. David Siegel and Scott McGehee. Remake of Max Ophuls' *The Reckless Moment* (1949)
Original Sin (2001), d. Michael Cristofer. Remake of Francois Truffaut's *Mississippi Mermaid* (1969)
The Good Thief (2002), d. Neil Jordan. Remake of Jean-Pierre Melville's *Bob le flambeur* (1955)
Unfaithful (2002), d. Adrian Lyne. Remake of Claude Chabrol's *The Unfaithful Wife* (1969)
Beyond a Reasonable Doubt (2009), d. Peter Hyams
The Killer Inside Me (2010), d. Michael Winterbottom
Mildred Pierce (2011), d. Todd Haynes (HBO miniseries)

Homage Noir

Blow Out (1981), d. Brian De Palma
Body Heat (1981), d. Lawrence Kasdan
Dead Again (1982), d. Kenneth Branagh
Dead Men Don't Wear Plaid (1982), d. Carl Reiner. Homage-Parody
Blood Simple (1984), d. Joel Coen
Black Widow (1987), d. Bob Rafelson
Johnny Handsome (1989), d. Walter Hill
Kill Me Again (1989), d. John Dahl
Revenge (1990), d. Tony Scott
Twin Peaks (1990–1991), TV series, Mark Frost and David Lynch, creators
Reservoir Dogs (1992), d. Quentin Tarantino
True Romance (1993), d. Tony Scott (original screenplay by Quentin Tarantino)
Pulp Fiction (1994), d. Quentin Tarantino
Red Rock West (1993), d. John Dahl
The Last Seduction (1994), d. John Dahl
The Big Lebowski 1998), d. Joel and Ethan Coen
Go (1999), d. Doug Liman
The Man Who Wasn't There (2001), d. Joel and Ethan Coen. Also Nostalgia Noir
Brick (2005), d. Rian Johnson

- True Detective*, season one (2014), HBO series, Nic Pizzolatto, creator (multiple seasons)
- Fargo*, season one (2014), FX series, Noah Hawley, creator (multiple seasons)
- Twin Peaks/Twin Peaks: The Return* (2017), Showtime TV series, Mark Frost and David Lynch, creators (Lynch directed all episodes)

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CHAPTER 10

Conclusion

As neo-noir approaches 60 years of existence, the time has come to consider not only what makes a film “noir” but also what makes it “neo.” In the introduction, we started with the contention of the misuse of the term “neo-noir” to the point of meaninglessness. “Noir” lost meaning because critics lost sight of the purpose of noir. Whether classic noir or neo-noir, a film gains noir status, as Borde and Chaumeton pointed out in *Panorama of American Film Noir* (1955), when it “responds to a certain kind of emotional resonance as singular in time as it is in space” (5). The task for the noir critic, then, becomes isolating the response and articulating *a specific sense of malaise* (13). To achieve that end meant relying on elements indicated by Borde and Chaumeton. In particular, we gleaned not a definition of film noir, but a set of elements contained in noir films. The elements consisted of (1) response to a singular time or space, (2) ambivalent hero, (3) oneiric/dream state, (4) violence theme, (5) visual style, and (6) femme fatale. The elements served to guide a discussion of the excessive and fragmented body of films that constitute neo-noir in the post-classical Hollywood cinema. From a macro point of view, neo-noir consists of movements of films clustered together by a time consideration or thematic commonality. This book is by no means the first to form neo-noir films into specific movements. Much of this has already begun. Katherine Farrimond’s *The Contemporary Femme Fatale: Gender, Genre and American Cinema* (2018), for example, clusters neo-noir films focused on the femme fatale into groups like “Glamorous Ghosts” (femme fatales

who end the film as “good girls” and dispense with the femme fatale imagery) and “Corpses” (femme fatales who haunt from the past). Linda Williams’ *The Erotic Thriller in Contemporary Cinema* (2005) lays out a neo-noir movement and sub-divides erotic thrillers as noir into categories such as Porn Noir and Direct-to-Video Erotic Thrillers. Nina K. Martin worked in similar territory with *Sexy Thrills: Undressing the Erotic Thriller* (2007). Emily E. Auger articulated another thematic movement with *Tech-noir Film: A Theory of the Development of Popular Genres* (2011). However, few critics focused on the larger concept of neo-noir and how movements, like Erotic Noir and Tech Noir, fit in.

Less work in clustering films into movements as a response to a singular time exists, and this book attempted to begin filling that void. Transitional Noir juxtaposed late classic noir to first efforts of neo-noir in the 1960s. Hollywood Renaissance Noir demonstrated how new filmmakers combined personal vision with either revising the noir or recreating noir. Eighties Noir formed around the idea of not being safe no matter how the culture reassures you. Nineties Noir focused on the anxiety of identity to reflect its time. Digital Noir, since the 2000s, formed a new movement around the anxiety of being lost on the technology grid. The key concept of movements bound by time came from Paul Schrader. In his essay “Notes on Film Noir (1972)” and elsewhere, Schrader contends that classic film noir was a “historical movement” and that as such film noir ended. From this notion we take the idea that the time-bound movements possess beginnings and endings. As times change, so does neo-noir’s response. Schrader, consequently, sees neo-noir as a “mirage” of classic noir, and in a fashion that metaphor guided this book.

Neo-noir as mirage, I believe, forms the central concept of the purpose of neo-noir. In articulating a response to a singular time or space, in participating in a discourse of the darker aspects of the culture, a neo-noir establishes itself as noir and differentiates itself from the crime film, the gangster film, or the private eye film. Borde and Chaumeton pointed out, “The vocation of film noir has been to create *a specific sense of malaise*” (13). A different “malaise” afflicted the post-World War II generation than afflicted the 1960s or the 1990s or the 2000s. The mirage of neo-noir lies in its ability to generate a movement of films that respond to cultural malaise. It need not be the same malaise of the classic noir era; it need only be a malaise of the time or space. The work of the noir critic should not be finding the iconography of classic noir in contemporary films, but finding contemporary films that achieve *neo-noir* status—what

malaise they may confront, how the hero's ambivalence reflects that malaise, what dream state they evoke, how the violence and visual style articulate the malaise, and how the presence or absence of the femme fatale shades the response. What makes the films "neo," then, becomes their ability to effectively create a mirage of classic film noir: the films operate in a fashion similar to classic noir, doing for the current moment what classic noir did for its moment.

Consider also how the modes of production influenced the ebb and flow of movements. Repeatedly, we found groups of filmmakers re-enacting variations on the filmmakers of classic film noir. Groups of directors coalescing, if momentarily, to make similar films in similar modes of production. For example, the directors of Transitional Noir working in television as a variation of the B-movie, or Hollywood Renaissance directors revising and recreating noir in their mutual explorations of genres, or contemporary directors relying on narrative and visual metaphors of networks of technology surrounding our existence. Not only do the films form a mirage of classic noir, but often we see another mirage of directors working much as the classic film noir directors worked.

Some neo-noir films try to make the mirage as convincing as possible, as do the films labelled Nostalgia Noir. The illusion comes as recreation of the times. In 1975, Robert Mitchum, a star of many classic film noirs, could appear as Philip Marlowe in *Farewell, My Lovely*. Not only does Mitchum evoke memories of the classic era, but *Farewell* also benefitted from being the first major Philip Marlowe adaptation after Robert Altman's revisionist Marlowe in *The Long Goodbye* and a return to form. For some viewers, the Mitchum version of Marlowe seemed more faithful to a classic noir depiction. But, in truth, it offered a dream/mirage of what we collectively imagined classic noir to be. *Farewell* manipulated a visual style in widescreen and color that recalled the 1944 version, *Murder, My Sweet*. *Farewell* also relied on the lonely trumpet on the soundtrack—a sound style rarely heard in classic noir, but by 1975 it had become thoroughly associated with the classic style. While *Farewell* evoked many classic noir tropes, it also included content to remind the viewer that it was *not* of the classic era—a depiction of race and ethnicity not evident in the classic era, along with sexual content and language beyond the pale of the Code. *Farewell*, like *Chinatown* (1974) and *L.A. Confidential* (1997), may offer a very convincing mirage, but as Schrader made clear, the classic noir era ended, and these films are only a mirage and, therefore, *neo-noir*.

The oneiricism of neo-noir encourages the necessity of further research into neo-noir. Just as the western “dreams” of an American past or the musical “dreams” in an abstract form of inner expression, the neo-noir film “dreams” of the ills of the culture in which it was produced. James Naremore (2008) explains Borde and Chaumeton’s notion of oneirism: “For Borde and Chaumeton, the essence of noirness lies in the feeling of discontinuity, and intermingling of social realism and oneiricism, and an anarcho-leftist critique of bourgeois ideology, and an eroticized treatment of violence. Above all, noir produces a psychological and moral disorientation” (22). Again, the neo-noir audience must seek a new feeling of discontinuity and oneiricism and articulate how the noir resonates with a new, specific time, which elevates the importance of the post-classical perspective. Much like neo-noir, the post-classical is a mirage of its classical predecessor. The post-classical audience experiences its own sense of discontinuity because of its background, or more accurately, its training. The post-classical audience arrives at adulthood with a level of experience decoding visual information the classical audience member could never fathom. The post-classical audience is trained in fragmented narratives, excessive visual style, and multiple forms of “movie.” Each member, though, brings a different level of awareness of what has come before. If we narrow it down to neo-noir, again an audience member may have a great knowledge of film noir and neo-noir, the noir-literate, or they may have very little. The noir-literate decodes from a different point of view than one unfamiliar. The noir-literate recognizes, for example, the neo-noir operation in a film like Tony Scott’s *Man on Fire* (2004)—the ambivalent hero, drifting into Mexico, suckered into a scheme, and the final “suicide” mission, because of their awareness of films such as *Ride a Pink Horse* (1947), *Out of the Past* (1947), *Border Incident* (1949), or *Bring Me the Head of Alfredo Garcia* (1974). This mirage of noir then requires the viewer to decode the excessive and fragmented visual style with which it was made. As demanding, maybe off-putting, as the film may be, the successful post-classical film becomes appealing to the contemporary viewer because it engages their sophisticated level of training. Finding the neo-noir dream within the modern film becomes a part of the attraction. The audience takes pleasure in discovery and in discovering participates in a new dream.

As mirage, neo-noir creates a new dream, one rooted in the complicated—excessive and fragmented—film-viewing experience of the post-classical Hollywood cinema. Understanding film noir, as a general concept,

becomes, for the literate viewer, a means by which to decode the neo-noir film. For the uninitiated, the attractive neo-noir may lure the viewer, like the best mirage, to a new experience (in an ideal world: guide the new viewer to learn more about neo-noir and film noir). The sense of discontinuity within a neo-noir may provoke the viewer to set things right, that is, examine the dark discourse on culture within the film, rationalize its content and style, and accept or reject its themes. As post-classical cinema, the viewer may sense they did not “get it” the first time, something furthered by excessiveness and fragmentation, and since repeated screenings are encouraged by the availability of multiple viewing experiences, additional viewings often yield new information (e.g., the eye/seeing motif in *Chinatown*, the varying levels of dreams in *Blade Runner*, recognizing Vincent in the opening scene of *Pulp Fiction*, understanding the flashforwards in *Man on Fire*, how the multiple timelines in the first season of *True Detective* connect to each other, and so on). Or, something in a neo-noir sparks an interest in the viewer and another viewing of the film ensues. Discontinuity is neo-noir territory: because responding to a singular time or space manipulates our expectations and leaves us unbalanced, we then work to bring the neo-noir into balance. And in so doing, realize the mirage that is the neo-noir film.

Balancing the new with the old is not only the neo-noir experience but also the experience of post-classical Hollywood cinema. Neo-noir operates as a metaphor of post-classical Hollywood cinema. Neo-noir, like the post-classical, broke from the bonds of its classical establishment and created new and varied forms. Some forms lasted longer than others, some multiplied, and some incorporated previous tropes, but all forms engaged in the intertextual discourse. What was built was an ever-developing movement breeding excessiveness and fragmentation and in so doing leaving some viewers behind as it picked up new initiates who recognized the response in these films to their time or space. In *The Classical Hollywood Cinema: Film Style & Mode of Production to 1960* (1985), Bordwell, Staiger, and Thompson suggested, “It is now pertinent to consider to what extent the Hollywood mode of production and the classical style have changed” (608). While Bordwell (2006) and Thompson (1999) denied the post-classical (in favor of a persisting classical mode), they found balance in the new and the old. In a sense, Bordwell and Thompson see the “noir” in neo-noir. Other critics, such as Peter Kramer, found post-classicism focusing on the “increased speed and intensity of stylistic change” (81). In Catherine Constable’s (2015) words, “The post-classical film displays its

characteristic fragmentation through textual strategies, particularly inter-textual references and generic hybridity... [and the] open-ended text does sustain the construction of multiple readings, suggesting the possibility of more complex modes of spectatorship" (25). The benefit of post-classical Hollywood cinema as a concept resides in its emphasis on organizing, deciphering, and intertextuality leading to an understanding of Hollywood cinema since the 1960s. As with neo-noir, it begins with seeing the period as a mosaic and not as one or two major movements.

Seeing neo-noir as a mosaic—smaller pieces fitting together to form a larger work—clarifies neo-noir. As the mosaic comes together to form an image, or a pattern, or a design, neo-noir also coalesces, which becomes an image with many faces. The critics who established the classic mode, such as Borde and Chaumeton (1955), Schrader (1996), and Place and Peterson (1976), established that noir was about the tone and mood of a response to a singular time and place. That would become its purpose: noir acts as a discourse into the darker aspects of the culture in which the films were produced, heroes would give in to their more dangerous desires, and stories would concern the spiral downward. And whereas the mosaic of classic film noir established its image with only few pieces, neo-noir, once released from the bounds of the classic, would add its own pieces to the image, an image continually in flux, continually expanding, continually excessive, and continually fragmented. As the culture and modes of production change, neo-noir exerts, perhaps frustratingly, an ability to change with the times, so as to continue to serve its purpose.

The noir critic adds resolution to the overall image/mirage of the neo-noir mosaic. The work concerning the film movements brought together by theme needs to continue. I offered a few in this book and cited others previously articulated, but so many more need attention, and neo-noir as a concept needs more argument. More genres do not need to be modified by adding "noir"; rather what makes a film "noir" needs emphasis. The theme that ties the films together, which is always important, but so too is the concept of noir. What makes the film a neo-noir should get more attention. The term loses meaning when it can be attached to anything. In Bould's words, what qualifies as neo-noir became "fuzzier," and the mosaic image loses resolution, prompting the question, can one "talk about any film as noir if it is illuminating to do so, regardless of what one might consider its dominant generic tendency?" (92). The basic question, then, should be, "What makes this film neo-noir?"

I see many possibilities and questions in need of answers. For example, a movement of neo-noir focused on Cawelti's transformative category of burlesque/parody. A comedy/parody movement of neo-noir could include such film and television as:

The Black Bird (1975), d. David Giler. Hammett/Sam Spade parody
Grosse Pointe Blank (1997), d. George Armitage
The Big Lebowski (1998), d. Joel Coen. Detective/Chandler parody
Dead Men Don't Wear Plaid (1982), d. Carl Reiner. Parody mashup
Blondes Have More Guns (1995), d. George Merriweather
Archer: Vice season five (2014), animated, neo-noir/Eighties Noir
Archer: Dreamland season eight (2017), animated, Nostalgia Noir

An African American Noir could be distilled from two larger movements of Blaxploitation (the 1970s and 1990s) and African American cinema. Are all Blaxploitation crime films neo-noir? What unique factors does the African American cinema bring to neo-noir? Similarly, we could seek an Asian American Noir. Or a neo-noir movement grounded in films written and directed by women.

In this book, to keep the scale of the endeavor within reason, I limited the consideration to Hollywood cinema. If we were to remove that limitation, a flood of additional movements pours in, both chronological and thematic. How various cinematic cultures adapt the purpose of noir continues to be of importance. Spicer's anthology, *European Film Noir* (2007); Bould's *Film Noir: From Berlin to Sin City* (2005); Naremore's chapter "The Other Side of the Street" on neo-noir in Asia, Latin America, and Africa in *More Than Night: Film Noir in Its Context* (2008); and multiple works on French New Wave cinema and Hong Kong pre-unification crime cinema have already set this idea in motion.

As for movements bound together by time periods, what I provided here is, again, only a sampling. Much more work needs to be done. By focusing on Hollywood cinema, I have de-emphasized independent cinemas operating in America since the 1960s. Directors coming from outside of Hollywood and American culture ebb and flow with film history, and I believe a neo-noir movement lies within (Does John Woo's *Face/Off* [1997] connect to John Boorman's *Point Blank* [1967]?). Neo-noir in the twenty-first century deserves more detail than I have been able to give it. Further, how writers and directors enter and exit the Hollywood system may guide the establishment of new periods of neo-noir.

The excessiveness and fragmentation of neo-noir as post-classical Hollywood cinema is a major part of its attraction. Sifting through the possibilities will never be complete, nor will the articulation of specific movements ever reach an end. The intertextual discussion will only grow more complex, more detailed, and more interesting.

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